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1. Gains and Losses: Assessing the Trajectories of the War on Iran

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More than a month into the US-Israeli war on Iran, official narratives of victory contrast sharply with the ambiguity of outcomes on the ground and the absence of a clear end-state. The 2 April address by US President Donald Trump, delivered on the 33rd day of the war, largely reiterated prior statements without offering strategic clarity. Intended in part to stabilise financial and energy markets, the speech instead prompted negative reactions, reflecting scepticism about both the trajectory of the conflict and Washington's ability to bring it to a decisive close. In his address, Trump sought, belatedly, to justify the war while projecting an image of success. He denied that regime change in Iran was an objective, even as he claimed that core strategic goals had been achieved, particularly the degradation of Iran's nuclear programme, conventional military capabilities and defence industries. At the same time, he signalled that military operations would continue for several more weeks and threatened escalation, including expanded targeting of Iran's energy infrastructure, should Tehran refuse U.S. terms in ongoing but largely stagnant negotiations. A similar effort to construct a narrative of victory emerged in Israel. Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, who had framed the conflict as existential, declared that Iran no longer posed such a threat—an assertion that implicitly contradicted earlier justifications for the war. These parallel claims of success invite closer scrutiny of what the principal actors—the United States, Israel and Iran—have actually achieved, and what they have failed to accomplish. Militarily, the US-Israeli campaign has produced tangible results. Conducted almost entirely as an air war, it has relied on intensive bombardment using aircraft, guided missiles and drones, while avoiding ground engagement. Thousands of targets across Iran have been struck, including military bases, missile platforms, industrial sites and research facilities. Senior Iranian leadership figures—among them top political, military, and security officials—have been assassinated, and significant damage has been inflicted on air defence systems, enabling substantial, though not uncontested, control of Iranian airspace. Critical infrastructure has also been targeted. Elements of Iran's nuclear programme, such as the heavy water facility in Arak, appear to have suffered severe damage, although the status of other key nuclear sites remains uncertain. Strikes extended beyond strictly military objectives to include steel plants, petrochemical facilities and other civilian industries, as well as universities and research centres accused of dual-use functions. Iran's naval capabilities in the Gulf and Arabian Sea have been largely neutralised, with remaining assets limited to small, fast-attack craft. The war has also expanded beyond Iran's borders. In Lebanon, Israeli operations against Hezbollah have included targeted assassinations, widespread destruction in southern areas and the southern suburbs of Beirut, and limited ground incursions. In Iraq, US and Israeli strikes have targeted militia positions and leadership figures linked to Iran, though without the same scale of devastation seen elsewhere. Despite these achievements, key strategic objectives have not been realised. Regime change—widely understood to be a key US and Israeli aim—has failed. The elimination of senior leaders has not destabilised the system; rather, it has produced a new cadre of officials who appear more ideologically committed and, in some cases, more hardline. Efforts to mobilise internal opposition or armed groups in border regions have also fallen short, reflecting intelligence miscalculations regarding the strength and cohesion of anti-regime forces. Equally significant has been the failure to contain Iran's response. Iranian missile capabilities, underestimated by US and

Israeli planners, have continued to operate with little apparent degradation. Tehran has also demonstrated an ability to expand the scope of the conflict, targeting neighbouring states and leveraging regional allies. Hezbollah has maintained both operational capacity and a substantial missile arsenal, defying Israeli expectations following earlier confrontations. Meanwhile, Iraqi militias aligned with Iran have contributed to a broader deterrent posture, threatening US interests and regional adversaries alike. For its part, Iran has achieved a measure of political resilience. Despite sustained attacks and leadership losses, the system has preserved its internal coherence and governance structures. It has effectively employed asymmetric tools, including missile strikes and the selective disruption of maritime traffic in the Strait of Hormuz. The latter, in particular, has had global economic repercussions, increasing pressure on all parties while simultaneously complicating US relations with its allies. At the same time, Iran's shortcomings have been considerable. Air defence systems have failed to prevent repeated violations of national airspace, exposing critical vulnerabilities. Intelligence and security breaches have enabled high-level assassinations and revealed extensive foreign infiltration of Iranian institutions. Moreover, attempts to deter attacks on its own infrastructure by threatening regional states have not succeeded; instead, they may have deepened tensions between Iran and its neighbours without constraining US or Israeli actions. Against this backdrop, the prospects for ending the war remain uncertain. Washington appears increasingly aware of the difficulty of achieving regime change and has shifted toward seeking a comprehensive agreement addressing nuclear capabilities, missile programmes and regional alliances. Iran, however, interprets its endurance as leverage, adopting a more rigid negotiating position that includes demands for full sanctions relief, guarantees against future attacks and recognition of its regional role. The window for a negotiated settlement is narrow. Failure to reach agreement risks further escalation, potentially including intensified strikes on civilian infrastructure or even limited ground operations. Yet domestic considerations in the United States—rising energy costs, public opinion pressures, and the approach of midterm elections—may incentivise a declaration of ceasefire, even in the absence of a durable political resolution. Such an outcome would not resolve the underlying conflict. At best, it would mark a temporary pause in a longer confrontation, leaving open the possibility of renewed hostilities in a different form. Moreover, even if a ceasefire were reached on the Iranian front, the parallel conflict in Lebanon is likely to continue, complicating any broader de-escalation and ensuring that the regional dimensions of the crisis remain unresolved. *This is a summary of a policy brief originally written in Arabic available [here](https://www.aljazeera.net/en/analyses/escalation-without-exit-strategic-disorientation-and-potential-scenarios-us%E2%80%93israeli-war).

2. Escalation Without Exit: Strategic Disorientation and Potential Scenarios in the US–Israeli War on Iran

URL: <http://studies.aljazeera.net/en/analyses/escalation-without-exit-strategic-disorientation-and-potential-scenarios-us%E2%80%93israeli-war>

More than a month since the launch of the full-scale offensive by the US–Israeli coalition against the Islamic Republic of Iran, the trajectory of the conflict has become opaquer than ever before. Despite this pervasive uncertainty, it can be asserted with a reasonable degree of analytical confidence that the repercussions of this confrontation have already triggered structural shifts in both the regional and global order. Consequently, a reversion to the pre-war status quo appears increasingly improbable. In these circumstances, the principal analytical task is to map the potential pathways

ahead and to delineate the most plausible scenarios that could define the future evolution of the conflict and its wider strategic ramifications. Prior to engaging in any substantive analysis, it is essential to recognise that part of the ambiguity surrounding the war's outcome can be attributed to a form of strategic disorientation on the part of the United States. This condition can be interpreted through the theoretical lens of Carl von Clausewitz, who posited that war is nothing but the continuation of politics by other means. Accordingly, war is not an autonomous end, but rather an instrument subordinated to political objectives; thus, any assessment of military instruments devoid of their political end-state lacks analytical coherence. Within this framework, any military engagement that is not anchored in a clearly defined and attainable political objective—even if it achieves tactical or operational successes on the battlefield—is, at the strategic level, destined for failure. In the absence of a precise and transparent articulation of both strategic and operational objectives, confusion within the White House has become increasingly evident. Beyond this, it can be argued that the United States initiated its current military campaign with a degree of haste. Contradictory statements by US officials, strikes targeting Iranian civilian infrastructure, and internal political frictions collectively serve as indicators of this incoherence. In the weeks leading up to the offensive, the deployment of US military assets within the US Central Command (CENTCOM) area of responsibility was conducted with considerable planning and precision, advancing simultaneously along both defensive and offensive axes. On the offensive front, this included the forward deployment of US Air Force assets—comprising fighter aircraft, aerial refuelling platforms, airborne early warning and control systems (AEW&C), airborne command posts, and signals intelligence (SIGINT) collection platforms—to regional bases, particularly in Saudi Arabia and Jordan, alongside the dispatch of carrier strike groups USS Abraham Lincoln (CSG-3) and USS Gerald R. Ford (CSG-12). On the defensive front, the United States sought to mitigate its vulnerabilities by evacuating well-known military installations in countries neighbouring Iran and reinforcing its layered ground-based air defense architecture. Nevertheless, the persistence of war into the second month has compelled the Pentagon to deploy additional logistics and manpower. The request for a \$200 billion supplemental budget from Congress, coupled with the rapid deployment of 10,000 elite personnel—including airborne units and US Marines—after a month of sustained large-scale air operations, suggests that initial planning assumptions have not been fully realised. Reports have even emerged regarding the potential deployment of the USS George H.W. Bush carrier strike group to the Middle East. The Pentagon's apparent urgency in initiating the war on 28 February 2026 can be analysed within the context of exploiting a unique operational window of opportunity. The convening of a high-level defence council meeting in Tehran provided a rare and time-sensitive target set. This was followed by extensive airstrikes against the meeting venue within the compound containing the Office of the Supreme Leader of Iran. These strikes not only resulted in the deaths of several senior Iranian commanders but, through a simultaneous attack on the residence of Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, also led to his assassination along with several members of his family. Despite Tehran once again incurring significant human losses due to the repetition of prior security lapses—previously observed during the 12-day conflict and the targeted killing of senior commanders in the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps' Aerospace Force during a meeting—the strategic objectives of the US–Israeli coalition were not fully achieved. At least within segments of the Pentagon, there had been an expectation that the rapid elimination of senior leadership figures—particularly Ayatollah Khamenei—would precipitate the collapse of Iran's politico-military structure. It was also assumed that Iran's military response would remain limited and controlled, as in previous instances. The US President's call for Iran's "unconditional surrender" during the first

week of the war reflected precisely such initial assessments. Subsequently, efforts by Israel's intelligence agency, Mossad, to foment social unrest also failed to yield the desired outcomes. According to longstanding traditions, Iranians mark the last Wednesday of the year—just days before Nowruz—through gatherings known as “Chaharshanbe Suri”, involving bonfires, fireworks and large public gatherings. From the perspective of Israeli security planners, this social context presented a potential opportunity to incite violence and transform public gatherings into street unrest. In this vein, during a specific time window, a portion of Israeli drone strikes focused on targeting security checkpoints to facilitate conditions conducive to internal destabilisation. This poorly conceived plan ultimately failed to achieve its intended objectives. By the third week of the conflict, as optimistic projections regarding a rapid conclusion lost credibility, and as the shock induced by disruptions to maritime traffic through the Strait of Hormuz imposed additional strain on the global economy, the United States adopted a new approach—supplementing the shock doctrine—in conducting the war, an approach that has persisted to date. This framework, which may be conceptualised as “de-escalation through escalation”, has emerged as a defining factor in shaping the prospective trajectory of the conflict from the American perspective, and it is within this paradigm that future scenarios must be assessed. On March 18, the Israeli Air Force conducted a strike against facilities in Asaluyeh. The attack, which targeted pipeline infrastructure associated with the South Pars gas field, occurred at approximately 14:10 local time. Although the United States officially denied prior knowledge of the operation and described it as unacceptable, the incident can nonetheless be assessed as a critical inflection point—arguably a point of no return—in the evolution of the war. The objective of targeting this critical infrastructure was to convey an explicit message from the US–Israeli coalition to the Islamic Republic of Iran—one that extended beyond purely military aims and effectively constituted an overt threat of initiating a broader infrastructure war against Iran. While Washington appeared to expect that Tehran might adopt a cautious stance or even move toward de-escalation under such pressure, a decisive response was delivered within hours. In this context, Iranian armed forces carried out a series of calibrated strikes against the Saudi Aramco Total Refining and Petrochemical Company (SATORP) and Jubail regions in Saudi Arabia, the Al-Hasn gas field in the United Arab Emirates, and, most notably, the Ras Laffan industrial zone in Qatar. These attacks resulted in an estimated disruption of at least 17 percent of Qatar's liquefied natural gas (LNG) export capacity for an indeterminate period. This response demonstrated Tehran's determination to sustain the conflict. Consequently, in contrast to earlier periods—when the effects of Iranian actions, whether strikes on regional military bases or even the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, were largely assessed as short-term—this confrontation now carries the potential for long-term, multi-year consequences for both sides. This reality necessitates serious attention from Western policymakers and military officials, particularly among US allies. Accordingly, any analysis of future scenarios and projections of the war's outcome must simultaneously account for two fundamental variables. The first is the degree of commitment by the United States and Israel to continue the process of militarily degrading and economically destabilising Iran—even at the cost of inflicting irreversible damage on infrastructure and industrial targets. The second is the emergence of a form of political consensus in Tehran, whereby the acceptance of war termination would be contingent upon credible and enforceable guarantees against the recurrence of similar attacks, as well as the establishment of a clear mechanism for compensation for incurred damages. Absent such conditions, it is evident that in the coming years, recurrent strikes at short intervals targeting Tehran will be pursued with the objective of achieving full politico-economic collapse. Therefore, Tehran now appears to be preparing for a protracted

conflict with a multi-month operational horizon. In an ideal scenario for the White House, the United States may seek—based on its prior assessments and claims—to bring the conflict to a conclusion within a maximum window of six to eight weeks from the initiation of operations. Within this framework, the incumbent administration would define the destruction of Iran's military-industrial infrastructure at multiple levels, the degradation of its ballistic missile programme, and the weakening of its nuclear programme as its end-state objectives, and on the basis of achieving these goals, declare itself victorious in the campaign. Although economic pressures and the foreign policy considerations of Donald Trump could render such a scenario partially plausible—particularly with the aim of securing a rapid exit from the conflict and avoiding entanglement in a protracted war of attrition—a set of powerful countervailing and deterrent factors stands in the way of its realisation. The first issue poses a fundamental question: would Tehran, after absorbing such a scale of damage, be willing at all to place trust in unreliable ceasefire assurances? Within a period of less than a year, Iran has been subjected to two major attacks, leading to a shift in the perception of decision-makers in Tehran regarding the nature of prior negotiations. In this context, a prevailing interpretation has emerged that the pre-war talks—particularly those preceding the 12-day war—were not genuine avenues for de-escalation, but rather instruments of deception and time-buying employed by the Trump administration. Accordingly, any prospective negotiations are now assessed as serving a similar function. Violation of Iran's strategic red lines during this conflict has also elevated the nature of the war beyond a purely military confrontation, transforming it into an existential struggle. Consequently, the decision-making framework in Tehran is no longer defined solely by tactical or even operational considerations, but rather at a higher level by the perception of a fundamental threat to the survival and continuity of the country's politico-security structure—an evolution that inherently constrains flexibility in accepting a ceasefire or compromise. The second issue pertains to the reaction of regional states to such a decision. Arab governments would face a critical dilemma: whether they can accept Iran in the condition of a “wounded tiger” in their immediate neighbourhood, while the United States effectively distances itself from direct security commitments, substituting them with assurances such as the provision of more advanced weapon systems. States that have participated—directly or indirectly—in strikes against Iran, even beyond the framework of their defensive commitments to Washington, are fully aware that this level of involvement will not be without long-term consequences and will be noted in Tehran's future strategic calculations. The third issue concerns Israel's position regarding any potential ceasefire. Israel has effectively been engaged in a sustained state of war for approximately two years. While the continuation of this situation may, from certain analytical perspectives, be interpreted as a mechanism for managing or deflecting internal challenges, polling data indicates that a significant portion of the population in the occupied territories continues to support the continuation of the war. Under such circumstances, Israel can be regarded as one of the principal obstacles to any form of compromise—a strategic actor that stands to benefit not only from the weakening of Iran, but also from the gradual attrition of Arab states throughout this process, unless it is directly constrained by the United States. The United States may still seek to test its prospects through targeted assassinations of political and military officials. As previously observed, dozens of prominent figures—including Ali Larijani, Secretary of the Supreme National Security Council—were assassinated in coordination with Israel. Nevertheless, the trajectory of Iran's military operations within a defensive framework has continued uninterrupted. Predefined operational directives governing the conduct of the war remain in place and are not fundamentally disrupted by the elimination of key individuals. In this regard, it is important to note that such a situation is not

unprecedented for Tehran and is not its first experience confronting the physical elimination of senior officials under wartime conditions. During the Iran-Iraq War, particularly following the removal of Abolhassan Banisadr from office, the People's Mojahedin Organisation of Iran entered an armed phase of confrontation. This period is widely regarded as one of the bloodiest phases of political violence in modern Iranian history, during which a number of prominent figures were targeted in terrorist attacks, including Mohammad Ali Rajai, Mohammad Javad Bahrani and Mohammad Beheshti, alongside dozens of religious authorities, government officials, members of the judiciary, and military personnel. Ultimately, in light of the factors outlined above, a rapid US exit from this campaign would be contingent upon the emergence of a form of mutual understanding between Tehran and Washington—one capable of consolidating a minimum set of interests and red lines for both sides within a credible and enforceable framework. However, as long as the United States is not prepared to offer concrete and measurable concessions within the context of a viable agreement, the alternative will remain the continuation of a pressure-based approach—one grounded in the application of instruments of power across multiple domains, aimed at compelling Tehran to revise its strategic calculations. In the weeks ahead, the US-Israeli coalition is expected to progressively expand the scope of its operations toward Iran's economic infrastructure. Early indications of this approach are already visible in airstrikes targeting significant segments of Iran's steel industry. This trend may extend in a cascading manner to other critical sectors of the economy, including power generation facilities, core infrastructure such as bridges and road networks, cement production plants, and even mining operations. At the strategic level, the objective of such actions is to generate broad-based economic pressure and, subsequently, incite social discontent with the aim of compelling the governing system to accept terms of capitulation. In response, Iran's reaction to such a scenario can be assessed as largely predictable: corresponding infrastructure across the region—particularly those established through direct or indirect US investment—will be subjected to reciprocal military action. Under conditions in which Tehran has succeeded in maintaining an effective rate of fire in both its drone and missile domains, while signs of strain in defensive missile inventories—particularly anti-ballistic interceptors—are emerging on the opposing side, Iran may gradually acquire the capacity not only to threaten US economic interests in the region, but also to directly target Israel's economic infrastructure. In this context, the 2 April missile strike against the Segula industrial zone and the destruction of a facility belonging to Aerosol—a company active in the production of quadcopters, reconnaissance UAVs and loitering munitions—can be assessed as the first documented instance of effective Iranian strikes at this level. The scope of this attack could, if necessary, expand to more critical infrastructure such as power generation facilities. Part of this effectiveness can be attributed to Israel's policy of rationing anti-ballistic interceptor missiles—a condition that, if the conflict persists, is likely to face serious constraints in the short term with respect to replenishment. While the balance between offensive and defensive missile capabilities is gradually shifting in Iran's favour, one plausible scenario—though not as a standalone solution, but rather as a complementary option—would involve the employment of special operations forces. Units operating under the command of United States Special Operations Command, currently deployed in the Middle East, could be tasked with executing a series of targeted operations aimed at suppressing or disrupting Iranian missile bases. While these facilities demonstrate considerable resilience against aerial bombardment, they remain, from the standpoint of internal vulnerabilities, potential targets for infiltration and sabotage operations. Indeed, CENTCOM has already sought to complement airstrikes on tunnel entrances by employing BLU-91/B munitions to mine the surrounding areas of such installations. The execution of such a scenario, despite its inherently bold

character, can be conceptualised within an acceptable risk framework—particularly given that portions of Iran's missile infrastructure are located along the country's southern littoral, in relatively close proximity to the coastline, thereby reducing operational risk for attacking forces compared to deeper inland targets. Nevertheless, such operations cannot be conducted entirely beyond the detection capabilities of Iranian defensive forces. Finally, one of the decisive variables that may persist even beyond the formal termination of hostilities is the issue of control over the Strait of Hormuz. Within this context, some analysts argue that as long as Iran retains effective control over this strategic waterway, the United States will be unable to credibly claim victory, and the strategic implications of this condition will endure for years. While White House officials assert that the United States does not maintain direct dependency on oil transiting through this route and that energy market volatility would be limited to short-term effects, the reality is considerably more complex. Beyond China, a substantial portion of the United States' Asian allies rely heavily on Middle Eastern energy supplies, and any disruption in this chain would indirectly impact the US economy. Among these, Japan represents one of the most vulnerable cases, importing over 90 percent of its oil from the Middle East, with approximately 70 percent of that volume transiting through the Strait of Hormuz. Under such conditions, an increase in interest rates by the Bank of Japan in response to rising energy prices—or, in other words, an appreciation of the yen against the dollar—could generate far-reaching consequences for the global economy, directly affecting equity, bond and real estate markets. Under the combined influence of the strategic importance of this waterway and pressure from regional Arab states, the United States may resort to military measures aimed at reopening the Strait of Hormuz. Among the potential scenarios regarding the Strait is, once again, the seizure of Kharg Island. The island's significance derives from its role in facilitating approximately 90 percent of Iran's oil exports, thereby rendering it a potentially effective instrument of coercive leverage. However, as previously noted, operational considerations indicate that both the seizure and, more critically, the holding of the island would entail substantial challenges. Its proximity to the mainland and the absence of natural defensive features expose it to persistent vulnerability. Although the presence of sensitive oil infrastructure may constrain the scale of Iranian firepower, any attempt to seize the island would necessitate the deployment of layered air defence systems, the establishment of fortified defensive positions, and sustained air support by the attacking force. Even so, it must be emphasised that the capture of Kharg Island, absent control over the Strait of Hormuz, would lack full strategic utility and, at best, could serve as a bargaining instrument in future negotiations. Similarly, the seizure of islands overlooking the Strait of Hormuz—including Abu Musa, Greater Tunb, Lesser Tunb, Larak, Hormuz and Qeshm—has been considered as potential operational objectives. From a military standpoint, islands located at greater distance from the Iranian mainland, such as Abu Musa, are assessed as relatively easier to seize, whereas islands such as Qeshm, due to their proximity to the mainland and operational characteristics similar to Kharg, present significantly greater complexity. However, even if such objectives were achieved, control of these islands alone would not suffice to fully reopen the Strait, given that a substantial portion of Iran's offensive capabilities—particularly in the domains of UAVs and anti-ship missiles—are projected from within the country's interior. In general terms, any direct military intervention in the Strait of Hormuz could trigger a new phase of attritional conflict over a one- to three-month horizon, without necessarily yielding a decisive outcome. Moreover, under current conditions, a form of “selective control” is being exercised over the Strait; a complete physical blockade has not been implemented, and vessels belonging to non-hostile states are permitted safe passage upon authorisation. By contrast, any US military action could fully disrupt

maritime traffic for several weeks, and in the event of extensive mine-laying operations, such disruption could extend for months. Beyond energy transit, this maritime corridor plays a critical role in the movement of less visible yet strategically vital commodities such as helium, sulfur and urea—materials that are indirectly essential for advanced industries, including semiconductor manufacturing, rare earth extraction, and industrial cooling systems, and directly critical for agriculture. As such, disruption of this route could affect global supply chains at levels extending well beyond the energy sector. Such a scenario would carry significant consequences for European allies dependent on liquefied natural gas and Asian economies reliant on crude oil, a factor that has thus far contributed to the absence of meaningful support for an international military campaign in this waterway. Ultimately, the most probable trajectory for the United States may be a composite of the aforementioned scenarios. It appears that Washington will, at least until the completion of the deployment of additional forces and equipment to the region, refrain from direct large-scale engagement in the Strait of Hormuz and instead focus on strengthening political and economic pressure mechanisms within the framework previously outlined. As noted at the outset, war can be conceptualised as the continuation of a negotiation process in which military instruments serve the realisation of political objectives. From this perspective, the nature of the conflict resembles less a temporary confrontation and more a prolonged war of attrition. Nevertheless, the Trump administration appears to have initially pursued a rapid and short-term victory—akin to its approach in Venezuela—but has, in practice, become entangled in a protracted and attritional conflict that imposes a fundamentally different strategic logic and set of requirements. As this trajectory unfolds, the United States is targeting infrastructure and civilian objects in an effort—reminiscent of the approach used during the Kosovo War—to raise the costs of conflict for Iran across multiple domains and influence Tehran's political decision-making. In turn, Iran has leveraged countervailing instruments—most notably the strategic leverage of the Strait of Hormuz and strikes against US regional interests and partners—to maintain a balance of pressure. On this basis, it can be estimated that the conflict will persist for at least another month. Should the current trends continue, the volume of unrealised oil production could approach one billion barrels; and by the end of April, tangible signs of an energy crisis are likely to become increasingly evident across the economies of Asia, Africa and Europe. At the same time, the continuation of high-risk and accelerated actions by the United States may further exacerbate the conflict, creating a scenario in which not only adversaries but also US allies are exposed to escalating costs stemming from this state of strategic disorientation.

3. Iran's Strategic Options: Rethinking Negotiation with America

URL: <http://studies.aljazeera.net/en/analyses/iran%E2%80%99s-strategic-options-rethinking-negotiation-america>

Introduction In analysing the foreign policy of the Islamic Republic of Iran, reliance upon the classical frameworks of liberal diplomacy—predicated as they are on mutual trust, international institutions, and legal obligations—appears distinctly inadequate for elucidating the conduct of major powers, most notably the United States. The foreign policy system of the Islamic Republic defines 'Iranian realism' as a pragmatic theoretical framework which, in stark contrast to Western schools of thought, is founded not upon the maintenance of a crude balance of power, but rather upon 'active deterrence' and a steadfast reliance on practical, on-the-ground measures. In this view, written

commitments and diplomatic assurances are devoid of intrinsic value; rather, it is exclusively tangible, operational capabilities in the field that are deemed the true guarantors of survival and national security. The historical experience of engaging with major powers, specifically the United States, has demonstrated that diplomacy in its conventional sense—rooted in goodwill and adherence to obligations—proves wholly ineffectual against America's structural interests and habitual pattern of abrogating agreements. Furthermore, international commitments, when bereft of a robust deterrent backing, ultimately amount to ceding the initiative to an actor that simultaneously dictates and flouts the rules of the game. Consequently, Iranian realism must be understood as an indigenous theory of decision-making. By synthesising 'historical memory', the 'calculus of power' and 'pre-emptive action', it offers a paradigm for comprehending and directing foreign policy that is profoundly divergent from Western models. Contrary to the classical interpretations of realism within international relations, Iranian realism is not merely an analytical construct; it is a logic of survival, born of Iran's historical encounters with the volatility of the international system and the capricious behaviour of its adversaries. Transcending the simplistic binary of 'negotiation versus confrontation', this approach is anchored in a fundamental axiom: only that which has been unequivocally established in the theatre of power shall be accorded recognition at the negotiating table. From this perspective, diplomacy is intrinsically a function of objective power, rendering any a priori reliance upon legal mechanisms inherently flawed. It is upon this basis that the late Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, has emphatically underscored the necessity of leaning on domestic strength, while steadfastly avoiding any dependence upon or trust in foreign commitments—particularly those of the United States. Ayatollah Khamenei had repeatedly characterised the United States as an 'untrustworthy', 'perfidious' and 'deceitful' state, deeming negotiations with it an exercise in futility. Highlighting America's extensive record of broken promises, he has consistently counselled the nation's officials to rely upon domestic capabilities rather than placing their faith in Western assurances. By way of illustration, during an address to the Cabinet on 28 July 2021, he articulated: "Domestic programmes must absolutely not be made contingent upon Western cooperation, for such an approach is intrinsically doomed to fail. Wherever you predicated your endeavours upon the West and negotiations with them—and with America in particular—you were unsuccessful; conversely, wherever you advanced without placing your trust in the West and relinquished your hopes in them, you achieved success and moved forward." (1) Consequently, any analysis of contemporary conflicts—including the 12-Day War and the Ramadan War—must be re-evaluated through the prism of this very Iranian realism, a paradigm which locates the demarcation between negotiation and resistance firmly within the concept of 'deterrent power'. Thus, the present exposition is predicated upon an approach that underscores the primacy of objective power, historical empiricism and a structural distrust towards both bilateral treaties and the international system at large. Crucially, it asserts the absolute precedence of survival and national security over mere nominal commitments. The United States is a regime that has abrogated the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA)—an accord representing the culmination of the most protracted negotiations in history. Indeed, in the preceding months—prior to the 12-Day War, which commenced on 13 June 2025, and the Ramadan War, which erupted on 28 February 2026—this very regime embarked upon a criminal enterprise. Amidst active negotiations, in a criminal move, it initiated a war—utterly devoid of any legal or customary international legitimacy—by assassinating the Supreme Leader—a towering figure in the historical struggle against oppression and global arrogance—along with his family, and by perpetrating a massacre of innocent schoolgirls at the Shadjareh Tayyebbeh School in the city of Minab. Throughout its history, particularly subsequent to its emergence as the globe's

so-called superpower, the United States has frequently assumed the mantle of mediator or guarantor in ceasefires and peace accords, or conversely, has acted as a direct belligerent in conflict. In every such instance, it has brazenly persisted in violating its commitments. A historical review unequivocally demonstrates that this ethos of treaty abrogation and perfidy constitutes a systemic and recurrent behavioural pattern. Mendacity, deception and reneging on promises are the very paradigms of American foreign policy. Within this duplicitous framework, on the one hand, the violation of obligations by hostile actors has routinely been met with American backing or complicit silence. On the other hand, the United States itself—whether through unilateral withdrawal from international treaties or by exerting pressure upon its allies—has systematically sacrificed adherence to peace agreements at the altar of the vested interests of the war industry's corporate enterprises, or in deference to prioritising its so-called 'national interests'. An examination of several historical precedents from the past half-century alone serves to substantiate this American chicanery.

1. The Vietnam War, the Paris Accords and the Abandonment of an Ally (1973–1975) Following years of arduous negotiation, the Paris Peace Accords were signed in 1973 between the United States, North Vietnam and South Vietnam. Under this treaty, the United States committed to a 'severe response'—including extensive airstrikes—in the event of any ceasefire violations by North Vietnam. Richard Nixon, then US President, reiterated his 'personal assurances' to the South Vietnamese leadership regarding their national defence. Merely two years later, in 1975, North Vietnam launched a full-scale offensive. The United States, by then under the administration of Gerald Ford, not only defaulted on its obligations but executed a precipitous withdrawal from the region. South Vietnam collapsed, and thousands of American allies were left to their fate.
- (2) This serves as a quintessential example of American unreliability—a trait not exclusive to the Trump era, but one woven into the fabric of US history.
2. Afghanistan, the 2020 Doha Agreement and the Fall of Kabul In February 2020, the Donald Trump administration signed the Doha Agreement with the Taliban. Under this agreement, the United States pledged to withdraw its forces, while the Taliban guaranteed that Afghan soil would not be utilised by terrorist groups and committed to intra-Afghan dialogue. Throughout this process, the elected Afghan government was entirely excluded and subjected to the pressure of 'Sword of Damocles' style tweets to accede to American demands. Predictably, the Taliban swiftly violated their commitments, escalating attacks against the Afghan state. Despite these overt breaches, first the Trump administration and subsequently the Biden administration proceeded with the withdrawal. In August 2021, this hurried and ill-conceived retreat culminated in the total collapse of the Afghan government and the Taliban's return to power.
- (3) This event stands as one of America's gravest diplomatic failures and a symbol of Washington's disregard for its commitments to its allies.
3. Obstruction of Ceasefires in Gaza (2023–2026) The most recent manifestation of violating peace and ceasefire pertains to the war in Gaza. Notwithstanding its rhetoric of supporting peace, the United States has repeatedly exercised its veto power within the UN Security Council to block ceasefire resolutions. From October 2023 to as of this writing, the United States has vetoed at least four Security Council resolutions calling for an 'immediate, unconditional and permanent ceasefire'. The latest instance occurred in November 2024, when 14 members of the Council voted in favour, and the United States stood alone in blocking the resolution.
- (4) 4. Unilateral Withdrawal from International Treaties and the Destabilisation of Global Order Fundamentally, the United States displays no genuine commitment to international treaties. For instance, in May 2024, the International Court of Justice (ICJ) issued an emergency order explicitly demanding that "Israel immediately halt its military offensive in Rafah".
- (5) Rather than facilitating the enforcement of this binding ruling, the United States disrupted the

international legal process by proposing a hollow resolution in the UN Security Council, thereby granting Israel the opportunity to persist in its operations. In January 2026, the Trump administration ordered the US withdrawal from 66 international organisations and treaties, including the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC) and the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC). Experts have characterised this move as a catastrophic blow to global cooperation, leading to the scientific and diplomatic isolation of the United States. (6) Systematic Breaches of Commitment by the United States during the Era of the Islamic Revolution in Iran Throughout the history of its relations with Iran, the United States has violated numerous obligations, whether enshrined in international agreements or offered as diplomatic assurances. This pattern, persisting from the final years of the Jimmy Carter presidency to the present day, serves as a primary pillar of the profound mistrust towards Washington. Several prominent instances of these breaches are highlight here: 1. The 1981 Algiers Accords, the Hostage Release and Disregarded Obligations Following the 444-day hostage crisis at the US Embassy, the Algiers Accords were signed in January 1981 between Iran and the United States, facilitated by the Algerian government. This agreement established clear, reciprocal obligations for both parties. (7) The United States committed to four principal mandates: 1) the unfreezing of approximately \$12 billion in Iranian assets 2) non-interference in Iran's internal and external affairs 3) the lifting of all trade and financial sanctions and 4) the barring of legal claims against Iran within US courts. Despite being signed as an 'Executive Agreement' rather than a Senate-ratified treaty, subsequent US administrations systematically undermined its provisions. In the decades that followed, the United States continued to support opposition groups and imposed sanctions that far exceeded the framework of the original agreement. (8) 2. The 2003 'Grand Bargain' Proposal and the Bush Administration's Rejection of a Historic Opportunity In the spring of 2003, coinciding with the US invasion of Iraq and the fall of Saddam Hussein, the reformist administration of President Mohammad Khatami transmitted a comprehensive proposal to the George W. Bush administration via the Swiss diplomat, Tim Guldemann. This proposal, widely known as the 'Grand Bargain', represented a significant historical opportunity for the normalisation of relations based on four fundamental axes: 1) Full transparency in the nuclear programme and the adoption of the Additional Protocol 2) cooperation with the United States to stabilise Iraq 3) the cessation of support for Palestinian groups and the acceptance of a two-state solution and 4) collaborative efforts in the 'War on Terror', including against Al-Qaeda and the People's Mojahedin Organization of Iran (MEK). (9) The Bush administration summarily rejected the proposal without formal explanation. International analysts have evaluated this rejection as the "greatest missed opportunity for peace with Iran". (10) This dismissal, coupled with the 2002 designation of Iran within the so-called 'Axis of Evil', underscores a pattern of American bad faith even prior to the formal commencement of negotiations. 3. The 2015 JCPOA and Unilateral Withdrawal Despite Verified Compliance Despite Iran's warranted distrust of the United States, to demonstrate the Islamic Republic's commitment to international norms, the JCPOA was signed in 2015 between Iran and the P5+1 (the United States, Russia, China, France, the United Kingdom and Germany), subsequently enshrined within UN Security Council Resolution 2231. (11) This agreement, achieved after two years of intensive negotiations, was hailed by the international community as a landmark diplomatic triumph. The United States committed to lifting nuclear-related sanctions, refraining from imposing new nuclear-related measures, and facilitating international trade and banking with Iran. (12) Yet, on 8 May 2018, then-President Donald Trump unilaterally withdrew the United States from the agreement, (13) despite repeated certifications from the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA)

that Iran remained in full compliance with all its obligations. (14) The Trump administration immediately reinstated secondary sanctions against Iran and any third-party nations engaging in trade with the Islamic Republic. This move was not only a blatant breach of commitment to Iran but also placed America's European partners including France, the United Kingdom and Germany (also known as the E3) in a precarious position, compelling them to establish the Instrument in Support of Trade Exchanges (INSTEX) mechanism to preserve the accord. It aimed to preserve the Iran nuclear deal by supporting humanitarian trade, but was liquidated in March 2023 following minimal usage. Analysts contend that this American action sent a definitive signal to the world that even multilateral agreements endorsed by the UN Security Council lack any guarantee of permanence against a change of administration in Washington. (15) 4. The 'Maximum Pressure' Policy (2018–2021), the Abrogation of Multilateralism and the Erosion of Diplomatic Credibility Following its withdrawal from the JCPOA, the Trump administration pursued the 'Maximum Pressure' Policy, which stood in stark contradiction to both the spirit and the letter of previous agreements. The United States imposed sanctions aimed at reducing Iranian oil exports to zero, (16) representing a direct violation of JCPOA commitments. In March 2025, the US government announced it would not renew the sanctions waiver for Iraq's purchase of Iranian electricity and gas. (17) The Iranian Foreign Ministry characterised this move as "entirely illegal" and an "admission of lawlessness". Furthermore, in 2020, the Trump administration attempted to trigger the UN Security Council's 'snapback' mechanism to reinstate all UN sanctions. However, as noted by the E3 powers, the United States was no longer a participant in the agreement following its withdrawal and thus possessed no such legal standing. (18) 5. Violations of Territorial Sovereignty and Covert Operations (2003–2008) During the George W. Bush presidency, the United States executed a series of interventionist measures against Iran, violating international obligations and the UN Charter. Over the years, Iran repeatedly lodged complaints regarding the incursion of American drones into its airspace. (19) Simultaneously, the Bush administration provided financial and military support to armed opposition groups, such as Jundallah in Sistan and Baluchestan and the Kurdistan Free Life Party (PJAK) in Iran's Kurdish regions. (20) Conclusion: The Mendacity of Trump and the US Administration: The Necessity of Substantive Action and Reliance on 'Iranian Realism' The examination of the aforementioned precedents similarly demonstrates that American breaches of commitment regarding ceasefires and peace accords recur within three primary paradigms: - Hollow assurances to allies: As evidenced by the cases of South Vietnam and Afghanistan, the United States has historically abandoned its partners at the first sign of shifting political winds. - The subversion of international law to shield proxies: This is manifest in the extensive use of the veto power to obstruct peace resolutions against the Israeli regime and to prevent investigations into its own or its allies' atrocities. - Unilateral abrogation of key agreements: The systematic abandonment of multilateral diplomacy and the withdrawal from treaties that serve as the very guarantors of global peace and stability. Consequently, any engagement with such a power must transcend the sphere of rhetorical promises and be predicated upon a rigorous Iranian realism—an approach that prioritises tangible, verified actions and deterrent strength over the ephemeral words of an untrustworthy interlocutor. In an environment where the rules of engagement are perpetually redefined by hegemonic powers, Iranian realism and pragmatism have emerged as a strategic necessity. By rejecting a passive reliance on legalistic commitments, this approach seeks to re-evaluate the nexus between power and diplomacy. Diplomacy, in this framework, is viewed as an extension of 'power on the ground'—a tool to consolidate tangible achievements. Within such a paradigm, security is generated by 'imposing costs on the adversary', and agreements are

understood merely as transient phases within a continuous power struggle. Consequently, the future of Iranian foreign policy depends on deepening this logic which is a synthesis of active deterrence, geopolitical leverage and conditional diplomacy. This logic not only facilitates the management of current crises but also possesses the capacity to shape a regional order favourable to Iran's interests. On this basis, six fundamental strategic approaches are emphasised:

- Any commitment remains invalid on paper alone; it is substantive action that provides deterrence. Therefore, the total dismantling of the military infrastructure of the United States and the illegal Israeli regime constitutes the basis for continuing the defensive struggle in the Ramadan War. The core of this strategy is a rejection of negotiations and the continuation of war until the complete eradication of US and Israeli military assets in the region, thereby depriving them of the capacity for reconstruction and reinforcing Iranian primacy.
- The establishment of systematic structures for Iran's sovereign toll and tariff control power and management of the Strait of Hormuz. This includes the imposition of transit tolls on all goods passing through this strategic waterway—a practice common in the Suez Canal in Egypt, the Panama Canal, and the Turkish Straits of Bosphorus and Dardanelles. As the conduit for 25% of global energy, the Strait of Hormuz is the world's most vital maritime artery, passing through the shared territorial waters of Iran and Oman. Iran must, in practice, deploy all necessary customs and control apparatuses along this route.
- Given the inherent mistrust of American commitments, war reparations must be deposited into the official accounts of the Islamic Republic of Iran before any cessation of hostilities. Until such payments are rendered, the war shall continue with full force.
- Prior to any declaration of the end of the war by Iran, the United States must formally and publicly accept and declare responsibility for the killing of Iranian citizens and compatriots.
- All adversarial leaders and activists who provided media or logistical support to the United States and Israel during the Ramadan War—including leaders of the Iranian opposition—must be formally extradited to Iran. The war shall persist until such individuals are handed over.
- An immediate and concurrent halt to the war against Iran's allies, including the oppressed people of Gaza and Hamas, Lebanese Hezbollah, Yemen's Ansarullah, and the Iraqi Al-Hashd al-Shaabi. Based on Iranian realism, formal diplomacy regarding commitments and accords is currently devoid of efficacy. Instead, the focus shall shift to public diplomacy to inform global opinion across West Asia, Europe, America and Southeast Asia as a complement to the deterrence strategy. All strategic decisions regarding war and peace shall remain centralised under the principle of Unified Command, directed by the new Leader of the Revolution and Commander-in-Chief of the Armed Forces, Ayatollah Sayyid Mojtaba Hosseini Khamenei, within the Supreme National Security Council and the Joint Staff of the Armed Forces. For the time being, strategic wartime decisions are relegated to the 'war room', and all forms of formal diplomacy concerning treaties shall be avoided. This pragmatic approach, by transcending ceremonial diplomacy and relying upon the realities of the field, secures Iran's national interests and ensures sustainable security.

- “■■ ■■ ■■ ■■ ■■ ■■ ■■ ■■ ■■ ■■ ■■ [Wherever you tied work to the West, you failed; wherever you proceeded without relying on the West, you advanced]”, Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Islamic Republic of Iran, 28 July 2021, <https://tinyurl.com/y96sa3f6> (accessed 30 March 2026).

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4. Secularism and Sacred Narratives: The Contradictions of US Political Rhetoric in the 2026 Iran War

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Abstract The United States has always presented itself as a secular liberal democracy grounded in the separation of religion and state. However, throughout its modern history, American wartime rhetoric has often incorporated moral and religious language that frames conflicts in ideological or theological terms. The 2026 US-Israeli war on Iran provides a contemporary case through which to

examine this contradiction. This analysis looks into United States' political and military discourse and how it reveals a persistent tension between its formal commitment to secularism and its practical reliance on religious and moral narratives to justify and sustain conflict. By analysing the war on Iran alongside earlier conflicts such as the Cold War, the War on Terror, and the Iraq War, this analysis shows that this pattern is structural rather than incidental. While defenders argue that such rhetoric is symbolic or limited to individuals, this analysis contends that it reflects a deeper inconsistency that undermines the credibility of the United States' claim of pure secularism and contributes to the moral escalation of worldwide geopolitical conflicts.

Introduction

The United States has long defined itself as a secular political system in which religion and state authority are formally and definitively separated. This identity is embedded in constitutional law and often emphasised in both domestic and international discourse. However, during periods of war, this purely secular self-representation gets put to the test. In such contexts, political and military rhetoric often shifts from secular justification toward moral and sometimes explicitly religious framing. The 2026 conflict between the United States and Iran illustrates this contradiction quite clearly. Official narratives emphasise strategic concerns such as nuclear nonproliferation and regional security. At the same time, credible reporting indicates that elements within US political and military structures have employed religious language, invoking ideas of divine purpose and apocalyptic struggle. This is particularly alarming and important, as it raises a central analytical question, namely whether a state that claims secular neutrality can coherently engage in discourse that frames war in quasi-religious terms. This analysis argues that the United States exhibits a form of political duality that constitutes a structural contradiction. While it maintains a formal commitment to secularism, it repeatedly relies on religious and moral narratives to mobilise support and legitimise military action. This pattern, evident in the 2026 Iran war and reinforced by historical precedent, challenges the coherence of American secular identity and suggests that its foreign policy discourse is shaped not only by strategic calculation but also by ideological and cultural narratives.

The 2026 Iran War: Strategic Justifications and Religious Undercurrents

The 2026 escalation between the United States and Iran was triggered by coordinated military strikes involving US and Israeli forces, with the justification being that Iran sponsors terrorists worldwide and that Iran refuses to "renounce their nuclear ambitions".

- (1) Later developments included expanded military operations and increased troop deployments across the Middle East
- (2) Official US justifications for the conflict have remained grounded in conventional strategic language, including deterrence, national security and regional stability. However, this secular framing has been accompanied by a parallel discourse that introduces religious elements into the narrative of the war. Reports from established media organisations and watchdog groups say that some US military personnel were exposed to rhetoric portraying the conflict as part of a divine plan or linked to biblical end-times prophecy.
- (3) Additional reporting suggests that references to concepts such as Armageddon were allegedly invoked in military contexts, raising concerns about the appropriateness of such language within a formally secular institution.
- (4) Concerns about this religious framing have also entered the political arena. Members of the United States Congress have formally requested investigations into whether military leaders have framed the war in explicitly religious terms, underscoring the seriousness of the issue.
- (5) While such claims remain contested and do not represent official doctrine, their presence in credible reporting demonstrates that religious framing is actively circulating within the discourse surrounding the conflict. The coexistence of strategic justification and religious rhetoric reveals a significant contradiction. On one hand, the United States presents its actions as rational and secular. On the other hand, elements of its discourse invoke moral superiority and divine purpose.

This duality suggests that secularism, while formally upheld, is not consistently maintained in practice. A Pattern of Moralised Warfare The integration of moral and religious rhetoric into US wartime discourse is not unique to the 2026 war on Iran. Rather, it reflects a broader historical pattern. During the Cold War, United States leaders often framed the ideological struggle against the Soviet Union as a confrontation between a religious free world and godless communism. This framing transformed a geopolitical rivalry into a moralised conflict, thereby strengthening domestic support through ideological polarisation. Similarly, following the September 11 attacks, the War on Terror was often described in terms that blurred the distinction between strategic necessity and moral struggle. President George W. Bush's use of the term "crusade," although later retracted, showed just how quickly religious language could enter official discourse. (6) The Iraq War further reinforced this pattern, with narratives emphasising moral responsibility and the confrontation of evil. Scholarly work supports the argument that such rhetoric is deeply embedded in United States political culture. When looking at the concept of civil religion in America, it becomes clear that national identity and political authority are intertwined with religious symbolism. (7) Within this framework, the use of religious language in wartime discourse is not an anomaly but a recurring feature of political communication. The 2026 Iran war therefore appears as part of a consistent historical trajectory in which US conflicts are framed not only in strategic terms but also in moral and symbolic language. Structural Contradiction and Political Instrumentalisation The recurring use of religious rhetoric within a formally secular state raises a fundamental issue. It is insufficient to interpret this phenomenon as merely symbolic or incidental. Rather, it reflects a structural contradiction within United States political practice. One interpretation is that this represents a deliberate strategy of political instrumentalisation. Religious language serves to mobilise domestic audiences, simplify complex geopolitical realities, and frame conflicts in morally compelling terms. By presenting wars as struggles between good and evil, political actors can generate public support and reduce opposition. However, this explanation does not fully resolve the contradiction. Even if religious rhetoric is used strategically, repeated deployment undermines the credibility of the United States' claim to secular neutrality. A state that consistently invokes moral and religious narratives in times of conflict cannot easily maintain the position that its actions are purely rational and secular. This contradiction becomes particularly significant in the context of international relations. When conflicts are framed in moral or quasi-religious terms, they are more likely to be seen as existential struggles rather than negotiable disputes. This increases the difficulty of diplomatic resolution and contributes to the escalation of tensions. Furthermore, the coexistence of secular policy and religious rhetoric creates ambiguity regarding the true basis of US foreign policy. It raises the possibility that strategic decisions are influenced not only by material interests but also by ideological and cultural factors that are not openly acknowledged. In this sense, the issue is not simply one of hypocrisy, but of structural inconsistency. The United States operates as a secular state in formal terms, yet its political discourse repeatedly draws upon religious frameworks. This duality weakens the coherence of its political identity and complicates its position in the international system. The Other Argument Notwithstanding, some still argue that the United States remains fundamentally secular in its institutional structure. The Constitution prohibits the establishment of religion, and official policy statements regarding the 2026 Iran war are framed in strategic rather than theological terms. It is also important to note that much of the reported religious rhetoric originates from individuals rather than formal doctrine. Allegations concerning religious framing within the military are still under investigation and are not universally confirmed. (8) From this perspective, such rhetoric may reflect personal beliefs rather than institutional policy. Additionally,

the use of religious narratives is not unique to the United States. Other actors in the Iran conflict, including Iran itself, have also employed religious framing to legitimise their actions. This suggests that the phenomenon may be a broader feature of contemporary conflict rather than a uniquely American contradiction. While these arguments are valid, they do not fully address the central issue. Even if religious rhetoric is not codified as official policy, its repeated presence in political and military discourse indicates that it plays a meaningful role in shaping how conflicts are understood and justified. The persistence of this pattern suggests that it is not merely incidental but deeply embedded within American political culture.

Conclusion The 2026 Iran war highlights a persistent tension within American political identity. While the United States is institutionally secular, its wartime discourse has repeatedly incorporated moral and religious language that frames conflict in ideological terms. This pattern is not new but reflects a long-standing tradition in which geopolitical struggles are presented as moral or even sacred endeavours. The evidence suggests that this phenomenon is best understood as a structural contradiction rather than a simple inconsistency. The United States simultaneously maintains a formal commitment to secularism while relying on religious narratives to mobilise support and legitimise military action. This duality undermines the coherence of its secular identity and contributes to the escalation of conflicts by framing them in absolute terms. Understanding this tension is essential for analysing US foreign policy and its global implications, as it reveals that political discourse is shaped not only by strategic considerations but also by cultural and ideological factors that complicate the distinction between secular governance and moralised warfare.

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5. The War No One Can Win: Why Shattering the Iranian Regime Is a Strategic Miscalculation

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The shattering of the Iranian regime risks triggering a catastrophic horizontal war and vertical political collapse, as Israel remains the primary existential threat to the region's stability—a crisis forcing the Middle East back into 19th-century power politics. This regression, driven by a US policy that is dismantling the very system it once established, effectively ends the region's brief 'Dengist era' and the economic spirit that once fuelled its connectivity projects. The Israeli genocide in Gaza has dramatically escalated tensions across the region. What began as a devastating war in Gaza has gradually transformed into a broader geopolitical confrontation particularly between the Israeli-US coalition and Iran. The positions of many Middle Eastern states have become increasingly clear: they refuse to be party to Israeli aggression, which has lost all moral legitimacy as its genocidal policies extend into Lebanon. It has become politically untenable for Muslim-majority countries to align with Israel, even amidst their own long-standing competition and proxy conflicts with Tehran. This shift remains firm despite current Iranian strikes against US bases located on regional soil; the capitals of the region now view these escalations not as a direct war against themselves, but as an inevitable consequence of the Israel-US confrontation from which they seek to distance themselves. The Erosion of Israeli Legitimacy and the End of the Middle East's 'Dengist' Era The question may begin with whether Israel has historical legitimacy in the region at all. Beyond the settler-colonial character of Israel and the massacres associated with its expansion, before 7 October 2023, the region had entered a period of rapprochement. Gulf countries, Türkiye, Egypt, and even Israel had begun improving relations. Even during the G20 meeting in New Delhi in September 2023, just one month before 7 October, the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC) was announced (1) and presented as a project that could bring prosperity through transportation, energy and digital connectivity to the region. (2) The vision of the Middle East as a "New Europe", a deeply integrated economic hub linking Asian economies, the Gulf and Israel to Africa and Europe, has become a central pillar of global political discourse. Türkiye, simultaneously and alternatively, announced the Development Road Project, signalling a deepening strategic alignment with Iraq. This route is increasingly highlighted as a more feasible alternative due to its lower cost and its inclusive approach toward Iran, which continues to play a vital role in the security of the Strait of Hormuz. In addition to trade route divergence, tensions in the Eastern Mediterranean decreased, and rapprochement processes began between Türkiye, Egypt and Israel. The Qatar blockade ended. At the same time, there were also ongoing developments aimed at further integrating Israel into the region. Therefore, there was a visible diplomatic thaw in the region and a quest for the Gulfication of the greater Middle East. Beyond these developments, Azizi and Halabi (3) predicted in 2025 that the Middle East is undergoing a fundamental shift as revolutionary ideologies and transnational nonstate armed actors give way to a state-centric model focused on economic development. With the "Axis of Resistance" in decline and regional powers like Saudi Arabia and Türkiye prioritising stability along with the global engagements, a 'Dengist' spirit has emerged. This new era emphasises sovereign statehood, digital infrastructure and integrated trade corridors over ideological conflict, positioning the region as a pragmatic economic hub rather than a theater for proxy warfare. This is not wishful thinking: the stabilisation of Syria after Assad and the disarmament of the Kurdistan Workers' Party (PKK) demonstrate a tangible move toward a state-centric regional order. In the wake of 7 October, regional countries initially sought to mediate the crisis, even under Israeli genocidal policies, regional and global players pressured Israel to end the conflict, leading to critical summits in Egypt and the subsequent establishment of a Board of Peace. However, Israeli military operations have not stopped with the genocide in Gaza. Threats have expanded far beyond Gaza, extending to Syria, Lebanon, Yemen and Iran. Yet

despite the scale of the conflict, there has been almost no direct military confrontation between regional states and Israel with the notable exception of Iran's brief but intense 12-day confrontation with Israel. Most regional governments remained reluctant to engage Israel directly, including Iran, largely because of the overwhelming security umbrella provided by the United States. Today, however, we are witnessing a broader Israeli war with the region, even including Iranian attacks on American bases located in the countries of the region. These attacks are widely perceived as part of the Israeli confrontation with Iran rather than as a direct Iranian war against those regional states themselves.

Self-Sufficiency (Khod-Kafai) vs. Isolation: The Sustainability of the Regime

To understand Iran's behaviour in this confrontation, one must begin with a concept that has shaped the Islamic Republic since its founding revolutionary slogan: Khod Kafaye (Farsi: self-sufficiency).

(4) Since the 1979 revolution, Iranian political doctrine has been built around the idea of strategic autonomy. The regime has consistently sought to minimise vulnerability to external pressure by developing internal capacity across several critical domains. First is ideological self-sufficiency. The Iranian political system is built upon a revolutionary narrative emphasising resistance, sovereignty and independence from both Western and Eastern domination. The famous revolutionary slogan, "Neither East nor West, only the Islamic Republic", reflects this worldview. In the face of ongoing US-Israeli aggression, the opposition is weakened as the pressure effectively serves to validate and reinforce these revolutionary ideals. Second is economic resilience. Iran's economic capacity is far from limitless, and sanctions have imposed enormous costs on Iranian society. Yet decades of sanctions have also forced Iran to develop alternative supply chains, domestic production systems and parallel financial mechanisms, alongside the growing dominance of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) within the economy. The sanctions regime has weakened Iran's economy but has also encouraged a model of adaptive survival that makes rapid regime collapse far less likely than many observers assume. Third is military self-reliance. This strategy dates back to the earliest days of the revolution and was reinforced during the Iran-Iraq War. Over time, Iran has invested heavily in asymmetric warfare capabilities, including ballistic missiles, drone technologies and networks of regional allies and militias. These capabilities allow Tehran to project influence without relying on conventional military parity. Yet a critical question remains: Can Iran truly be self-sufficient within the international system? Unlike Israel, which operates within a robust US-led alliance network, Iran lacks a comparable security architecture. Although Tehran maintains strategic cooperation with Russia and China, these relationships do not constitute formal security guarantees. In a prolonged confrontation with Israel and its Western partners, Iran could find itself strategically isolated. This is also result of Iranian proxy policies in the region as the central governments has a reservation against the Iranian regime. And yet, ironically, such isolation may produce consequences far more dangerous than many policymakers in Washington or Tel Aviv appear willing to consider: more fronts, higher costs and no clear path to defeat.

Horizontal Escalation and Vertical Failure of Regional and Global Politics

The greatest danger lies not only in interstate escalation but in the reactivation of internal conflicts across the Middle East. Several countries in the region remain deeply fragile after decades of war and institutional collapse. Iraq, Lebanon and Yemen already host armed networks with transnational loyalties and ideological alignments which could once again become arenas for overlapping regional conflicts and have a potential to spread Syria. The aftermath of the US invasion of Iraq in 2003 and the post-Arab Spring transitions demonstrated how quickly regional political divisions and polarisations can spiral into prolonged civil war including the proxy strategies. The current geopolitical climate carries similar risks. But the Iranian case presents a different calculation for Israel. A possible collapse of Iranian central control

could generate a landscape in which decentralised militias and ideological movements operate across multiple states, making the security of Israel, US allies in the region (such as Gulf countries), Iraq, Lebanon and Syria, far more precarious than before. In his recent analysis, Robert A. Pape cites the conflicts in Vietnam and Kosovo to highlight the inherent risks of horizontal escalation, arguing that US-Israeli aerial dominance alone cannot secure a clear victory. (5) He posits that a prolonged, widening war ultimately favours Iran, as Tehran can leverage regional instability and economic disruption. The consequences will not remain confined to the Middle East. Sectarian and political divisions within the region can easily resonate within diaspora communities in Europe and North America, as well as Asian countries particularly where Shia political networks feel directly implicated in the conflict. If Israel believes that the collapse of the Iranian regime would secure its future, it is a miscalculation of the situation, because such an outcome could pose the greatest long-term threat to Israel itself who also became the central threat to regional states already.

Back to the 19th Century: The Architect's Exit and the Death of Global Consent

The conflict is often interpreted through familiar frameworks: deterrence, nuclear proliferation, regional power balance and the possibility of cascading civil wars across Iran and beyond by the mobilisation of decentralised Shia networks across multiple continents. Besides, for decades, the United States campaigned for a global order rooted in Western-style governance, liberal institutions and collective security guarantees. However, US Secretary of State Marco Rubio's recent speech at the Munich Security Conference signalled a historic departure from this role. By arguing that the current international system no longer serves American interests and asserting that the United States will maintain its hegemonic status regardless of the cost. Washington has clearly signalled the end of the "liberal" era. This raises a troubling paradox: who is going to intervene against the United States—the primary architect of our global institutions and a state that has intervened against so-called 'rogue states' in the name of these values—now that it is ready to abandon them? The answer, clearly, is no one. Today, the non-Western world increasingly views American power not as a stabilising force, but through a lens that resembles the imperial and colonial dominance of the past, as illustrated by recent developments in Venezuela and Greenland. As morality and shared values are stripped from the international order, we are witnessing a "Great Regression". The world is retreating from the promise of global cooperation and spiraling toward the raw, realist power politics of the 19th century—an era defined by spheres of influence, colonial-style interventions and the belief that might makes right. Across Asia, Africa and parts of the Middle East, political elites and intellectuals are increasingly questioning whether the current international system still rests on genuine global consent. A prolonged confrontation with Iran is going to fuelling anti-American sentiment globally, as military dominance alone cannot sustain an international order once its hegemonic legitimacy has eroded. Because the global community invests heavily in the 'American Dream' and the US-guaranteed 'rules-based order' through human capital, financial markets and political alignment, the collapse of that soft power would be more catastrophic for the United States than any tactical defeat on the battlefield. While the lack of clear objectives, narration of success from both parties, currently offers both sides a potential path to de-escalate and satisfy their domestic audiences, but this exit remains blocked by continued Israeli aggression, a destabilising force that the United States must now actively restrain to prevent a systemic collapse. The Iranian case therefore carries implications far beyond the Middle East. It could destabilise the entire region and, in doing so, produce the greatest long-term threat not only to Israel's future security but also to the very idea of the Western world.

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6. The Strait of Hormuz: Global Economic Shock and the Limits of Military Power

URL: <http://studies.aljazeera.net/en/analyses/strait-hormuz-global-economic-shock-and-limits-military-power>

On 28 February 2026, following a large-scale assault by the United States and Israel, the Iranian Armed Forces issued radio warnings prohibiting all navigation through the Strait of Hormuz. This restriction remains in effect, particularly targeting non-Iranian tankers. While the strategic significance of the Strait of Hormuz as a critical global energy transit chokepoint is well-known, this single waterway has the potential to impact the global economy far more profoundly than expected. And that is a lever of influence Tehran fully understands—the Strait is the butterfly capable of sparking a tornado as far away as Texas. This paper aims to briefly examine the global importance of the Strait of Hormuz, assess potential US measures, and evaluate Iran's likely responses. A Quick Overview: The Strait of Hormuz's Role in the Global Energy Market and Macro Economy: Since before the conflict began, Tehran has warned that any military adventurism in the region could have irreversible consequences for the global economy, placing direct responsibility on the United States. To understand this fully, it is essential to grasp the exact role this waterway plays in the global economic cycle. The economic importance of the Strait of Hormuz stems from its role as the primary—and in many cases the sole—export route for the world's largest oil and gas fields. Countries such as Iraq, Kuwait and Qatar depend on this strait to deliver hydrocarbons to international markets, as does a substantial portion of oil exports from Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates. In 2025, roughly 15 million barrels per day of crude oil and 5 million barrels per day of refined petroleum products were exported through this route. Estimates indicate that around 80 to 89 percent of the crude oil and condensates transiting the Strait of Hormuz are shipped to Asian refineries. China and India alone receive more than 40 percent of this volume. Countries such as Japan and South Korea also show high dependence on Gulf energy, sourcing approximately 95 and 75 percent of their crude oil needs from the region respectively. Even the United States, despite significant increases in domestic production over recent years, continues to rely on the Strait for about 7 percent of its oil consumption. However, the strait's strategic importance is not limited to oil. It is also one of the most critical arteries for liquified natural gas (LNG) trade. In 2025, over 112 billion cubic metres of LNG—equivalent to roughly 20 percent of global LNG trade—were transported via this passage. Qatar, the world's second-largest LNG exporter, depends entirely on this route for all its maritime shipments. Therefore, any disruption in LNG flows could have consequences even more severe than those affecting oil, as large-scale alternative infrastructure for natural gas transport is far more limited. Beyond energy markets, and the indirect impact of rising fuel prices on goods and services—especially in Western Europe and North America—the Strait of Hormuz plays a decisive role in the global macroeconomic cycle. Certain industrial metal markets are directly or indirectly affected. For example, aluminium production in Gulf countries reached around 6.3 million tons in 2024, accounting for 8 to 9 percent of global output and nearly 23 percent of global supply outside China. With the aluminium market facing a structural deficit of approximately 600,000 tons, any disruption could trigger sharp price spikes. On the London Metal Exchange (LME), aluminium prices have quickly exceeded \$3,400 per ton, with potential surges to \$3,600–4,000. Sulphur—sometimes called the “invisible commodity of the global economy”—provides another example of strategic dependency. Due to extensive natural gas sweetening and sour crude refining operations, the Gulf region produces roughly 44 percent of

global sulphur. Any disruption could push Middle Eastern Free on Board (FOB) prices above \$600 per ton, rapidly impacting the sulphuric acid market. The largest consumer of sulphur worldwide is the chemical fertiliser industry, accounting for 60–70 percent of global demand. If supply disruptions continue for more than two months, production of strategic crops such as corn, soybeans and wheat would be directly affected. At a deeper level, the link between Middle Eastern sulphur and critical metal production is particularly significant, as modern extraction processes for metals such as nickel, cobalt and copper rely heavily on sulfuric acid. Nickel production in Indonesia and copper in Central Africa, for instance, are dependent on this material. The ripple effects extend even to high-tech industries. The global semiconductor and electronics sectors require substantial quantities of high-purity sulphuric acid for microchip production and silicon wafer processing. Any shortage would increase manufacturing costs in major East Asian tech hubs—including Taiwan, South Korea and China. Furthermore, many semiconductor manufacturers rely on Qatari LNG for stable electricity supply. Taiwan, for example, sources roughly 30 percent of its LNG through the Strait of Hormuz. In such a scenario, even a limited disruption could affect companies like TSMC, which produces nearly 90 percent of the world's most advanced chips and consumes approximately 9 percent of Taiwan's electricity. It is now evident that a disruption in the Strait of Hormuz represents a practical illustration of chaos theory—and chaos cannot be countered with chaos. As Gandhi famously said, "An eye for an eye makes the whole world blind." Energy Market Response

Immediately following Iran's declaration of a wartime status and the imposition of navigation restrictions, energy markets reacted swiftly. Brent crude prices surged significantly, briefly approaching \$100 per barrel. While prices continue to fluctuate, estimates indicate that without a medium-term crisis management solution, prices could reach \$120 per barrel, and in the long term, potentially approach \$200. Simultaneously, with tanker traffic through the strait down by 90 percent during the first week of March 2026, the International Energy Agency (IEA) launched the largest emergency reserve release in its history. On 11 March, all 32 member countries unanimously agreed to release 400 million barrels of oil into the global market—more than twice the previous record set in 2022 following Russia's invasion of Ukraine. This volume, equivalent to roughly 26 days of normal oil flows through the Strait of Hormuz, was intended as a "time bridge" to prevent a complete collapse of the global energy supply chain. In parallel, the US Department of Energy announced that President Donald Trump had authorised the release of 172 million barrels of oil from the US Strategic Petroleum Reserve as part of a multilateral effort to stabilise the global energy market. According to the statement, the distribution of this oil would begin the following week, with full market integration expected to take approximately 120 days. Additionally, the US Department of the Treasury issued a 30-day license allowing countries to purchase Russian oil and petroleum products currently at sea, aiming to stabilise global energy markets. Despite these developments in oil markets, the primary shock occurred in natural gas. The suspension of shipping through the Strait of Hormuz, combined with damage to QatarEnergy facilities that halted production, caused Europe's Title Transfer Facility (TTF) gas index to rise by more than 60 percent in just 10 days. In late February, TTF prices ranged between €30 and €32 per megawatt-hour, but as the conflict escalated and the risk of supply disruption increased, prices climbed to over €50–55 in early March. Low storage levels in Europe, coupled with efforts by Asian countries—particularly China, Japan, South Korea and India—to secure alternative shipments from Atlantic sources, added further pressure on markets, placing European nations in a precarious position. Rising energy costs, especially for natural gas, carry wide-ranging economic implications for Europe and the United States. In countries with high dependency, such as Italy, the United Kingdom and Germany,

electricity prices have already increased by more than 13 percent. Under these conditions, energy-intensive industries—including chemicals, steel, cement, fertiliser and glass—are compelled to absorb higher production costs, which subsequently drives up the prices of finished goods along the supply chain. Beyond these sectors, the service industry—including transportation, logistics and retail—is also affected by rising fuel and electricity costs, contributing to broader inflationary pressures on advanced industrial economies. The US Military and Reopening the Strait of Hormuz

These developments have placed the United States in a precarious position. On one hand, Washington must assert relative control over the strait to portray itself as victorious in the conflict; on the other hand, any reckless military action could merely escalate tensions or produce irreversible consequences. It is important to note that the Strait of Hormuz has not been fully closed. The term “closure” is currently used metaphorically. At present, various vessels are prohibited from transiting due to warnings issued by Iran, and maritime traffic is directly monitored by the Iranian Armed Forces. Ships without direct links to the United States or Israel are only targeted if they attempt to transit the strait. Meanwhile, some reports indicate that vessels bound for China have successfully passed through. In situations of armed conflict at sea, the law of naval warfare permits a belligerent State to take action against enemy vessels and certain categories of merchant shipping that effectively support the enemy’s military operations. Under Rules 38–46 and Rule 60 of the San Remo Manual on International Law Applicable to Armed Conflicts at Sea, merchant vessels that transport fuel or other supplies contributing to the enemy’s war effort may lose their civilian protection and become lawful military objectives, provided that any action taken complies with the principles of military necessity, distinction and proportionality. In circumstances where the United States and Israel have initiated unlawful uses of force against Iran and have conducted military operations from naval and regional bases in and around the Gulf, they cannot reasonably expect to continue enjoying the full protections and advantages of peacetime maritime legal regimes while simultaneously engaging in hostilities governed by the law of armed conflict. Rather, the legal framework applicable to their conduct and to any responsive measures is that of the law of armed conflict at sea. This represents a form of “smart control” over the strait, minimising collateral damage. However, Iran retains the capability to make transit completely impossible for any vessel. In such a scenario, not only would navigation be blocked entirely, but the compensation for damaged or sunken vessels would impose significant time and financial costs on stakeholders. Other vulnerable targets include power plants, desalination facilities, district cooling systems and similar infrastructure that sustains life in the artificial environments of desert cities. Yet Iran has refrained from striking these. This restraint is deliberate: attacking such targets would invite reciprocal strikes against its own critical infrastructure and could irreparably damage relations with Arab states. Instead, Iran has closed the Strait of Hormuz to most commercial shipping. This has precipitated a severe global energy crisis, but it remains far preferable to mutual destruction of essential infrastructure. An element of strategic wisdom and calculated restraint is clearly at work here. For their part, Arab states have largely chosen—wisely—to remain outside the conflict. How the United States intends to navigate this delicate balance remains unclear, but the Strait of Hormuz is undoubtedly one of the most discussed topics at United States Central Command (CENTCOM) headquarters. The main question is whether, given the resources and capabilities at CENTCOM’s disposal, conducting a military operation to reopen the strait would be strategically and economically viable. The answer is that such an operation would follow a general framework: intensive and targeted bombardment of coastal areas, maximised suppression of mobile missile launchers using existing capabilities, and, ultimately, naval escort of vessels toward a secure corridor. According to

the latest update released by CENTCOM on Operation “Epic Fury”, approximately 6,000 targets across Iran have been struck since the operation commenced on 28 February 2026, and such attacks are likely to continue. Nevertheless, as observed in recent days, Iran continues to launch ballistic and cruise missiles. Additionally, suicide drones remain a significant challenge. Therefore, it can be concluded that the United States’s priority would be the complete neutralisation of Iran’s ballistic missiles, anti-ship cruise missiles and suicide drone capabilities. Suppressing the launch and use of suicide drones is expected to be even more difficult than countering cruise and ballistic missiles. In general, identifying mobile launchers is one of the most challenging intelligence tasks on the battlefield. To locate such targets, the United States employs an extensive network of intelligence and reconnaissance assets. At the core of this network are US Space Force reconnaissance satellites, including radar, optical and infrared platforms. Complementing these are electronic and signals intelligence (ELINT/SIGINT) satellites and aircraft, as well as reconnaissance drones operated by the US Air Force and Navy, all of which play a critical role in target identification. In addition to space-based systems, ground-based electronic intelligence (ELINT) assets also play a significant role. During the Cold War, the Soviet Union was deeply concerned about the National Security Agency’s ability to track and identify its missile launchers. The agency could intercept electronic signals emitted by Soviet launchers, providing valuable intelligence in the process. The first step in any operation would involve targeted strikes against known coastal installations. One of the key assets available to CENTCOM is the US Air Force’s bomber fleet. Currently, several B-52H and B-1B strategic bombers are deployed in Europe and actively participating in strikes against Iran. There is also reason to believe that a number of B-2A stealth strategic bombers have been involved, operating from US territory or from Diego Garcia in the Indian Ocean. However, these bombers cannot identify targets on their own; continuous intelligence support is essential. Moreover, given the operational turnaround time between sorties, complementary measures are required to maintain sustained pressure. In such a scenario, should the United States decide to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, we would likely see the deployment of US Army multiple launch rocket systems (MLRS) to fire short-range ballistic missiles from bases in Bahrain and possibly the United Arab Emirates against coastal targets in Iran. These targets could also include positions on Iranian islands in the Gulf. Alongside the use of precision-guided missiles, increased armed drone activity along the coast is expected. US tactical aviation will also play a crucial role. To maximise operational endurance, US fighter aircraft may need to relocate from more distant bases in countries such as Jordan and Israel to closer staging points, for example in the UAE. This repositioning, however, would expose them to Iranian short-range missile systems. Therefore, significant reinforcement of missile defence systems in the UAE would likely precede any serious effort to restore navigation through the strait, particularly since four Terminal High Altitude Area Defense (THAAD) batteries in Saudi Arabia, the UAE and Jordan have already been targeted by precise Iranian strikes. In this scenario, US fighter aircraft would have two primary roles: offensive and defensive. In the offensive role, F-15s, F-16s and F-35s would operate within their designated areas to disrupt cruise and ballistic missile launches, anti-ship strikes and suicide drone attacks. They could also conduct operations against Iranian vessels to prevent mining or attacks on commercial shipping. In the defensive role, these fighters would act as an aerial shield against suicide drones, thereby alleviating pressure on the US Navy’s ship-based air defence systems. The Navy would assume the most critical role in such an operation. Any effort to reopen the Strait of Hormuz would likely require the presence of at least two, if not three, carrier strike groups to escort commercial vessels and tankers safely through the waterway. Such an operation would undoubtedly be highly complex. Each carrier strike group

typically comprises a nuclear-powered aircraft carrier, several guided-missile destroyers, and a complete air wing. The backbone of air defence for each carrier strike group during commercial vessel escort operations in the strait would be the Arleigh Burke-class guided-missile destroyers. These ships generally possess between 90 and 96 missile launch cells, with roughly two-thirds of these munitions assumed to be dedicated to air defence. These would be actively used to protect escorted vessels from residual threats during the operation.

Geography vs. Military Power At its narrowest point, the Strait of Hormuz is approximately 39 kilometres wide, yet the navigable channel for ultra-large crude carriers (VLCCs) is far narrower. The strait consists of two 3.7-kilometer lanes for inbound and outbound traffic, separated by a buffer zone. Together, this 11-kilometer corridor underpins the global energy economy and lies close to Iran's coastline, enabling the Iranian military to monitor all vessel movements with precision. Iran's control over the strait is not merely a function of military hardware; geographic advantage plays a decisive role. With the longest coastline along the northern side of the strait and strategic control over islands including Greater Tunb, Lesser Tunb, Abu Musa, Lark, Qeshm and Hormuz, Iran can assert both power and oversight over maritime traffic. This geographic advantage, combined with an asymmetric military doctrine, provides Tehran with a potent strategic tool. These islands host both defensive and offensive systems, including anti-ship cruise missile launchers and suicide drones. Iran's primary requirement is to deter vessels from transiting, as nearly any explosive projectile can destroy oil tankers or LNG carriers. In contrast, the United States would need to conduct extensive operations to suppress Iran's coastal military assets before guaranteeing permanent safe passage for vessels. Iranian naval forces similarly focus on asymmetric warfare, employing sea mines, anti-ship missiles, fast attack craft (speedboats) and small submarines. It should be noted that, prior to the outbreak of hostilities, Iran explicitly warned relevant parties that any attack would trigger both vertical and horizontal escalation. One example was the letter from Iran's Permanent Mission to the United Nations dated 19 February 2026. This dynamic was also analyzed in an earlier analysis published by Al Jazeera Centre for Studies, titled "Why Trump Hesitates to Go to War with Iran". Iran's cruise missile arsenal includes short-range systems such as the Nasr with a 35-kilometre range and the Nasir with a 90-kilometre range. Next are the Noor-class missiles, based on the Chinese C-802, with ranges of 120, 200 and 300 kilometres. Finally, the Soumar and Paveh cruise missiles can strike targets up to 1,000 kilometres away. Notably, these anti-ship cruise and ballistic missiles can be fired from deep inland, over 1,000 kilometres from the strait, significantly enhancing the survivability of the launchers. Suicide drones operate similarly. One-way attack drones, which have proven highly effective in this conflict, further compound the threat. The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps Navy (IRGCN) and the Islamic Republic of Iran Navy (IRIN) also deploy fast attack craft armed with anti-ship cruise missiles, rocket launchers and even anti-tank guided missiles. These can be launched in large numbers to saturate and overwhelm convoy defences. Many such vessels are based in underground coastal facilities. To counter aerial threats, some are equipped with surface-to-air missiles, while crews carry man-portable air-defence systems. Coastal submarines represent another significant danger. The acoustic properties of the Gulf make it particularly suitable for their operation, posing a threat to both commercial shipping and any escorting naval forces. Overall, the region is a truly target-rich environment. Defending every possible energy related infrastructure is simply impossible, and even a small number of "leakers"—missiles or one-way attack drones that penetrate defences—can inflict catastrophic damage. If the United States enters the Strait of Hormuz, its military power would directly confront Iran's geographic advantage. Even an extensive air campaign along the coastline would not prevent cruise missile and suicide drone

launches from deep inland. These factors may push the United States toward high-risk decisions. Amphibious operations along the coast and the seizure of certain Iranian islands fall within this calculus. As reported, with the approval of the Pentagon, an order has been issued to deploy 2,500 U.S. Marines to the Middle East along with the amphibious ready group Tripoli. This naval group consists of the USS Tripoli, USS San Diego and USS New Orleans. The group also includes 20 F-35B fighter jets. The naval group is currently located in the eastern Pacific Ocean and will arrive in approximately two weeks. The critical question remains: how much do the lives of US service members matter to commanders? Even if small islands are successfully occupied, US forces stationed there would remain exposed to continuous Iranian fire, with minimal cover. To mitigate such risks, the United States would have to cover an enormous operational area. The concept of naval convoys also carries significant risk. The navigable portion of the Strait of Hormuz is extremely narrow, with shallow surrounding waters. This means that if any vessel—especially a lead ship—were seriously damaged or sunk, it could render the rest of the convoy effectively defenceless. Escort speed is another challenge: a commercial vessel typically moves at 18 knots (33 km/h), whereas an Arleigh Burke-class destroyer can travel at 30 knots (50 km/h). Lower speeds constrain manoeuvrability, increasing vulnerability. Another critical consideration is how many escort operations would be required to move approximately 200 non-sanctioned tankers currently in the area, and whether returning to pre-crisis shipping rates and sustained exports would even be feasible. These are questions the United States has yet to resolve. Iran's undersea capabilities present an additional challenge. Even with some Iranian submarines destroyed in the early days of the conflict, naval mines, torpedoes and unmanned underwater vehicles can easily target ships. In a high-pressure campaign, Iran could deploy mines throughout the strait. The United States's possible countermeasure could involve a form of conditional naval blockade, similar to operations conducted in Venezuela. In practice, this would entail intercepting Iranian vessels—tankers or cargo ships—once they enter the Arabian Sea, and only releasing them if maritime traffic in the Strait of Hormuz is maintained. While such a scenario is not implausible, it could trigger a severe Iranian response against US-allied Arab states. Countries like Kuwait, Bahrain, Qatar and the UAE rely heavily on maritime imports for daily necessities, rather than overland supply routes through Saudi Arabia. In summary, reopening the Strait of Hormuz may be militarily possible, but the primary challenge for the United States is that such an operation would likely incur extremely high costs and require a prolonged timeframe. Furthermore, even initiating such a conflict could trigger a global economic crisis. The combined set of threats to vessels attempting to transit the strait represents a credible and persistent danger. Neutralising this threat could take weeks or even months, and maintaining permanent control over the long term is impractical. Consequently, if the United States seriously pursues military action, a likely approach would involve a combination of the previously discussed scenarios: increased strikes along the coast, controlled amphibious operations, and the interception of Iranian vessels to exert short-term pressure on Tehran. At the same time, time is not on Washington's side; while the United States relies on classic operational scenarios, Tehran retains the initiative.

7. Strategic Paralysis and Escalatory Spillover: Applying Warden's Five Ring Theory in Operation Epic Fury

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Executive Summary Operation Epic Fury, the joint US–Israeli air campaign launched against Iran on 28 February 2026, reflects a doctrinal application of Colonel John Warden's Five Ring Theory of strategic warfare. Rather than focusing on battlefield attrition, the campaign has adopted an "inside-out" targeting approach aimed at rapidly paralysing the Iranian state by striking leadership structures, critical national systems and infrastructure before engaging fielded forces. The objective is not merely military degradation but systemic collapse of command authority and war-fighting capacity. While the strategy aligns closely with Warden's theory of strategic paralysis, the campaign carries significant regional risks. Iran's response has already demonstrated a counter-strategy: expanding the conflict horizontally by targeting economic and energy infrastructure in neighbouring Gulf states. The result is an emerging strategic contest between systemic paralysis and regional escalation, with profound implications for global energy security and regional stability.

Strategic Framework: Warden's Five Rings John Warden's model conceptualises the enemy state as a system composed of five concentric rings: leadership, system essentials, infrastructure, population and fielded military forces. The theory argues that decisive strategic effects can be achieved by attacking the inner rings particularly leadership and critical national systems thereby incapacitating the state's ability to coordinate resistance. Operation Epic Fury appears structured along precisely this logic. Instead of traditional campaigns aimed at destroying Iranian military formations, the United States and Israel have prioritised leadership decapitation, systemic disruption and infrastructure degradation in order to induce rapid strategic paralysis. From the perspective of its architects, this approach also reflects a strategic assessment that the confrontation had reached a point where military escalation was increasingly viewed as unavoidable. Years of tensions surrounding Iran's missile capabilities, nuclear infrastructure and regional proxy networks had produced a security environment in which both Washington and Tel Aviv believed the status quo was becoming progressively more dangerous. Within this context, an "inside-out" strategy offered a method designed not for prolonged war but for compressing the conflict's timeline by striking the core mechanisms of state coordination at the outset. In effect, the campaign carries a pre-emptive logic: by decentring Iran's command structure and disrupting its decision-making apparatus early, the coalition seeks to deny Tehran the organisational coherence required to mount an effective national defence or orchestrate a coordinated retaliatory campaign.

Ring One: Leadership – Disrupting the Strategic Brain The innermost ring of Warden's model consists of leadership, which, in the case of Iran, includes the Supreme Leader, the leadership of the Iranian Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC), as well as the Iranian national security leadership as a whole, which oversees military operations. The reported killing of Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei during the opening phases of the operation represents a critical disruption of the Iranian regime's leadership structure. While Mojtaba Khamenei has reportedly taken over leadership, any transition in a highly centralised regime tends to create a window of temporary disruption of command structures. The strategic objective of disrupting this ring of leadership, though, is not merely symbolic decapitation but, rather, functional paralysis. If the leadership cannot effectively communicate orders to critical organisations, such as the IRGC, then the military operations of the opponent begin to stall as a result. The military

forces deployed might be equipped with weapons as well as personnel, but they are operationally paralysed in the absence of clear strategic direction. Disruption of communications, therefore, might be as critical as the elimination of leadership figures themselves, as cyber attacks appear to be focused on ensuring that any new leadership within the Iranian leadership structure remains fractured and disputed. According to Warden's logic, if the "brain" of the state is unable to communicate with the rest of the system, then it effectively ceases to function as a coherent strategic actor.

Ring Two: System Essentials – Targeting the Regime's Lifeblood The second ring of Warden's model comprises the essential systems of the state that provide it with economic and military strength. These systems in the case of Iran include energy production, oil exports and the industrial base for missile production. Strikes on hardened ballistic missile sites and energy production facilities indicate that these facilities are now at the centre of the war in Warden's model. The ballistic missile sites of Iran are a cornerstone of its deterrence strategy, providing it with the ability to project power beyond its borders in the region. By striking at these sites, the United States and Israel are attempting to limit the ability of Iran to retaliate in kind in the future. Energy production facilities are also of critical importance to the state of Iran. The oil production facilities of Iran provide it with the financial strength to sustain its institutions and armed forces, as well as serving as the logistical backbone of its military operations. Fuel production facilities provide it with the ability to sustain domestic transportation networks, its armed forces and its industries. According to Warden's theory of warfare, modern states are unable to function without access to essential systems of energy production and industrial facilities. By striking at these facilities in tandem with the missile production facilities of Iran, the United States and Israel are attempting to sever the lifeblood of the Iranian war machine. The long-term implications of these strikes are considerable, particularly in terms of their impact on Iran's ability to fund its proxy networks and regional military operations in the future.

Ring Three: Infrastructure – Breaking the System's Connections The third ring in Warden's model is the infrastructure, and this is the part where the system's connections are broken. It includes the transportation systems, communication systems, ports and other digital systems. In Operation Epic Fury, the cyber attacks and the kinetic strikes are all targeted at the regime's connections and systems. The disruption in the internal transport systems and the satellite communications weakens the regime's capacity to control the movements of its military forces in the country. The disruption in the operations of the Iranian navy in the Gulf of Oman is part of the operations in this ring. It is not just the navy's assets that are being destroyed but the connection and the bridge between the country and the rest of the world. The weakening and the destruction of the ports and the naval assets and systems in the country are meant to weaken the regime's capacity and its connections in the Gulf and the rest of the world. Another important part in this ring is the disruption in the digital systems and the satellite communications. The satellite communications are the backbone in the modern command systems. In Warden's model, this is the nervous system in the country. Once this is disrupted, the capacity of the leadership in the country is weakened, and the military forces are fragmented.

Ring Four: Population – Psychological Pressure and Internal Stability The population represents the fourth ring in the model and is the social base of the state. This ring is not often attacked directly but can be attacked indirectly through the degradation of the other rings. In the case of Iran, the campaign's message seems to be aimed at creating psychological pressure on the domestic population. This is because the quick degradation of the IRGC's infrastructure and the disruption of the regime's defences may be perceived as a sign of strategic inevitability. This can have significant political effects because if the population begins to believe that the regime is not capable of defending the sovereignty of the state or maintaining order

internally, they may lose confidence in the state. This can lead to increased unrest in the state and put pressure on the internal security forces of the state. In line with the theory provided by Warden, the theory indicates that if the population loses confidence in the state's ability to effectively rule the state, the cohesion of the political regime begins to break down. Although external military pressure rarely causes the collapse of the state, it can hasten the political crisis in the state.

Ring Five: Fielded Forces – Neutralising Key Threats This is the outermost ring in the five-ring theory. In the conventional approach to warfare, the main objective has been to defeat the forces in the ring through attrition and direct combat. However, according to the five-ring theory, this ring is the least strategically important ring. This is because if the other rings have been successfully degraded, the forces in the ring will be ineffective regardless of their strength and sophistication. Nevertheless, Operation Epic Fury has also targeted some of the conventional military capabilities of Iran. According to reports, more than 5,000 targets have been struck, including the security infrastructure of the IRGC as well as some of the military installations of the Iranian military forces. The destruction of more than fifty vessels of the Iranian navy, as well as the capabilities of fighter jets, limits the military capabilities of Iran in the region. These strikes serve primarily defensive purposes. By degrading Iran's conventional capabilities, the United States and Israel protect high-value assets such as the aircraft carrier USS Gerald R. Ford and other regional military deployments. In Warden's logic, the purpose of attacking this ring is not to win the war directly but to prevent interference while the inner rings are dismantled.

Strategic Synthesis: An Inside-Out Campaign Viewed through the lens of Warden's Five Rings theory, Operation Epic Fury appears to be a textbook example of inside-out strategic warfare. The campaign's sequencing leadership decapitation, infrastructure disruption, energy targeting, and selective military strikes aligns closely with Warden's model for achieving systemic paralysis. The ultimate objective is not the physical destruction of the Iranian military but the collapse of its operational coherence. If leadership cannot communicate effectively, if energy infrastructure cannot sustain military operations, and if logistical networks cannot connect command with execution, the state's war-fighting capacity deteriorates rapidly. Under such conditions, fielded forces may remain physically intact but strategically irrelevant. However, wars rarely remain static, and adversaries often adapt under pressure. Iran is unlikely to remain passive in the face of such systemic targeting. Historically, states subjected to decapitation and infrastructure strategies attempt to compensate through decentralisation, redundant command structures and asymmetric responses. Tehran could shift operational authority to regional military commands, empower IRGC units and proxy networks to act autonomously, or intensify cyber (highly unlikely) and missile operations designed to impose costs beyond the immediate battlefield. In this sense, war is also a learning process: as the campaign unfolds, both sides are likely to adjust their methods, testing the limits of Warden's theory in a real-world environment where adaptation, improvisation, and strategic resilience often shape the trajectory of conflict as much as initial doctrine.

Policy Implications - For policymakers, Operation Epic Fury illustrates both the potential effectiveness and the inherent risks of systemic warfare. The campaign demonstrates how modern airpower, cyber operations and precision strikes can be integrated to target the structural foundations of a state rather than its military formations alone. - However, the strategy also introduces significant uncertainty. Leadership decapitation can produce succession struggles rather than immediate strategic paralysis, while infrastructure disruption may generate humanitarian and economic consequences that complicate international support for the campaign. - Moreover, Iran retains significant asymmetric capabilities, including regional proxy networks and cyber warfare assets that could extend the conflict beyond its initial geographic boundaries. -

Understanding the logic of Warden's Five Rings is therefore essential not only for analysing the campaign itself but also for anticipating its potential regional and global consequences. - Lastly, Operation Epic Fury demonstrates that modern warfare is increasingly fought not on the battlefield's periphery, but at the strategic centre of gravity where leadership, systems and legitimacy intersect.

8. The Iran War Unraveling: Expanding Scope and Ambiguous Objectives

URL: <http://studies.aljazeera.net/en/policy-briefs/iran-war-unraveling-expanding-scope-and-ambiguous-objectives>

By the end of its first week, the war launched by the United States and Israel against Iran was expected to become clearer in its motivations, main developments and the objectives pursued by those leading it. Yet despite the constant sound of aircraft and missiles over the Middle East and scenes of widespread destruction, the war has instead become more ambiguous. Statements by senior officials in Washington have offered differing explanations regarding the reasons for the war, its duration and its ultimate objectives. In the early days of the conflict, US President Donald Trump gave several different estimates of how long the war might last. At one point, he suggested it would continue for only a few days or perhaps a week; at another, he indicated that it could extend four to five weeks; and on another occasion, he stated that the United States would continue fighting until its objectives were achieved. The administration initially justified the war by arguing that Iran represented a threat to US security and that Iranian negotiators had manipulated the course of negotiations during several rounds of talks concerning Iran's nuclear programme. However, Secretary of State Marco Rubio later stated that the United States had entered the war alongside Israel partly out of concern that Iranian retaliation against Israeli strikes could target American interests. Trump subsequently insisted that the decision to go to war had been entirely American and that the United States had drawn Israel into the conflict rather than the reverse. The war nevertheless reflects an unprecedented level of cooperation between the United States and Israel. Although Washington had provided military and intelligence support to Israel in earlier wars—including the conflicts of 1967 and 1973—and had conducted limited strikes during the brief Israeli campaign against Iran in June 2025, the current conflict represents the first time that the two countries have fought together in full operational partnership. Evidence suggests that the campaign had been jointly planned for months through extensive coordination between American and Israeli military leadership. Despite this close cooperation, the two allies do not appear to share identical views regarding the ultimate objectives of the war. According to statements by US officials, the main goals are to destroy Iran's missile systems and launch infrastructure, neutralise its naval capabilities, prevent the development of a military nuclear programme, and weaken Iran's ability to support allied armed groups in the region. US officials have also stated that establishing a democratic government in Iran is not among the war's objectives. Israel, however, has adopted a more expansive vision. Israeli leaders have openly called for the removal of the Iranian regime. According to regional sources, Israeli officials had indicated before the outbreak of hostilities that Iran would face a comprehensive war that would not end before either the overthrow of the Islamic Republic or the fragmentation of the Iranian state. Meanwhile, the war has expanded rapidly beyond Iran itself. Iranian leaders appear to have adopted a strategy that treats the conflict as a struggle for

national survival and seeks to raise the costs of war for the United States, Israel and the wider international system. Iranian missiles and drones have targeted not only Israel but also several neighbouring states hosting US forces, including Jordan, Saudi Arabia, Gulf states, Turkey and Azerbaijan. Although Iran maintains that these attacks target only American military sites, some strikes have affected airports, energy facilities, diplomatic missions and other infrastructure across the region. Other arenas of escalation have also emerged. Hezbollah opened hostilities along the Lebanese–Israeli border, launching attacks on northern Israel and engaging Israeli forces in southern Lebanon. Israel responded with extensive bombardment of Shiite areas in southern Lebanon and Beirut's southern suburbs and ordered evacuations from large parts of these districts. In Iraq, pro-Iranian armed groups mobilised in support of Tehran, while discussions have emerged regarding possible attempts by the United States and Israel to engage Iranian Kurdish armed groups based in northern Iraq. The economic consequences of the war have also become increasingly evident. Iran has effectively disrupted navigation in the Strait of Hormuz, a critical passage for global energy supplies through which a significant share of the world's oil and gas normally passes. Attacks on regional energy infrastructure—including oil fields, export terminals, pipelines and gas facilities—have forced interruptions in production across parts of the Gulf. Energy markets have reacted sharply, with natural gas prices in Europe rising significantly and oil prices increasing amid fears of prolonged disruption. Officials in the region warn that continued escalation could lead to a major global economic crisis. Despite the scale of US and Israeli airstrikes—reportedly striking thousands of targets including military bases, command facilities, infrastructure and energy installations—the Iranian state does not appear close to collapse. Reports indicate that daily life in major cities such as Tehran continues within the limits imposed by wartime conditions and that the institutions of the state remain present. Although the assassination of Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei in the opening strike was expected by some observers to destabilise the regime, this has not occurred. The Iranian political system is characterised by a distribution of power among multiple centres of authority, even though the Supreme Leader occupies a central position. Following the assassination, Iran moved toward the selection of a new Supreme Leader, Mojtaba Khamenei. Once the leadership structure is fully consolidated, decision-making within the system may become more coherent. While the new leader is associated with the conservative current within the regime and is expected to maintain the emphasis on national sovereignty and independence that characterised the previous leadership, Iran is not a suicidal state. For this reason, the future course of the war remains uncertain. Under certain circumstances, the United States could declare that the war has achieved its objectives by weakening Iran's military capabilities and then seek to end the conflict. At the same time, continued escalation remains possible if the war persists without clear signs of Iranian retreat or willingness to negotiate on new terms. After only one week, therefore, the defining feature of the war is not clarity but growing complexity. The conflict has expanded across multiple regional arenas and begun to affect the global economy. In such conditions, firm predictions about its eventual outcome remain difficult.

*This is a summary of a policy brief originally written in Arabic available [here](https://www.aljazeera.net/policy-briefs/iran-war-2020).

9. Blinding US Eyes in the Middle East

URL: <http://studies.aljazeera.net/en/analyses/blinding-us-eyes-middle-east>

The United States has long assessed Iran's missile arsenal as the central pillar of Tehran's military deterrence and offensive strike capability. Accordingly, Washington has pursued a range of measures to mitigate this threat. These efforts have included the transfer of specialised anti-ballistic missile defence systems to Arab partners and the development of an integrated regional air and missile defence architecture under the authority of United States Central Command. One component of this initiative involved plans to establish a joint command and control framework capable of integrating Israeli radar capabilities with the radar networks of several Arab states. Following Iran's employment of missile forces during Operation True Promise-1, Iranian planners appear to have recalibrated their operational approach in Operation True Promise-2. Rather than conducting a combined strike package involving suicide drones, cruise missiles and ballistic missiles, Iran reportedly emphasised a heavier reliance on ballistic missile strikes. This shift resulted in a substantially higher number of ballistic missile launches compared with the earlier operation. The change in operational emphasis was illustrated by the targeting of two major Israeli air bases, Nevatim Airbase and Tel Nof Airbase. In the aftermath of Operation True Promise-2, the United States sought to reinforce regional missile defence coverage. This reportedly included the attempted deployment of at least one Terminal High Altitude Area Defense (THAAD) battery to Israel. In parallel, US naval assets equipped with the Aegis Combat System—including destroyers of the Arleigh Burke class—were positioned along the eastern Mediterranean coast. These vessels possess the capability to intercept ballistic missiles using the Standard Missile series of interceptors. As regional tensions escalated further, Washington moved to expand its air and missile defence presence across the Middle East. In addition to the systems already deployed in several Arab states, these efforts reportedly included the stationing of a new THAAD battery in Jordan, alongside the deployment of an additional MIM-104 Patriot battery at Ovda Airbase in southern Israel. Prior to the initiation of US and Israeli military operations against Iran, Washington reportedly conducted extensive logistical and operational preparations. These activities included the large-scale redeployment of fighter squadrons and aerial refuelling tankers, as well as a significant increase in strategic airlift operations involving aircraft such as the Boeing C-17 Globemaster III and the Lockheed C-5 Galaxy. According to available information in the days leading up to the conflict, the US Air Force conducted more than 310 transport sorties from bases within the United States to European staging locations, including Ramstein Air Base and RAF Mildenhall. From these hubs, aircraft subsequently continued onward to operational bases across the Middle East, delivering personnel, equipment and logistical supplies. Particularly noteworthy are the origin bases of many of these flights, which reportedly included Fort Hood and Fort Bliss. Fort Hood hosts the 69th Air Defense Artillery Brigade, which operates Patriot air defence batteries. Meanwhile, Fort Bliss serves as the headquarters of the 32nd Army Air and Missile Defense Command, which oversees multiple Patriot batteries as well as several THAAD anti-ballistic missile batteries. The involvement of these installations suggests that the United States was transferring elements of its Patriot and THAAD missile defence architecture to the Middle East for forward deployment. Among the regional destinations for these transport flights, Jordan—alongside states such as Saudi Arabia, Qatar and United Arab Emirates—appears to have served as a major logistical hub. In particular, Muwaffaq Salti Air Base reportedly received the highest volume of US transport traffic, with approximately 150 to 170 sorties conducted to the facility in the period immediately preceding the conflict. Although the scale of these transport operations and their points of origin had already suggested a broader effort to reinforce regional missile defences, satellite imagery released on 20 February provided more concrete evidence. The imagery, captured over the southern sector of Muwaffaq Salti Air Base,

indicated that the United States had deployed a complete THAAD battery to Jordan. The deployment reportedly included six launch units, each equipped with eight interceptor launch tubes, an AN/TPY-2 detection and tracking radar, power-generation equipment required to operate the radar system, and a range of additional vehicles and support elements associated with the THAAD battery. The THAAD battery is designed to counter ballistic missile threats by intercepting incoming targets during the terminal phase of their trajectory. The system is capable of detecting and engaging ballistic missiles at ranges of up to approximately 200 kilometres, with interception occurring at altitudes between roughly 100 and 150 kilometres, typically outside the Earth's atmosphere. Engagement is carried out through the launch of Talon interceptor missiles, which employ hit-to-kill kinetic interception to neutralise the target. The United States remains the primary operator of the THAAD system and currently maintains an inventory of seven operational batteries. Beyond the United States, the United Arab Emirates became the first international customer of the system, procuring two THAAD batteries in 2008. Subsequently, Saudi Arabia emerged as the second foreign purchaser, signing an agreement in 2017 for the acquisition of seven THAAD batteries. In the UAE, the system has reached full operational status and is deployed at two primary locations: northern Abu Dhabi and the strategic coastal area of Al Ruwais. In Saudi Arabia, two out of the seven procured batteries have so far been delivered and deployed in operational configuration. These systems are reportedly positioned in two locations: one southeast of Riyadh and another south of Jeddah, forming part of the kingdom's expanding ballistic missile defence architecture. In addition to the deployment of layered air and missile defence systems across regional partner states, the United States also relies extensively on early-warning radar infrastructure to detect incoming missile threats and provide timely alerts to forward-deployed forces. These radar systems play a critical role in the missile defence architecture by enabling the early detection of launches, issuing warning notifications to bases and potential target areas, facilitating the rapid evacuation of personnel and sensitive equipment, and activating anti-ballistic missile defence systems. Such early-warning capability ensures that interceptor systems can engage incoming ballistic threats within the limited "golden window" of interception during the terminal phase of flight. Among the most advanced assets within this early-warning architecture is the AN/FPS-132 early-warning radar. In 2013, Qatar purchased this system from the United States in a deal valued at approximately \$1.1 billion, which also included associated communications equipment, encryption systems and additional support infrastructure. Construction and installation of the radar site were ultimately completed in 2019, when the facility became fully operational in the Wadi al-Dehool region of Qatar. The AN/FPS-132 radar installation consists of three fixed radar arrays, each providing 120-degree coverage, collectively enabling a 360-degree surveillance envelope around the site. Operating in the UHF frequency band, the system is designed for long-range strategic surveillance, allowing it to detect and track a wide range of objects. These include ballistic missiles, intercontinental ballistic missiles (ICBMs), space launch vehicles, satellites and other space objects at distances reaching approximately 5,000 kilometres. The United States Missile Early-warning Network constitutes a multi-layered and integrated architecture that combines several complementary detection and tracking systems. This framework incorporates infrared reconnaissance satellites, long-range ground-based early-warning radars, land- and sea-based radar and missile defence systems, as well as dedicated command and control centres. The primary objective of this network is the rapid detection and assessment of ballistic missile launches directed toward the United States. Once a launch is detected, the system is designed to track the missile, determine its trajectory and flight profile, estimate the potential impact point, and promptly notify

military command authorities so that appropriate defensive measures or retaliatory responses can be initiated. Operational oversight of this early-warning architecture is primarily conducted by several key US military organisations, including the United States Space Force, United States Strategic Command, North American Aerospace Defense Command and the Missile Defense Agency. Within this command structure, the system can also provide early-warning information to allied or partner states. Under certain operational circumstances, such capabilities may also be used to issue alerts to Israel regarding potential missile threats originating from Iran, enabling Israeli defence systems to prepare for possible ballistic missile attacks. Therefore, targeting and disabling key nodes within this architecture could significantly degrade the effectiveness of the broader missile early-warning network and reduce the reaction time available to allied defence systems. In fact, strikes against forward-deployed ground-based radar installations located in close proximity to Iran could disrupt the early detection chain that provides warning data to regional partners, including Israel. Among the most important components of this forward sensor layer are long-range ground-based early-warning radars positioned in countries surrounding Iran. These include systems such as the AN/FPS-132 early-warning radar deployed in Qatar, as well as the AN/TPY-2 radar associated with the THAAD deployed in several neighbouring states. Once launch detection is achieved and the collected data is verified, the system proceeds to determine the approximate flight trajectory and estimate the likely impact area of the incoming ballistic missile. The processed tracking data is then transmitted to various anti-ballistic missile defence systems positioned along the missile's projected flight path. This dissemination of information enables those systems to prepare and, if feasible, initiate interception procedures during either the midcourse phase or the terminal phase of the missile's trajectory. A number of missile defence systems can operate within the broader framework of the United States early-warning network, relying on the sensor and tracking data provided by this architecture to intercept incoming ballistic threats. Among these systems is the MIM-104 Patriot, which is capable of engaging ballistic targets during the terminal phase of flight within the atmosphere using the PAC-3 interceptor missiles. Another key component is the THAAD, designed to intercept ballistic missiles in the terminal phase outside the atmosphere through the use of Talon interceptor missiles. Naval-based interception capabilities are provided by the Aegis Combat System. This system can engage incoming threats during the terminal phase within the atmosphere using Standard Missile 2 and Standard Missile 3 defensive missiles, while the SM-3 interceptor can also be employed during the midcourse phase outside the atmosphere. In addition, the Ground-Based Midcourse Defense system was specifically developed to intercept long-range ballistic missile attacks directed toward the United States. Collectively, these systems can function as layered defensive elements under the umbrella of the US missile early-warning and tracking network. Because the information generated by this early-warning architecture can also be shared with allied defence systems, several Israeli missile defence platforms may similarly operate within its broader detection and tracking framework. These include the Arrow 2 interceptor, designed to engage ballistic targets within the atmosphere; the Arrow 3 system, optimised for exo-atmospheric interception; and the newer Arrow 4, intended to engage ballistic targets both inside and outside the atmosphere. In addition, the David's Sling air defence system can also form part of the operational defensive architecture that benefits from early-warning data generated by this network. Within the US missile early-warning architecture, the initial detection of ballistic missile launches is primarily conducted through a network of infrared reconnaissance satellites. This space-based system—known as the Space-Based Infrared System—operates in both geosynchronous (GEO) and highly elliptical (HEO) orbits. The satellites are equipped with infrared

(IR) sensors designed to detect the intense thermal signature produced by ballistic missile propulsion immediately after launch. At this stage, once a ballistic missile launch occurs, these reconnaissance satellites generate the first alert within the US early-warning network. The initial data transmitted typically includes information such as the approximate launch location, launch time, and a preliminary assessment of the missile category—for example, whether the launch involves a short-range, intermediate-range or intercontinental ballistic missile. Following this initial detection, the data provided by the satellite network is further analysed and correlated with observations from ground-based and sea-based early-warning sensors. It is at this stage that the importance of long-range early-warning radars becomes particularly evident. This radar network—comprising systems such as the AN/FPS-132 early-warning radar, the AN/FPS-123 radar, and the AN/TPY-2 radar associated with the THAAD—is responsible for calculating a more precise flight trajectory once the satellite-derived data has been verified. Using radar tracking data, these systems determine a refined flight profile for the launched missile and estimate its probable impact area. This information is subsequently transmitted back to the broader early-warning network for operational assessment. Based on these calculations, authorities can decide whether to initiate evacuation procedures in the predicted impact area. The response may vary depending on whether the projected target location lies within a civilian population centre or a military installation, but in either case, the goal is to relocate personnel and sensitive equipment as rapidly as possible before impact. However, this process becomes significantly more complex when dealing with hypersonic glide vehicles (HGVs). Unlike traditional ballistic warheads, HGVs are capable of manoeuvring at relatively low altitudes during the midcourse and terminal phases of flight. Such manoeuvrability complicates the task of estimating the missile's trajectory and determining its final impact point, potentially degrading the accuracy of predictive models and, in worst-case scenarios, disrupting the early-warning and interception process altogether. At present, the core network of US early-warning radars is distributed across multiple strategic locations worldwide. These include installations in Alaska, Greenland, the United Kingdom, California, Japan, South Korea and Qatar. In addition to these fixed installations, the network also incorporates sea-based radar platforms, including floating X-band radar systems positioned primarily in the Atlantic Ocean to expand long-range detection coverage. Once the detection, verification and trajectory estimation stages are completed, the processed data is transmitted to key command and operational centres, including the Missile Defense Agency, United States Strategic Command, and the North American Aerospace Defense Command. Following the outbreak of the US–Israeli conflict with Iran, anti-ballistic missile defence systems and early-warning radar installations emerged as critical strategic targets from Iran's perspective. Disrupting or disabling these assets—particularly those deployed across the Middle East—could significantly reduce the regional early-warning capability of the United States, shorten the reaction time available to missile defence systems, and thereby increase the probability that ballistic missiles could penetrate defensive layers and reach their intended targets. IRGC's first step: Attacking an AN/FPS-132 early-warning radar in Qatar Iran's first reported action against US radar and missile defence infrastructure in the region occurred on the opening day of the conflict. On the afternoon of Saturday, 28 February 2026, the public relations office of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps announced that Iranian forces had conducted a missile strike targeting the AN/FPS-132 early-warning radar installation located in Qatar. According to satellite imagery released on 3 March, the strike reportedly focused on the northern sector of the radar installation. This section of the facility is associated with the radar array responsible for monitoring the northern coverage sector, including airspace in the direction of Iran. IRGC's second step: Attacking an

AN/TPY-2 radar at the THAAD defence site in Al Ruwais and Abu Dhabi, UAE Iran's second operational step within this strategy involved targeting US-aligned anti-ballistic missile defence infrastructure across the region. In the initial phase of these strikes, Iranian forces reportedly targeted the launch facilities associated with the THAAD battery deployed in the UAE, specifically at defence sites located in Al Ruwais and Abu Dhabi. According to satellite imagery released by the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC), the strikes focused on the AN/TPY-2 detection and tracking radar associated with the THAAD system at both locations, as well as related support infrastructure at those sites. The AN/TPY-2 radar serves as the primary sensor responsible for detecting and tracking ballistic targets and guiding interceptor engagements within the THAAD architecture. In addition, The New York Times reported on 3 March, in an article titled "Iran Strikes U.S. Military Communication Infrastructure in Mideast," that the AN/TPY-2 radar at one of these defence installations had been destroyed, citing satellite imagery of the site as supporting evidence.

(1) IRGC's third step: Attacking the AN/TPY-2 radar at the THAAD defence site in Riyadh, Saudi Arabia The next step in the IRGC's strategy aimed at degrading US-aligned radar and anti-ballistic missile defence infrastructure in the region involved an attack on a THAAD site located southeast of Riyadh, near Prince Sultan Air Base in Saudi Arabia. According to a statement issued by the IRGC's public relations office on Tuesday, 3 March, Iranian forces conducted what was described as a second operation targeting THAAD systems in West Asia, focusing on a THAAD battery deployed in the Riyadh area. Subsequent satellite imagery of the defence installation indicated that the strike followed a pattern similar to the earlier attack attributed to Iran against the THAAD site at Al Ruwais in the UAE. The imagery suggested that the attack concentrated on the location of the AN/TPY-2 radar—the primary detection and tracking radar of the THAAD system—as well as associated support and operational infrastructure at the site.

IRGC's fourth step: Attacking the AN/TPY-2 radar of the THAAD defence site located at the Muwaffaq Salti Air Base in Jordan On Wednesday, 4 March, newly released satellite imagery of the recently deployed THAAD site in the southern sector of Muwaffaq Salti Air Base in Jordan suggested that the IRGC had likely targeted the AN/TPY-2 radar associated with the installation. This action appears to represent the next step in Iran's broader effort to degrade or blind US anti-ballistic missile radar coverage across the West Asia region. The imagery indicates that Iranian forces were able to identify the location of the defence site shortly after its deployment in Jordan, enabling them to conduct a strike aimed at the probable radar position within the THAAD battery during the early stages of the conflict. This suggests a capability to rapidly detect newly deployed missile defence infrastructure and prioritise it as a high-value target within the regional missile defence architecture. A key issue in assessing the targeting of THAAD-associated radars concerns the relatively limited number of AN/TPY-2 radar units produced to date. Based on available information, at least 16 AN/TPY-2 detection and tracking radars have reportedly been manufactured for operational deployment within the THAAD architecture. Of these, 13 units are allocated to the US Army for use in its missile defence forces, supporting 7 to 8 operational THAAD batteries along with a number of reserve radar systems. In addition, two radars were produced for the two THAAD batteries acquired by the UAE, while seven radars were intended for the seven THAAD batteries purchased by Saudi Arabia. Satellite imagery indicates that two of the seven radars acquired by Saudi Arabia have so far been delivered and deployed within the country. Technically, the AN/TPY-2 radar is a highly sophisticated active phased-array radar comprising approximately 25,344 individual transmit/receive elements and operating in the X-band frequency range. This radar is designed to detect, track and discriminate ballistic missile threats at distances and altitudes ranging roughly from 1,000 to 3,000 kilometres,

providing the sensor backbone required for THAAD interception operations. According to 2025 budget documentation released by the Missile Defense Agency, the estimated cost of producing a single AN/TPY-2 radar for the THAAD system can reach up to \$500 million. This figure reflects both the technological sophistication of the radar and the complexity involved in its manufacturing process. Consequently, the destruction or disabling of such systems during a conflict could impose significant operational and financial costs, potentially degrading the effectiveness of THAAD deployments within the broader US missile defence architecture. An important point to consider is that, although the radar and missile defence systems in question were formally purchased by Arab states from the United States and deployed within their territories, the strategic purpose of these systems extends beyond the immediate security requirements of the host countries. In practice, these assets appear to have been positioned primarily to support the broader security architecture of the United States, while also contributing to the defence posture of Israel within the region. Despite the substantial financial resources expended by several Gulf states on the acquisition and operation of these radar and missile defence systems, their deployment also supports broader US strategic objectives in the region. These include protecting US forces and military installations, safeguarding major oil and energy transportation routes, and strengthening the regional missile defence architecture. From this perspective, the geographic placement of these systems reflects a strategic calculus in which Gulf states play an important role within a broader US-led missile defence network. In the event of a regional conflict—such as the confrontation described here—this positioning could increase the risk that their territory and critical infrastructure may be exposed to retaliatory strikes due to their integration within the wider defence architecture.” Indeed, based on the imagery and information that have emerged during the conflict, several of these radar and missile defence installations appear to have been directly targeted during coordinated Iranian strikes, reportedly involving a combination of ballistic missiles and loitering munitions. The attacks suggest that these sites—despite their advanced defensive capabilities—became high-priority targets within Iran’s broader operational strategy aimed at degrading the regional missile defence network. Devon Lum, Haley Willis and Riley Mellen, “Iran Strikes U.S. Military Communication Infrastructure in Mideast”, The New York Times, 3 March 2026, <https://tinyurl.com/mv396unx> (accessed 9 March 2026).

10. Strategic Escalation and Conflict Sustainability in the US-Iran War

URL: <http://studies.aljazeera.net/en/analyses/strategic-escalation-and-conflict-sustainability-us-iran-war>

On the morning of Saturday, 28 February 2026, the United States, in coordination with Israel, commenced a military operation against the Islamic Republic of Iran. This offensive, launched immediately after the completion of US regional military deployment, was swiftly met with a substantial retaliatory strike by Iran’s Armed Forces against American military assets throughout the Middle East. The confrontation remains ongoing, with no clear outcome in sight. The central strategic question now is: how will this conflict ultimately be resolved? At approximately at 09:40 Iran Standard Time, a large plume of smoke rose above the Iranian capital. This initial blast, closely followed by a series of secondary explosions, occurred within the precinct of governmental offices.

By 10:00, reports indicated nearly 30 separate detonations across the city. The initial wave of coordinated US–Israeli strikes targeted key governance centres in Tehran rather than conventional military installations—a decision of clear strategic significance. In Iran, where Saturday marks the first working day of the week, senior officials are typically present in administrative and ministerial offices to set the agenda for the days ahead. The initial assault wave comprised Tomahawk cruise missiles launched from US naval assets in the Mediterranean, supported by fighter aircraft. The strikes were calibrated to disrupt the governing apparatus through the targeted elimination of senior political and military leadership. Among the reported high-value targets were facilities associated with the Judiciary, the Ministry of Defence, the Ministry of Intelligence, the Presidency, as well as the primary residence and political office of Iran's Supreme Leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei. According to The New York Times, the CIA had obtained intelligence indicating that a plenary meeting of senior Iranian officials was scheduled to convene that Saturday morning within a central government complex in Tehran. Assessments suggested the presence of senior defence officials alongside other key decision-makers. The gathering was reportedly held within a compound housing the Presidency, the Supreme Leader's Office and the Supreme National Security Council. Consequently, US and Israeli commanders, having initially planned to launch the operation under cover of darkness, recalibrated the timing to exploit intelligence that Iran's senior leadership would be gathered that Saturday morning. Approximately two hours after fighter aircraft were airborne—striking at roughly 09:40 Iran Standard Time—the coordinated long-range munitions impacted the targeted government compound. Tehran's apparent failure to enforce stringent security protocols reportedly resulted in the deaths of several senior officials during the joint Defence Council session. Among those identified were Major General Seyyed Abdolrahim Mousavi, Chief of Staff of the Armed Forces; Major General Mohammad Pakpour, Commander-in-Chief of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps; Ali Shamkhani, Advisor to the Supreme Commander-in-Chief; and Defence Minister Aziz Nasirzadeh. Reports further indicated that Ayatollah Khamenei, along with several members of his family, was also martyred. Despite the US expectation of structural collapse, Iran's defensive military operations commenced immediately, and the political leadership continued to function. A key factor in preventing the paralysis of Tehran was the failure to eliminate the President and the Speaker of the Parliament. It is also notable that senior political and military officials had predesignated successors, ensuring continuity of command. Governance in Tehran is proceeding along its established constitutional framework. At the highest level, Article 111 of the Iranian Constitution stipulates that in the event of the Supreme Leader's death, resignation or dismissal, an interim council—comprising the President, the Head of the Judiciary and a representative of the Guardian Council—assumes temporary authority until a new Leader is selected.

Command Structure and Operational Autonomy While the Iranian Armed Forces—comprising the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) and the Islamic Republic of Iran Army (Artesh)—retain a conventional hierarchical command structure, their operational posture has shifted significantly. In accordance with pre-established contingency plans, units are now operating on a regional and decentralised basis, engaging designated targets with considerable autonomy. The response has unfolded through a coordinated, multi-domain campaign integrating rocket artillery, ballistic and cruise missiles, loitering munitions (drones) and fighter aircraft. Notably, the scope of the strikes extends beyond Israeli targets to include US military installations across the Middle East. The character of the US–Israeli offensive represents a marked departure from previous conflict paradigms. The campaign has extended beyond the suppression of air defences and the neutralisation of missile infrastructure to include naval bases, army garrisons, border command

centres, police facilities and—most notably—state administrative buildings. The prioritisation of governance infrastructure in Tehran ahead of conventional military targets suggests a calculated strategic shift: the deliberate creation of a governance, security and command vacuum. This approach diverges from earlier public justifications by US officials, which emphasised Tehran's nuclear and ballistic missile programmes. The central strategic question therefore remains: how long can this operational tempo be sustained, and does time inherently favour the coalition? Preliminary assessments point to an unprecedented intensity of fire. Within the first 24 hours of the conflict, the US–Israeli coalition reportedly expended approximately 2,250 air-delivered munitions—1,200 from Israeli assets and 1,050 from US assets. The scale becomes clearer in comparative context. During last year's 12-Day War, roughly 4,300 munitions were used against more than 1,000 targets—an average of approximately 360 per day. By contrast, the first 24 hours of the current campaign alone account for more than half (approximately 52 percent) of the total munitions expended during that twelve-day conflict, and represent nearly four times its previous daily average. To sustain this volume of strikes, the number of US–Israeli aircraft deployed in the region has reportedly increased by more than 200 percent compared to the 12-Day War, reaching approximately 700 platforms. Such a concentration of airpower, however, demands large-scale operational coordination and substantial logistical support. While prepositioned assets and initial preparations may enable the coalition to maintain this tempo for up to two weeks, a protracted campaign would likely generate significant logistical strain on the US Air Force and Navy, with escalating financial and operational costs. The US Navy currently deploys at least 14 Arleigh Burke-class guided-missile destroyers in the region, some operating independently and others assigned to escort the Abraham Lincoln and Gerald R. Ford carrier strike groups. Assuming a standard vertical launch system (VLS) configuration—carrying a mix of Standard surface-to-air missiles and Tomahawk land-attack cruise missiles, with an estimated 40 Tomahawks per destroyer—and factoring in at least one Ohio-class guided-missile submarine, the Navy's available inventory of long-range cruise missiles likely exceeds 700. A substantial portion of this stockpile has reportedly already been expended. Reconstituting the strike capacity of these platforms requires reloading VLS cells, a process that must generally be conducted in port. The rotational withdrawal of destroyers to secure deep-water facilities, such as Diego Garcia, would therefore introduce operational gaps of three to five days in a carrier strike group's offensive output. Moreover, sustained strikes against fixed infrastructure are likely to produce diminishing operational returns over time. Even the destruction of designated targets would not necessarily compel Iranian capitulation. Instead, Tehran may shift toward a lower-volume but persistent campaign of asymmetric drone and missile strikes, imposing cumulative risk and forcing the United States into progressively higher-exposure operational postures. Decentralised Resistance and Asymmetric Capabilities Iran appears to be pursuing a strategy calibrated to account for the relative strengths and weaknesses of its adversaries. A central component of this approach is the delegation of decision-making authority to operational units across the country. This decentralisation preserves continuity of resistance even in the event of severe decapitation strikes against senior leadership. At the same time, it complicates the adversary's targeting process by reducing reliance on centralised command nodes. The objective is not to maximise strike volume, but to sustain a resilient and enduring campaign of attrition. Within 48 hours, Tehran reportedly launched more than 1,500 projectiles against US and Israeli targets, framing the response as fulfilment of the Supreme Leader's pledge to regionalise any military confrontation with Iran. The geographically dispersed nature of the strikes drew multiple states into the operational environment. Reports indicate ballistic

missile, cruise missile and loitering munition attacks against facilities in the United Arab Emirates, Kuwait, Qatar, Iraq, Saudi Arabia, Syria, Oman and Cyprus. Among the reported targets were the US Fifth Fleet headquarters in Bahrain, a US air base in Erbil, the Port of Salman in Bahrain, Al Salman Air Base in Kuwait, and the Port of Jebel Ali in Dubai. The scale and complexity of these operations have already produced measurable US losses. According to official statements, three US F-15E Strike Eagle aircraft were destroyed in Kuwait in a friendly-fire incident amid a congested air defence environment. In addition, the AN/FPS-132 early-warning radar in Qatar—part of the United States' global missile defence architecture—reportedly sustained significant damage. The Pentagon has confirmed at least four US military casualties. Regional Energy Security and Economic Warfare

Conversely, Tehran appears to be preparing for a protracted campaign spanning several months. Its most consequential lever in this theatre is the potential disruption of the global energy market. Following the reopening of financial markets, Brent crude rose to approximately \$80 per barrel, with further volatility likely. The IRGC Navy has imposed heightened transit controls in the Strait of Hormuz, leaving at least 150 vessels awaiting clearance. Visual evidence suggests that unauthorised vessels attempting transit have been targeted. To date, there have been no confirmed direct strikes against major oil and gas infrastructure in Arab states; reported damage appears largely attributable to air defence debris. Tehran has publicly denied any intention to target Saudi energy facilities, while warning that attacks on its own energy infrastructure or efforts to enforce a naval blockade would trigger proportional retaliation. In response, several oil and gas firms in Saudi Arabia, Qatar and Kuwait have reportedly suspended or curtailed operations as a precaution, contributing to upward pressure on global energy markets, including rising natural gas prices in Europe. Continued instability—combined with airspace closures and rerouted commercial traffic—would likely intensify market strain. While Washington may seek to mitigate short-term price spikes through Venezuelan supply and existing tanker inventories, replacing the medium- to long-term export capacity of the Gulf would be exceedingly difficult. The continuation of these hostilities threatens to inflate the financial overhead of military operations for the United States well beyond initial projections. The core issue is not a lack of US military capability, but rather that protracted conflict in the Middle East no longer aligns with long-term American national security priorities. This sentiment was notably echoed by Donald Trump during his initial presidential term, where he levelled trenchant criticisms against the Middle East policies of preceding US administrations. Such prolonged engagement risks exacerbating bipartisan political opposition in Washington while simultaneously degrading operational military readiness—capabilities analysts argue would be more optimally allocated to great-power competition with China. Key concerns for the US military centre on the finite inventories of Tomahawk cruise missiles, precision-guided air-launched munitions and anti-ballistic missile defence systems, all of which must be preserved to deter threats across Eastern Europe and East Asia.

US Operational Tempo vs. Iranian Strategy

Conflicting reports have emerged regarding alleged ceasefire requests initiated by the United States via intermediaries, even as American aerial strikes continue to concentrate on the Iranian capital to intensify pressure on the political leadership. Tehran has discerned a predictable pattern in current US behaviour: a preference for short, high-intensity kinetic campaigns followed by mid-cycle armistices. This cycle, potentially extending through the remainder of the incumbent presidential term and beyond, steers Iran toward a war of attrition intended to precipitate systemic collapse. The US understands that failure to compel Tehran to negotiate and concede under military duress will necessitate entry into a campaign of indeterminate duration. Efforts to secure the participation of European and Arab allies, particularly Saudi Arabia, in an anti-Iran coalition are understandable

within this framework. Given Israel's insistence on regime change, achieving an agreement that incorporates all US preconditions—which effectively constitute a document of capitulation—remains the optimal outcome for Washington. To secure such a settlement, the US may escalate targeted assassinations and increase the intensity of strikes. However, time is working against this objective.

Internal Instability The United States' secondary contingency plan, should the aerial campaign fail to achieve its objectives, involves fomenting significant internal disorder within Iran over the next two years. The repeated aerial targeting of police facilities, border outposts, border guard units and ground force assets substantiates this objective. Disrupting internal and border monitoring capabilities is designed to create corridors for the activation of armed terrorist cells, particularly given the tangible presence of anti-Iranian separatist groups in the Kurdistan Region of Iraq and extremist factions along the Pakistan border.

The Optimal Calculus In direct contrast to U.S. objectives, Tehran's preferred outcome may be the prolongation of the conflict. Although Iran would likely incur substantial material and human costs, sustaining a limited but persistent engagement—even over a two-to-four-week period—could impose disproportionate political and economic pressure on Washington. Financial strain on Arab states—including collateral damage in urban centres resulting from missile interceptions, degradation of shared military infrastructure such as joint-use airfields, and revenue losses across tourism, hospitality and aviation—may compound regional pressure on the United States. Over time, such cumulative costs could incentivise a reassessment of current American force posture. From this perspective, any unilateral ceasefire proposal lacking clear and reciprocal commitments from all principal parties would carry limited strategic value. The conflict appears to have crossed thresholds that Iranian decision-makers may interpret as existential, reducing the likelihood of de-escalation absent tangible guarantees.

The Danger of Impasse The situation would escalate significantly if neither side demonstrates flexibility. In response to Iran's apparent strategy of attrition, the United States could increase its risk tolerance and strike intensity in an effort to alter the trajectory of the conflict. Such escalation might aim either to compel a rapid return to negotiations or to generate internal political pressure within Iran. Potential pathways could include expanded strikes against dual-use facilities in major urban centres, including the capital and key provincial hubs; intensified targeting of senior political leadership; or, most consequentially, attacks on critical infrastructure such as power grids, industrial complexes, financial institutions and energy and refining facilities.

11. Reviving India-Oman Relations: Strategic Cooperation and Economic Integration

URL: <http://studies.aljazeera.net/en/analyses/reviving-india-oman-relations-strategic-cooperation-and-economic-integration>

India and Oman share a long history and 70 years of formal diplomatic ties, a partnership now underpinned by significant contemporary alignment. The durability of this partnership was highlighted by Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi's official visit to Muscat on 17-18 December 2025, an event that aimed to strengthen bilateral cooperation and reaffirm India's ongoing involvement in the strategically significant Gulf region. Today, this cooperation is reflected in well-developed economic relations, cooperation on energy issues, defence partnerships, and joint investments in connectivity and technology, all rooted in a long-standing historical past. This modern framework finds its roots in ancient interactions, where maritime trade and cultural exchanges first established the lasting ties between the two peoples. Historically, the coasts controlled by Oman, which ruled over a vast geographical area from the Arabian Peninsula to the East African shores, served as a strategic gateway passage for Indian traders. These interactions were highly instrumental for the establishment of strong ties between the peoples of the two countries. Consequently, an Indian diaspora has maintained its presence in Oman from those times to the present day. In the period following the establishment of modern diplomatic relations in 1955, the Indian diaspora in Oman strengthened its presence in social and economic life and strongly contributed to the formation of modern Omani state. Spanning centuries and sustained into the present, these social interactions bind the Omani and Indian peoples more closely than the traditional notion of diaspora allows. Indeed, there are people of Indian origin who came to Oman hundreds of years ago and became citizens of the country, as well as Indians who have received exceptional citizenship in the modern era due to their success in the business world or their contributions to the country. Owing to its traditionally liberal and inclusive policies, Oman hosts one of the largest communities of Indian-origin citizens in the Gulf. An estimated 10,000 Omani citizens are of Indian origin. In addition, approximately 686,635 Indian nationals reside in the country, playing a central role in the workforce and reinforcing bilateral economic and cultural ties. (1) Omani families of Indian origin have become major players in the country's economy by establishing large companies. One such family, the Khimjis, arrived in Oman from India in the 1870s and has maintained its presence in the country to this day. Besides contributing to the national economy, the Khimji family has also made significant investments in promoting cricket, a major socio-cultural activity in India, in Oman. (2) Another influential Indian-origin family in Oman's economic landscape is the Menon family. Puthan Menon, born in Kerala, India, came to Oman in 1976 and began operating primarily in the construction and real estate sectors. According to Forbes magazine, Menon, the richest person in Oman, has a fortune of \$4.6 billion. Alongside leading businessmen, the Indian diaspora in Oman also contributes significantly to the skilled workforce. (3) Human-centred cooperation between the two countries forms the foundation of their economic and strategic partnership. Indian labour is particularly prominent in sectors such as education, finance, and healthcare. The healthcare sector, in particular, has seen significant Indian participation, both through skilled professionals and through investment. Indian investors own some of Oman's largest hospital networks, including Badr Al Sama, as well as several of the country's leading private healthcare institutions, such as Aster Al Raffah, (4) Apollo Hospitals, (5) and KIMSHEALTH. (6) These investments aim to strengthen Oman's healthcare infrastructure while also transforming the

country into a regional healthcare tourism hub. Meanwhile, while Indian doctors and nurses continue to be employed in Oman, the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) is poised to stimulate new investments in select strategic sectors, notably the healthcare industry. Under CEPA's professional mobility provisions, the ceiling for intra-company transferees (ICTs) employed by Indian companies operating in Oman has been raised from 20% to 50%, enabling greater deployment of managerial and specialist staff. (7) Furthermore, the agreement facilitates the potential for Indian enterprises to engage in 100% foreign direct investment within key service sectors in Oman through commercial presence. (8) The Strategic Importance of Modi's Visit to Oman These areas of cooperation and the potential for further collaboration formed the basis of the Indian Prime Minister's visit. In this regard, Modi's visit aimed to strengthen and modernise the existing strategic partnership between the two countries, adapting it to the requirements of a new era marked by growing regional and global uncertainty. Above all, Oman is of paramount importance due to its strategic geographic position. It plays a critical role in the security of the Strait of Hormuz, through which a substantial share of global oil trade and India's energy imports pass. In a region marked by conflict and instability, Oman remains an indispensable and reliable partner for India's energy security. Oman's strategic value strengthens India's presence in the Western Indian Ocean and supports its broader ambitions to expand trade and transit corridors toward Iran and Central Asia. As a gateway to East Africa and Southeast Asia via the Indian Ocean, Oman also provides access to Iran and the Central Asian republics through maritime routes linking the Strait of Hormuz and the Gulf of Oman to onward overland corridors. (9) For India, Oman is a dependable ally that safeguards its commercial and security interests in these regions and can act as a counterweight to China's expanding role in the area. Indeed, India also seeks to strengthen its relations with Oman in order to counterbalance China, which it views as a strategic rival in the Indian Ocean. In recent years, China has adopted a more assertive regional policy and has deepened its engagement with Oman. (10) For instance, Oman's participation in the Belt and Road Initiative – China's modern Silk Road project – has been a sign of Beijing's growing influence in Muscat. This has encouraged India to re-examine its relations with Oman and implement a stronger cooperation agenda. At this point, Modi's visit can also be seen as a new step in the process of defining a role for Oman in the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor project, also known as IMEC, proposed by India during the G20 summit in 2023. A report published on 9 July 2025 by the National Maritime Foundation, based in New Delhi and supported by both the Ministry of Defence and the Indian Navy, emphasised the strategic importance of Oman's participation in the IMEC project and stated that such a development would significantly strengthen the project, particularly the Eastern Corridor. (11) Within the wider geopolitical landscape of the Gulf, Oman's neutral and mediating foreign policy gives it a particular role. By maintaining close relations with Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates while sustaining open channels with Iran, Oman plays a bridging and mediating role amid regional tensions. This position enables India to leverage its partnership with Oman in managing relations with other regional actors, including Iran and Saudi Arabia. This makes Oman a secure and stable anchor point at the heart of India's multifaceted regional diplomacy. The strategic significance of the relationship is reciprocal. For Oman, India represents a reliable and economically significant partner, particularly in supporting diversification beyond hydrocarbon trade. This growing alignment is reflected in rising bilateral trade, which reached \$10.61 billion in fiscal year 2024–25, up from \$8.95 billion the previous year. The increase was driven largely by expanded energy trade and the growth of non-oil commercial activity. Oman ranked as India's 29th largest export destination and 25th largest source of imports in 2024–25. Conversely, India was Oman's

fourth largest supplier of non-oil imports and its third largest market for non-oil exports during the same period. (12) Within the framework of Oman's national development strategy, Vision 2040, expanding partnerships with India aligns closely with Muscat's economic priorities, particularly in technology, renewable energy, healthcare, education, and small and medium-sized enterprise (SME) development. Given the long-standing presence of a large Indian community, Oman is likely to sustain and further institutionalise cooperation with India in addressing its demand for skilled human capital. Free Trade Agreement and Economic Integration Against this backdrop, the visit led to the finalisation of agreements in numerous areas aimed at strengthening relations between the two countries. The India-Oman Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA), intended to enhance economic ties, seeks to reduce trade barriers, facilitate investment flows, and expand cooperation in various critical sectors that matter to both parties. Negotiations for the CEPA began in November 2023 and continued for nearly two years. Prior to Modi's visit, Oman's Shura Council approved the agreement – an essential step for its entry into force – followed by approval from the Indian cabinet. (14) The agreement was formally signed by the leaders of both countries during the visit, making Oman the second Gulf state, after the UAE, to conclude a Free Trade Agreement with India. (15) Therefore, this agreement places Oman in an important position in India's economic diplomacy and lays the groundwork for the development of trade relations between the two countries on an institutional and sustainable basis. From this perspective, the India-Oman Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement is expected to elevate the trade relations between the two countries to another level. The agreement's significant reduction in customs tariffs and the elimination of technical barriers to unlock trade potential is expected to have a positive effect on India's exports to Oman, particularly in the sectors such as textile, pharmaceuticals, automotive parts and ready-made clothing. In addition, areas such as the digital economy and tourism emerge as new avenues of cooperation. It is anticipated that Indian technology firms will play a role in Oman's digital infrastructure transformation, while Oman will revitalise its health and cultural tourism sectors, which are significant markets in India. The positive momentum generated by the CEPA will also further develop ongoing investment projects. In this context, India's presence in Oman's strategic Duqm Port and Special Economic Zone is of great importance. Adani Group and other Indian consortia are involved in infrastructure investments related to the port. These projects have the potential to secure India's energy logistics while transforming Oman into a re-export and manufacturing hub in the Indian Ocean. Defence Cooperation and Strategic Partnership Military cooperation and the defence industry represent another key pillar of the India–Oman strategic partnership. Defence and security cooperation between India and Oman is vital, especially for the stability of the western side of the Indian Ocean. (16) The signing of a defence industry cooperation agreement during Sultan Haitham bin Tariq's visit to India in 2023 marked a significant step forward in bilateral security relations. Since then, interactions between the two countries' naval forces have intensified noticeably. In particular, the joint naval exercises, Naseem al-Bahr, have gained greater strategic relevance as maritime cooperation deepens. These exercises include search and rescue, anti-piracy operations, encounter procedures and joint patrol activities in critical areas. (17) The main objective of the exercises is to maximise operational compatibility and interoperability between the two navies, thereby guaranteeing the security and free navigation of critical maritime trade routes, including the Strait of Hormuz. There is also significant potential for partnership between India and Oman in maritime security and port access. Particularly in recent years, heightened risk in the Strait of Hormuz – along with sanctions imposed on Iran's energy exports and maritime logistics that have affected shipping, insurance and regional supply chains – has made Duqm, Oman's

Indian Ocean port, a far more strategic node for India. India, intensifying its efforts in this area, began operations at the Duqm port following a defence pact between the two countries in 2018. (18) Cooperation in the defence industry has moved beyond framework agreements to include concrete joint initiatives. Current efforts focus on maritime surveillance systems, coastal patrol vessels, and the development of maintenance and repair facilities. In addition, Indian defence firms are negotiating joint production and R&D agreements with Oman in areas such as medium-range air defence systems, unmanned aerial vehicle (UAV) technology transfer and cybersecurity. (19) This strengthens Oman's domestic defence capabilities while enabling India to gain a regional partner in a strategic sector. Another aspect of security cooperation security is counter-terrorism and intelligence sharing. The security institutions of both countries maintain ongoing information sharing, particularly in illicit security-related areas. (20) Shared concerns such as instability in Yemen and the threat of piracy in the Horn of Africa make this cooperation even more necessary. Institutionalised security engagement between Omani and Indian official institutions contribute proactively to regional security by coordinating threat assessments. (21) This multifaceted military-security partnership is transforming India and Oman's relationship from one of shared interests into a deeper strategic alignment rooted in mutual trust and regional security cooperation.

Energy Security as an Area for Sustainable Partnerships Energy security is a cornerstone of the India-Oman strategic partnership. Oman remains a significant and reliable supplier of crude oil and liquified natural gas (LNG) to India. Long-term supply agreements between the two countries provide stability, particularly in the face of fluctuations in energy markets. These agreements typically include flexible pricing mechanisms, increasing the predictability of India's energy import costs. Furthermore, Indian energy giants strengthen resource supply by participating in upstream projects in Oman through joint investments. Of India's annual imports from Oman – valued at \$6 billion – approximately \$1 billion accounts for crude oil and another \$1 billion accounts for LNG. During Modi's visit, both sides discussed prospective collaboration in green hydrogen and renewable energy. Moving beyond traditional hydrocarbon cooperation, the two countries aim to develop strategic partnerships in the energy transition space. (22) Oman's excellent solar and wind potential, reflecting its geographical and climatic characteristics, and India's renewable energy technologies create a complementary synergy. Indian companies provide technology, financing and expertise to develop large-scale solar power plants and wind farms in Oman to consolidate an investment aspect of the relations. At the heart of this cooperation is Oman's ambition to emerge as a global hub for green hydrogen production by 2040, a goal that aligns closely with India's broader energy transition strategy. The proposed green hydrogen corridor represents a tangible manifestation of this vision. Under this framework, India would contribute its expertise in electrolyser technology and renewable energy integration, while Oman would provide extensive land resources and supporting infrastructure for large-scale production. The project aims to export green hydrogen and its derivatives from Oman to India and other international markets via Duqm Port. (23) This initiative will contribute to transforming Oman's economy, consolidating Oman as a critical player in the global green energy trade. This comprehensive energy cooperation offers a forward-looking model that addresses both traditional security needs and shared responsibilities in combating climate change.

Conclusion Modi's visit to Oman deepened New Delhi's strategic footprint in the Western Indian Ocean and the Gulf. It elevated bilateral ties into a more comprehensive strategic and economic partnership. The signing of CEPA provides an institutional foundation for this relationship, underscoring India's recognition of Oman as a pivotal node in its regional logistics and trade networks. From a geopolitical perspective, the visit can be interpreted as a successful

expression of India's multi-aligned foreign policy approach. Oman's neutral and mediation-oriented diplomacy allows Muscat to navigate regional tensions while maintaining open channels with competing actors. This posture, in turn, provides India with strategic flexibility in balancing its relations with key regional powers, including Saudi Arabia, the UAE and Iran. Modi's visit can also be interpreted as part of India's broader effort to recalibrate its partnership with Oman amid growing regional competition. In fact, New Delhi appears to be pursuing a subtle balancing strategy against China's expanding presence under the Belt and Road Initiative by incorporating Oman into its own connectivity and logistics initiatives. At the same time, closer ties with Muscat serve to offset Pakistan's longstanding influence in parts of the Gulf. The expansion of military-security cooperation, the diversification of energy ties, and the emergence of partnerships in future-oriented sectors such as green hydrogen demonstrate that the relationship is being structured with a long-term strategic horizon. The vibrant Indian diaspora provides social legitimacy and a foundation of trust underpinning these collaborations. India is recalibrating its engagement with Oman to align with contemporary geopolitical realities while continuing to build on their longstanding socio-cultural connections. Ultimately, Modi's visit signals India's intention to elevate its partnership with Oman from a historically rooted relationship into a dynamic and forward-looking strategic alignment shaped by economic interests and geostrategic considerations. As both countries deepen cooperation, they are contributing to a framework that may influence the broader security and prosperity architecture of the Indian Ocean region.

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12. Targeting the Regime: The Second Round of the US–Israeli War on Iran

URL: <http://studies.aljazeera.net/en/policy-briefs/targeting-regime-second-round-us%E2%80%93israeli-war-iran>

In the early hours of 28 February 2026, Israel launched the opening strikes of the second US–Israeli war on Iran in less than nine months. The first wave targeted the highest political and military leadership of the Islamic Republic, including Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei and senior national security and Revolutionary Guard commanders. Khamenei and other top officials were killed. Within hours, US forces deployed across the region joined the campaign, widening the scope of attacks across Iranian territory. Iran responded as expected, firing medium-range missiles and deploying drones against targets in Israel, Jordan and US military sites in Iraq and across Gulf states. Oman was struck the following day. By the evening of the first day, commercial vessels reportedly received Iranian warnings not to transit the Strait of Hormuz, signalling Tehran's readiness to escalate the conflict economically. The war erupted only two days after a third round of indirect US–Iran negotiations in Geneva, mediated by Oman. Omani statements described the talks as positive and marked by significant progress. Iranian officials expressed optimism, announced upcoming expert-level meetings in Vienna under the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA), and signalled readiness for a fourth round. Throughout February, Tehran maintained that it sought a negotiated settlement while remaining prepared for war if imposed. During the same period, US President Donald Trump signalled a shift toward force. In his 24 February address before Congress, he asserted that Iran had resumed elements of its nuclear programme after earlier strikes in 2025 and,

for the first time, characterised Iran's missile arsenal as a threat extending beyond the region. He demanded a complete halt to uranium enrichment and inclusion of ballistic missiles in negotiations – conditions Tehran rejects. Mixed signals emerged from Washington, as some officials hinted at flexibility on limited enrichment while others reiterated maximalist demands. On 27 February, Trump publicly expressed dissatisfaction with negotiations, though he stated he preferred to avoid force. That same day, the IAEA reported uncertainty about the location of more than 9,000 kilograms of enriched uranium at varying levels, including over 400 kilograms enriched above 60 percent. Meanwhile, US force mobilisation around Iran intensified. When announcing the strikes, Trump devoted only limited attention to the nuclear issue. Most of his speech emphasised five decades of hostility between Washington and the Islamic Republic and declared that his administration could no longer coexist with the current regime. He concluded by addressing Iranians directly, urging them to seize what he described as a historic opportunity to free themselves from their rulers. Israeli rhetoric aligned with this orientation, openly appealing to minority communities and opposition forces. The early assassination of senior leadership confirmed that the war's central objective extends beyond the nuclear file. It concerns the existence, direction and future of the Islamic Republic itself. Two military paths are conceivable. A short war, lasting days to a week, would concentrate on degrading air defences, missile launch sites, drone infrastructure, ports, naval assets, command-and-control systems and remaining nuclear facilities, while continuing leadership targeting where possible. Its aim would be to weaken and disorient the regime, open space for opposition forces, and compel surrender in subsequent negotiations. A longer war, stretching weeks or more, would expand to economic infrastructure, governance centres, and possibly cultural and media institutions, seeking to shatter the structural pillars of the regime and render it vulnerable to collapse amid widespread unrest. This option aligns more closely with Israeli strategic preferences. Iran's response strategy rests on raising the cost of war. Acknowledging the imbalance of power, Tehran seeks to sustain missile and drone strikes to impose economic paralysis on Israel and the Gulf, particularly Bahrain and the United Arab Emirates. Disruption of the Strait of Hormuz would have severe global economic consequences. If regime survival becomes existentially threatened, Iran could encourage allied actors in Lebanon, Iraq and Yemen to open additional fronts, including maritime chokepoints, though the constraints facing these allies complicate escalation. Regardless of duration, Iran will emerge from this war exhausted. Yet collapse through aerial bombardment alone remains unlikely. The Islamic Republic is institutionally diffuse, with authority distributed across multiple governing bodies and security forces, including the regular army, Revolutionary Guard, internal security services and the Basij. Despite growing social discontent since 2008, the regime retains a significant base across regions and communities. Severe damage is more likely to produce internal contention than immediate regime implosion. Without ground invasion and sustained external control, a decisive overthrow remains improbable. Nor is a complete destruction of Iran's nuclear and missile capabilities assured. Enriched uranium stocks are dispersed and not fully accounted for, and missile infrastructure spans the country's vast geography. The technological foundations of both programmes are domestically developed and cannot be erased by airstrikes alone. The war's consequences will nevertheless be profound. Iran's regional influence may contract as the regime turns inward. If it survives with cohesion, it will confront a stark choice: accommodation with Washington involving structural and regional recalibration, or endurance and reconstruction while preserving strategic independence, potentially including pursuit of a nuclear deterrent. In either case, the central target of this war is not merely Iran's nuclear programme, but the Islamic Republic itself. *This is a summary of a policy brief originally written in Arabic available [here](#).

13. Reframing Palestine: A Comparative Analysis of Palestinian Representation in Western Legacy News Media and the Platformed Commentary Ecosystem

URL: <http://studies.aljazeera.net/en/analyses/reframing-palestine-comparative-analysis-palestinian-representation-western-legacy-news>

The struggle over Palestine has long extended beyond the battlefield into the realm of narrative power. For decades, Western legacy news media have played a decisive role in shaping global understandings of the conflict, exercising disproportionate influence over how violence, accountability and legitimacy are defined. A substantial body of research has shown that this coverage has produced a relatively stable “representational framework” that favours Israeli state perspectives, detaches military violence from its historical and structural context, and marginalises Palestinian political agency. (1) Palestinian resistance is routinely filtered through security-driven and racialised discourse, while Palestinian suffering is acknowledged largely as humanitarian tragedy rather than as the outcome of sustained occupation, siege and political exclusion. Yet the media environment that once sustained this dominance is no longer intact. The erosion of traditional gatekeeping and the rise of digital platforms have fragmented authority over political meaning and reconfigured the public sphere. Long-form interviews, podcasts and personality-driven digital programmes now function as influential arenas of debate, often reaching audiences comparable to or larger than those of legacy broadcasters. Operating with fewer institutional constraints, these platformed spaces have allowed perspectives that have been marginalised in mainstream coverage, including Palestinian voices and critical analyses of Western policy, to circulate more visibly. At the same time, they remain shaped by the commercial and algorithmic pressures of ‘platform capitalism’, which reward affective engagement, controversy and personality-driven framing. (2) This paper investigates whether the fragmentation of the contemporary media environment has meaningfully transformed representations of Palestine, or whether dominant narratives continue to be reproduced through new media forms. Drawing on a comparative discourse analysis of Western legacy news coverage and influential platformed commentary programmes during the 2023–2025 war on Gaza, the study examines how Palestinian visibility, agency and legitimacy are constructed across these distinct media environments. It hypothesises that while platformed spaces have expanded the circulation of Palestinian voices and facilitated more explicit critiques of Western policy, they often rearticulate core discursive logics, such as the securitisation of Palestinian resistance, the depoliticisation of Palestinian suffering, and the favouring of Western and Israeli interpretive frames, rather than fundamentally challenging them. As a result, platformed commentary both broadens the boundaries of debate and reproduces entrenched power asymmetries, pointing to a reconfiguration of media power rather than a rupture with established narrative hierarchies. Theoretical Framework This article draws on critical media studies and political communication to examine how meanings about Palestine are produced, normalised and contested across different media systems. It is anchored in framing theory, which highlights how news discourse prioritises certain interpretations of events, assigns responsibility, and defines the limits of moral and political debate. (3) The analysis is further informed by Stuart Hall’s theory of representation, which treats media language as a site where power operates through the

construction of identity and difference. This perspective is particularly relevant for understanding how Palestinians are racialised and positioned within Western media narratives that historically associate Arab and Muslim actors with security threats, while naturalising Israeli state authority. Narrative analysis complements this framework by examining storytelling practices, especially in digital commentary formats, where extended testimony, affective appeal and personalisation shape how Palestinians are cast as victims, resisters or moral subjects. (4) Methodologically, the study employs Critical Discourse Analysis within a qualitative comparative design combining lexical analysis and transitivity analysis to systematically examine patterns of agency, responsibility, and moral positioning of the media coverage during moments of acute crisis. It focuses on a targeted corpus drawn from Western legacy broadcasting, CBS and BBC, and two influential platformed programmes, Piers Morgan Uncensored and Breaking Points, selected for their agenda-setting influence, transnational reach, and contrasting institutional logics. Temporal Phases of Media Coverage To capture how media narratives evolved alongside shifts in the conflict itself, this study organises its analysis into three distinct temporal phases: the acute crisis following 7 October 2023, the period of protracted warfare and discursive stabilisation, and the aftermath marked by normalisation and narrative consolidation. For each phase, a video segment from each selected outlet was randomly sampled for close analysis, ensuring comparability across time and media environments while avoiding event-specific overdetermination. This periodisation enables a longitudinal examination of how lexical choices, agency attribution and framing strategies shift as violence becomes routinised, humanitarian suffering persists, and political justifications harden within public discourse, moving beyond static assessments of media bias toward an analysis of narrative evolution. (5) Phase 1: Acute Crisis (7 October – 31 December 2023) British Broadcasting Corporation (BBC) The BBC coverage in this phase adopts a dual humanitarian and operational frame, foregrounding Palestinian suffering while embedding it within a securitised institutional logic. Lexical markers such as “total siege”, “hospitals close to collapse” and “humanitarian crisis” convey moral urgency, yet Hamas is consistently labelled a “terror organisation”, anchoring the narrative within Western geopolitical consensus. Israeli military action is rendered through procedural language (“preparing for a ground offensive”, “targeting Hamas infrastructure”), presenting violence as strategic rather than punitive. In transitivity patterns, Israel is positioned as the primary agent in material processes, while Palestinians largely appear as affected participants. Civilian suffering is frequently expressed through existential constructions (“there is a humanitarian crisis”), foregrounding conditions while softening attribution of responsibility. Hamas agency is often mediated through Israeli claims, allowing official narratives to circulate with limited scrutiny. Columbia Broadcasting System (CBS) The CBS reporting during the acute phase is structured around a securitized moral frame that privileges Israeli military authority. Lexical choices such as “terror group,” “human shields,” and “destroy the infrastructure” depict Hamas as an existential threat while casting Israeli violence as necessary and restrained. Palestinian suffering is acknowledged visually and emotionally but is consistently reattributed to Hamas responsibility through the refrain that Israel is “at war with Hamas, not Gaza.” Transitivity analysis reveals a stark imbalance: Israeli actors are active, intentional agents (“we must destroy,” “we will do anything”), Hamas is granted agency only through criminalised acts, and Palestinian civilians are overwhelmingly passive recipients (“used,” “taken hostage,” “in the rubble”). Civilian harm is grammatically detached from Israeli action, appearing as tragedy rather than consequence. Piers Morgan Uncensored During the acute crisis phase, Piers Morgan Uncensored deployed a heavily securitised and moralised discourse that foregrounds Israeli victimhood while systematically

delegitimising Palestinian political subjectivity. Lexical choices such as “terror group”, “monsters”, “barbaric” and “death cult” construct Hamas, and by extension Palestinian resistance, as inherently criminal and irrational, foreclosing political interpretation. Israeli military action, by contrast, is framed through justificatory and defensive language (“duty to defend”, “proportionate response”, “security responsibility”), while Palestinian civilian suffering is rendered as tragic but incidental, detached from structural conditions such as occupation or siege. Palestinian terms like “blockade” or “concentration camp” are consistently challenged or reframed as extremist rhetoric, reinforcing a hierarchy of discursive legitimacy. Similarly, transitivity patterns intensify this asymmetry. Israel is positioned as a deliberate and controlled actor in material processes (“Israel warned civilians”, “Israel left Gaza”), while Palestinian civilians appear primarily as affected recipients (“killed”, “displaced”). Palestinian violence is individualised and criminalised through active verbs (“butchered”, “stabbed”), whereas Israeli violence is frequently abstracted through nominalisation (“the bombing”, “the campaign”), diffusing responsibility and normalising force. Breaking Points Breaking Points diverges sharply from broadcast media by advancing a counter-hegemonic investigative frame centred on state failure and elite accountability. Lexically, the segment emphasises exposure and negligence (“ignored warnings”, “bombshell report”, “looked the other way”), redirecting securitised language away from moral justification and toward institutional critique. Hamas violence is contextualised within Israeli intelligence failures rather than mobilised to legitimise military escalation. Transitivity patterns assign clear agency to Israeli institutions through verbs of omission and decision-making (“officials monitored”, “they allowed it to continue”), while Hamas agency is subordinated to prior state actions. Palestinian civilians appear only indirectly, reflecting the programme’s focus on political responsibility rather than humanitarian spectacle.

Phase 2: Protracted War and Discursive Stabilisation (January – June 2024) BBC BBC reporting maintains a humanitarian-operational balance, foregrounding deprivation through emotive language (“desperate for water”, “heartbreaking”) while rendering military violence through procedural terms (“strikes”, “launching”). Palestinian voices are humanised through testimony but individualised, with structural causes largely absent. Grammatically, Israel remains the principal actor, Palestinians the affected subjects. Existential constructions foreground devastation while obscuring direct responsibility, sustaining institutional neutrality. CBS CBS increasingly frames Gaza through a logistical humanitarian lens, emphasising aid delivery challenges over political causation. Lexical emphasis on “critical aid” and “diversion” introduces Hamas as an obstacle while normalising Israeli control as operational necessity. Whereas, transitivity patterns privilege Israeli and institutional agency, with Palestinians positioned as recipients of aid or deprivation. Responsibility is diffused through nominalisation and complexity framing. Piers Morgan Uncensored As the war protracts, Morgan’s framing hardens into a securitised moral absolutism. Lexical choices such as “eradicate Hamas”, “collateral damage” and repeated Nazi analogies normalise total military victory as both necessary and inevitable. Palestinian civilians are framed as ideologically compromised or morally suspect, while Israeli actions are consistently justified as reluctant but unavoidable. On the other hand, transitivity analysis shows Israeli actors as dominant agents shaping outcomes, while Palestinians are depicted either as passive victims or morally delegitimised collectives. Verbal processes privilege Israeli testimony and expertise, reinforcing epistemic authority. Breaking Points Breaking Points centres Israeli policy, infrastructure and political calculation. Lexical emphasis on control (“no-man’s land”, “bifurcation”) situates Palestinian suffering as the outcome of deliberate state strategy rather than battlefield chaos. Agency is consistently assigned to Israeli actors, while Palestinians appear as constrained subjects. Verbal processes favour Israeli rationale,

foregrounding power asymmetries over humanitarian immediacy. Phase 3: Aftermath and Normalisation (July 2024 – January 2026) BBC BBC coverage foregrounds casualty figures, infrastructure destruction and civilian testimony, balancing human impact with official claims and diplomatic context. While the human toll is vividly rendered, responsibility remains institutionally mediated. Agency is split between Israeli operational claims and Palestinian suffering articulated through testimony, sustaining BBC's calibrated neutrality. CBS CBS emphasises humanitarian devastation through affective storytelling while minimising political and military agency. Palestinian suffering is personalised, while Israeli action is largely backgrounded. Grammatically, Palestinians dominate as recipients of action, aid actors as purposeful agents, and Israeli military agency is largely absent, framing the conflict as tragedy rather than power struggle. Piers Morgan Uncensored Morgan's discourse stabilises into a pro-Israel/anti-Hamas narrative that assigns moral and causal responsibility for civilian suffering almost exclusively to Hamas. Lexical demonisation ("terrorist state", "propaganda campaign") coexists with language emphasising Israeli restraint and procedural caution. Transitivity patterns reinforce this logic: Hamas is the active moral culprit; Palestinians are passive victims; and Israel is a constrained but justified responder. Structural responsibility is largely erased Breaking Points Breaking Points continues to foreground Israeli agency and strategic calculation, framing Palestinian casualties as outcomes of deliberate decisions and contested pretexts. Lexical and grammatical abstraction diffuses responsibility while privileging state rationality. Israeli actors remain sovereign agents; Palestinians are recipients of force; Hamas agency appears fragmented and contingent, reinforcing asymmetries of control. Evolving Narratives Across Media Platforms: The Gaza Conflict Through a Theoretical Lens Temporal Evolution and Framing Dynamics Across the three phases of the Gaza conflict, media outlets display distinct framing strategies shaped by institutional norms, audience expectations and political economy. During the acute crisis (October–December 2023), Piers Morgan employed heavily securitised and moralised frames, foregrounding Israeli victimhood and demonising Hamas, while Palestinian civilians were largely collateralised, a clear example of Entman and Goffman's dominant framing. (6) CBS echoed this moralised securitisation, whereas BBC balanced humanitarian concern with operational proceduralism. Breaking Points, however, offered a negotiated or oppositional frame, emphasising the Israeli elite's mismanagement and structural responsibility, positioning Palestinian suffering as a cause of political decision-making rather than inherent criminality. (7) As the war protracted (January–June 2024), Morgan's commentary intensified securitised and moralised storytelling, normalising large-scale Israeli military action through historical analogies, whereas BBC and CBS maintained humanitarian-operational balances, centring Palestinian suffering yet depoliticising structural causality. Breaking Points shifted to strategic-political analysis, foregrounding Israeli decision-making and infrastructure projects as central determinants, with Palestinians depicted as affected stakeholders and Hamas actors as contingent. By the aftermath and normalisation phase (July 2024–January 2026), Morgan stabilised a pro-Israel/anti-Hamas "moral narrative"; BBC integrated human impact with institutional and procedural context; CBS emphasised deprivation and humanitarian loss; and Breaking Points consistently centred the Israeli's elite agency, framing Palestinian casualties as contingent outcomes of operational and political decisions. (8) Representation, Agency and Narrative Construction Across platforms, the politics of representation (Hall) and transitivity patterns reveal striking asymmetries. Legacy media, while balancing humanitarian concern with procedural reporting, largely mediate Palestinian agency through passive or victimised positions, legitimising Israeli action as controlled, strategic and morally constrained. (9) Platformed commentary exhibits more flexible narrative construction: Morgan

amplifies securitised moral hierarchies, foregrounding Israeli justification and delegitimising Palestinian agency, whereas Breaking Points emphasises systemic causality, elite accountability and structural critique, positioning Palestinian actors as stakeholders within broader political processes. Narrative inquiry highlights how storytelling devices – plot, character and closure – are mobilised differently: affective and morally charged in Morgan, investigative and analytic in Breaking Points. Political Economy and Public Sphere Considerations These patterns are deeply shaped by political economy. Legacy media are constrained by ownership, charter obligations, subscriptions, and geopolitical alignment, prioritising credibility, elite sourcing and procedural neutrality. (10)

Platformed commentary operates under platform capitalism, patronage incentives and audience-driven metrics, which encourage both provocative moral storytelling (Morgan) and long-form investigative analysis (Breaking Points). (11) Consequently, the digital ecosystem produces fragmented counter-publics that amplifies marginalised Palestinian voices while simultaneously creating ideologically homogenous audiences, reflecting both opportunities for counter-hegemonic discourse and structural reproduction of attention hierarchies. (12) Taken together, this comparative analysis illustrates that Palestinian representation is neither fixed nor uniform. Legacy media reproduce state-centric frames that constrain interpretation through lexical, grammatical and structural mechanisms, while platformed commentary enables alternative narratives, foregrounding elite accountability, systemic critique, and conditional Palestinian agency. Applying framing theory, representation, narrative inquiry, political economy and public sphere theory illuminates how micro-level discourse strategies (lexical choice, moral positioning, transitivity) interact with macro-level structures (ownership, platform incentives, audience composition) to shape the evolution of narratives in real time. Factors Driving Narrative Change across Phases Event Progression and Temporal Framing Narrative change throughout the conflict closely followed the temporal logic of war. Initial coverage was shaped by shock and urgency, favouring securitised and moralised framing that emphasised immediacy, blame and threat, with limited historical or structural context. As the conflict became protracted, attention shifted toward operational continuity and humanitarian conditions, including infrastructure destruction and aid constraints. In the normalisation phase, the routinisation of violence reduced crisis immediacy, enabling greater engagement with long-term consequences, structural causation and questions of accountability. (13) Media Ecology and Institutional Logics Narrative trajectories diverged across media environments. Legacy media adjusted gradually within institutional norms of verification, procedural balance and credibility, producing incremental shifts in emphasis rather than abrupt reframing. Platformed commentary, shaped by personality-driven formats and fewer institutional constraints, demonstrated greater narrative flexibility, moving more rapidly toward interpretation, moral positioning and critique. These contrasting logics explain why narrative evolution was uneven, with platformed spaces recalibrating faster and more visibly than legacy news systems. (14) Audience Incentives, Sources and Political Context Audience engagement and platform incentives further shaped narrative change. Attention-driven environments rewarded emotive or counter-hegemonic storytelling, while institutionally accountable outlets prioritised measured and humanitarian framing. Over time, expanded access to sources, such as investigative reporting, policy analysis and first-hand testimony, enabled more complex representations, including increased recognition of Palestinian agency and structural dynamics. These shifts unfolded within broader political and ideological contexts that constrained or enabled critique, reinforcing how narrative change reflects not only events on the ground but the political economy and epistemic limits of different media systems. (15) Conclusion Narratives of the war on Gaza are neither static nor uniform, but evolve in

response to shifting events, institutional norms and platform-specific incentives. Across legacy and platformed media, framing, representation and agency are dynamically negotiated: legacy outlets like BBC and CBS maintain humanitarian-operational and procedural frames that foreground Israeli agency and mediate Palestinian suffering, while platformed commentary oscillates between securitised moralisation, as in Piers Morgan Uncensored, and counter-hegemonic structural critique, as in Breaking Points. Lexical and transitivity analyses reveal consistent patterns of asymmetrical agency, yet the availability of sources, narrative formats and platform economics allow digital media to interrogate elite decision-making, highlight Palestinian perspectives, and reconfigure public discourse. Integrating framing theory, Hall's representation framework, narrative inquiry, and political economy perspectives, the analysis underscores that media narratives are co-produced within complex structural, ideological and temporal contexts. Ultimately, the evolution of coverage across three phases illustrates how public understanding of conflict is continuously reshaped: immediate crises trigger securitised and moralised framing; protracted violence shifts attention to operational and humanitarian realities; and normalisation produces reflection on accountability and structural causation, highlighting the intertwined roles of media, ideology and audience in the construction of meaning.

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14. AJCS Publishes New Book on Small States in an Era of International Conflict

URL: <http://studies.aljazeera.net/en/publications/ajcs-publishes-new-book-small-states-era-international-conflict>

Al Jazeera Centre for Studies has released a new book titled *Dhil al-Qaysar: ad-Duwal as-Saghira fi Zaman as-Sira' ad-Duwal* [The Tsar's Shadow: Small States in an Era of International Conflict], by Abdullah Rashid Al-Mursel Al-Marri. Spanning 365 pages, the book examines how the Russia-Ukraine war has reshaped the positions of small and peripheral states within the international system, revealing new roles that have emerged on the margins of the conflict, far from the centre of direct confrontation. The book is grounded in the central idea that major transformations in international politics often occur at the peripheries, where the limits of power are tested, positioning rules shift, and strategic calculations are reformulated. It traces how states in Central Asia, the Balkans, the Middle East and Africa have interacted with a moment of sharp global polarisation, analysing how they have managed their diplomatic, economic and security options. The study explores how these states have sought either to expand their room for manoeuvre or to fortify their positions within a volatile international environment. In this context, the book offers an in-depth reading of how small states can act as pragmatic players, leveraging opportunities created by disruptions in the international order while operating under strict geographic and political constraints. The significance of this work lies in its focus on the outer edges of international conflict, where subtle transformations are taking shape—developments that may pave the way for a rearrangement of the global balance of power. It provides a different understanding of power dynamics in a world moving toward a turbulent multipolarity. The author is a Qatari researcher specialising in international affairs and international relations. His work focuses on geopolitical transformations and the contemporary international system, with particular emphasis on the challenges facing small states amid international conflict and ongoing global realignments.

15. On the Brink of War: US and Iranian Calculations in the New Negotiations

URL: <http://studies.aljazeera.net/en/policy-briefs/brink-war-us-and-iranian-calculations-new-negotiations>

On 6 February 2026, Oman hosted indirect US-Iranian talks, described by Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi and his Omani counterpart Badr bin Hamad Al Busaidi, as well as regional media, as constructive and conducted in a positive atmosphere. These discussions, however, were limited to two sessions and were not direct negotiations. US President Donald Trump commented belatedly, calling the talks “good” and noting that Iran appeared eager to reach an agreement,

providing Washington with time for negotiation. Nevertheless, shortly before commenting, Trump had signed an executive order imposing tariffs on goods from countries still trading with Iran. These talks marked the first negotiation round since the 12-day war on Iran in June 2025. While Israeli and US officials claimed the war had achieved all objectives and many expected the confrontation to end for the remainder of Trump's term, tensions quickly resurged following nationwide protests against the Iranian regime in late December 2025 and early January 2026. In response to these demonstrations, Trump increased rhetoric against Tehran, citing both sympathy for protesters and the need to counter the Iranian government's suppression efforts. Despite Iran eventually quelling the protests, the United States reinforced its military presence in the region and around Iranian waters. Trump swiftly shifted from criticising Iran's domestic repression to the nuclear dossier. He had previously withdrawn from the nuclear agreement established under the Obama administration and claimed that US strikes on Iranian nuclear sites in June 2025 had destroyed the programme entirely. Moreover, US officials suggested that American demands would include Iran's missile programme and regional support for proxies in Yemen, Palestine and Lebanon—demands Iran rejects. Iranian National Security Council Secretary Ali Larijani stated unequivocally that Tehran would negotiate only on the nuclear issue. By late January 2026, expectations of a US strike on Iran were high, as Tehran's statements offered no signs of concession, and Trump had demonstrated limited willingness to back down, particularly after achieving objectives in Venezuela. Nevertheless, a more nuanced US assessment of Iran's internal situation, combined with pressure from regional allies such as Turkey, Saudi Arabia and Qatar—who engaged intensively with both Tehran and Washington—persuaded the parties to explore negotiations, initially as a trial. Although Turkey initially appeared poised to host the talks with observers from Turkey, Qatar and Saudi Arabia, Iran unexpectedly chose Oman as the venue, excluding other regional representatives. Tehran aimed to avoid giving Turkey mediation leverage or provoking additional demands from neighbouring states. Iranian leaks indicated this approach mirrored rejected negotiation frameworks, such as those related to Gaza. The US objectives in the negotiations are extensive. Press reports indicate Washington demands the cessation of uranium enrichment and the transfer of 400–450 kilograms of highly enriched uranium, citing concerns over Iran's potential nuclear weapon capability and destabilising regional effects. Mediators reportedly proposed compromise measures, allowing Iran limited enrichment up to 1.5 percent and transferring excess uranium to Turkey or Russia, which offered to handle enrichment for peaceful purposes. Unofficial discussions suggested American interest in gaining influence over Iran's oil and gas sector and rare mineral exploitation, as well as restoring American economic engagement. Prior to the Oman talks, U.S. negotiator Steve Witkoff met Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu on 2 February, signalling that US discussions would include Israeli concerns, particularly regarding Iran's missile programme and regional influence. While Israel sought restrictions on missile range and quantities, there is no confirmation that the Trump administration fully endorsed these demands. A subsequent Trump-Netanyahu meeting on 11 February reportedly prioritised the nuclear issue for Washington, while Israel insisted on including strategic security concerns. Iran approached negotiations from a weakened position relative to previous rounds, facing diminished regional influence—especially after the Assad regime's fall in Syria, weakened allies in Palestine and Lebanon, and reduced leverage in Iraq and Yemen. Economic sanctions and financial pressures had precipitated severe domestic challenges, including currency collapse, inflation and public protests. Tehran recognised the limits of its military capacity against the United States, understanding that further confrontation could be catastrophic. Consequently, Iran adopted a pragmatic approach, willing to make concessions on nuclear

enrichment levels while maintaining core defense and sovereignty principles. Iran categorically rejects discussing its missile programme, viewing it as essential for national defence. Tehran also seeks to retain some regional presence, particularly in Iraq, Lebanon, Yemen and Palestine, potentially limiting involvement to humanitarian, cultural and religious spheres. Its primary goal is sanction relief to rebuild an economy severely affected by US and international measures. Any agreement would likely involve gradual easing of sanctions, reflecting deep US-Iran distrust. The Oman talks focused on establishing a general framework for negotiations, without addressing detailed nuclear issues. Tehran indicated that transferring highly enriched uranium abroad was a "red line", although it might accept reducing enrichment levels domestically. The possibility of including US-Iranian discussions on regional influence exists, with Iran seeking to maintain limited involvement while adhering to its red lines. Ultimately, the ongoing US-Iran confrontation remains complex, with both sides weighing negotiation against the potential for renewed conflict. Achieving an agreement would require lowering the original demands of both parties. Should US negotiators fully adopt Israeli security concerns, a deal would be extremely difficult. Conversely, Iran might resist concessions perceived as undermining sovereignty or national defence, even if facing the threat of military escalation. The path forward is uncertain, balancing negotiation with the persistent risk of confrontation. *This is a summary of a policy brief originally written in Arabic available [here](#).

16. Methodological Approaches to Investigative Journalism and Their Impact on Enhancing Its Quality

URL: <http://studies.aljazeera.net/en/analyses/methodological-approaches-investigative-journalism-and-their-impact-enhancing-its-quality>

Abstract This study examines methodological approaches in investigative journalism and their intersections with scientific research methods, exploring how these frameworks can be employed to enhance the quality of investigative reporting. It aims to provide a comprehensive understanding of the methodological tools used in this field by addressing a central research question: What is the most effective methodology for producing high-quality investigative journalism, and how does it contribute to the development of journalistic practice? Drawing on case studies and practical examples, the study illustrates how scientific methods can be adapted to improve the accuracy and depth of information gathering and analysis in investigative work. It highlights the ways in which research methodologies can guide the investigative process and enrich its outcomes. The study also addresses the key challenges faced by investigative journalists and offers a holistic framework for overcoming these obstacles—ultimately aimed at strengthening the practice of investigative journalism and reinforcing standards of credibility and transparency.

Introduction The press plays a fundamental role in the structure of contemporary society as a core practice that upholds the principles of transparency and accountability and assumes the function of “counter-power” by exercising oversight over institutions and uncovering facts for the public. Through this crucial role, journalism constitutes a cornerstone in the construction of democratic systems, as it provides citizens with access to reliable information about developments within decision-making centres, enabling them to make informed choices. This proposition also reinforces the principle that independent journalism is a prerequisite for achieving democratic goals related to the preservation and continued progress of civilisation. Genuine democracy depends on an informed citizenry, which in turn requires high-quality media (1) and the widest possible access to its content, (2) fostering citizens’ active participation in public life. Investigative journalism lies at the heart of this media function. It represents the most demanding and valuable journalistic genre due to the meticulous effort and systematic work it requires to uncover hidden facts that are deliberately concealed by certain parties. The success of investigative reporting is closely linked to its strict adherence to scientific approaches based on in-depth research and field investigation, enabling journalists to produce content grounded in verified facts. This form of journalism requires rigorous commitment to established methodologies in order to achieve high levels of accuracy and objectivity. Investigative reporting is based on thorough research into sources, the extraction of concealed information, the verification and documentation of data, and the construction of sound hypotheses supported by strong evidence. Within this context, the development and formulation of hypotheses in investigative journalism constitute a particular challenge, as hypotheses serve as a fundamental cognitive and organisational tool that guides the course of the investigation and identifies the core questions the journalist seeks to answer. Accordingly, the success of an investigation depends on the journalist’s ability to formulate a well-constructed and testable hypothesis, which in turn requires a deep understanding of methodological approaches appropriate to the nature and objectives of the investigation. This study seeks to explore the intersections between scientific approaches and investigative journalism, and to examine ways of employing them to improve the quality of investigative practice. By reviewing the various approaches used by investigative journalists, the

study aims to provide a comprehensive overview of the methodologies used in this field, demonstrate how they can be applied to achieve the highest levels of accuracy and depth in information collection and analysis, and clarify the distinctions these approaches create in guiding investigations and enriching their results. This study also aims to examine the challenges facing investigative journalists and present a comprehensive vision for overcoming these obstacles, thereby enhancing journalistic efficiency and consolidating standards of credibility and transparency in investigative work.

1. Methodology and definitions

Research problem This study examines the foundations of investigative journalism and the role of scientific methodology in achieving comprehensive quality, through the following central research question: What is the most appropriate methodology in investigative journalism for achieving high-quality results? What is its impact on the development of journalistic practice? This central question arises from a number of professional and ethical issues, including:

- How can investigative journalists balance accuracy in data collection and analysis with adherence to ethical and professional standards?
- What is the impact of adopting diverse methodological approaches on the credibility and effectiveness of investigative reporting?
- How can a strong and reliable hypothesis be formulated for investigative reporting?

Research objectives This study seeks to highlight the importance of methodological rigour in investigative journalism and the role of scientific methodology in achieving high-quality outcomes. These objectives can be summarised as follows:

- To analyse the most significant approaches used in investigative journalism and examine the relationship between investigative quality and the methodologies applied in hypothesis formulation and the collection and analysis of information.
- To identify the challenges journalists face in applying investigative methodologies and explore ways to overcome them.
- To propose recommendations for improving investigative journalism practices, thereby strengthening their role in promoting transparency and accountability.

The importance of this study also stems from the urgent need to develop investigative journalism practices in response to rapid transformations in the media landscape and ongoing technological advances. It seeks to present a systematic framework that enhances the accuracy and credibility of investigative reporting, thereby reinforcing its role as an effective instrument of oversight in society.

Methodological strategy This study adopts a composite methodological strategy that combines several approaches to address the various dimensions of the research problem, including:

- The descriptive approach, which presents foundational concepts and terminology and provides a comprehensive overview of the importance, characteristics and methods of investigative journalism.
- The analytical approach, which is used to examine and evaluate the effectiveness of various investigative methodologies and assess their impact on result quality and informational accuracy.
- The comparative approach, which examines investigative journalism methods alongside scientific research methods, focusing on information-gathering techniques, analytical procedures, and their impact on credibility and effectiveness.

This analysis helps identify the most effective methodologies for producing accurate and comprehensive results and clarifies their contribution to the development of investigative practice. Together, these approaches enable the researcher to present an integrated vision for improving and enhancing the efficiency of investigative practices, contributing to the enrichment of investigative journalism and the development of its tools in response to changes in the media environment and increasing public expectations regarding transparency and accountability.

Definition of Investigative Journalism Investigative journalism is considered one of the most refined journalistic genres. (3) It relies on in-depth research and systematic investigation in the collection and analysis of information, with the aim of uncovering hidden facts or unknown dimensions of issues of public interest. It often addresses sensitive topics related to corruption,

unethical practices, crime, human rights violations, and other issues that may threaten social stability. (4) Investigative journalism differs from other journalistic forms in that it relies on material independently collected by the journalist, a practice sometimes referred to as “enterprise journalism”. (5) It does not depend on information readily available through open sources or provided by third parties but instead seeks to gather diverse perspectives and analyses related to the issue under investigation, thereby enhancing the comprehensiveness and depth of coverage. This approach renders investigative journalism a complex field that requires rigorous data analysis and often necessitates close collaboration between journalists and experts in fields such as law, economics and political science, to produce credible and well-substantiated investigations. Investigative journalism is characterised by its systematic, evidence-based, document-oriented and multi-source approach. Its primary objective is not merely to convey information, but also to draw public attention to issues that directly affect society, while proposing solutions and encouraging positive change. This form of journalism also requires specialised skills in evidence collection and analysis, as well as strict adherence to ethical standards, best professional practices, and respect for individual privacy throughout the investigative process. The definition of investigative journalism is shaped by its expected roles, the experiences of its practitioners, and the nature and requirements of the investigative process. While definitions may vary, they are complementary in pursuing the primary objective of investigative journalism: the disclosure of important information that has been concealed. (6) This objective helps society understand critical issues and encourages reform and change. According to the Global Investigative Journalism Network, investigative journalism is “systematic, in-depth, and original research and reporting, often involving the unearthing of secrets...its practice often involves heavy use of public records and data, with a focus on social justice and accountability.” (7) On the other hand, Article 19, an international human rights organisation, cites author Lucinda Fleeson, who argued that investigative journalism “is not limited to exposing corruption and criminal activity, but also includes stories that explain how systems work or fail, or construct complex narratives.” (8) According to the Al Jazeera Media Institute’s Investigative Journalism Handbook, investigative journalism “should uncover new facts about a single particular issue or problem. An investigation should be original and should break new ground for the audience. It should go beyond mere fact-checking and provide ‘clear, direct and irrefutable evidence with no trace of ambiguity’.” (9) The Arab Reporters for Investigative Journalism (ARIJ) believes that this type of journalism is based on documenting information and revealing facts, in a systematic and objective way, with the aim of bringing about change that serves the public interest. (10) In general, investigative journalism seeks transparency through an independent journalistic effort to collect and accurately analyse evidence and information from multiple sources, and to reach results that draw public attention to vital issues deserving of investigation and public debate, with the aim of stimulating positive change in the public interest.

Differences Between Investigative Journalism and Traditional Journalism

Although the objectives of investigative journalism do not fundamentally differ from those of public journalism, in terms of providing citizens with the information necessary to make informed decisions about their lives, societies and governments, (11) and although their tools may appear similar at first glance, (12) investigative journalism differs from traditional journalism in several essential aspects related to objectives, methods and information-gathering practices. Traditional journalism, or routine news reporting, is primarily concerned with the direct and rapid transmission of news and information. It conveys facts as they appear, without extensive exploration of underlying dimensions, which can be likened to observing a mountain only from its visible surface. In contrast, investigative journalism, often referred to as

in-depth reporting, seeks to uncover hidden facts and expose complex issues that require prolonged examination in order to promote transparency and accountability. It does not settle for surface-level appearances but focuses on what lies beneath, thereby acquiring an investigative character that demands advanced analytical and research skills. Whereas traditional journalism often relies on official or readily available sources, such as press releases and public statements, enabling rapid dissemination with limited depth, investigative journalism employs deeper research techniques. These include examining public records, interviewing undisclosed or confidential sources, and gathering corroborating evidence, allowing for the revelation of precise details and the production of comprehensive investigations that go beyond information accessible to the general public. Media content in traditional journalism is typically produced under pressure to meet real-time, daily or periodic publication requirements, with priority given to speed. Investigative journalism, by contrast, requires significantly more time and effort. Investigations may extend over weeks, months or even years, given the necessity of systematically collecting, verifying and analysing evidence to ensure the delivery of reliable content and clarify ambiguous dimensions for the public. The comparison between traditional and investigative journalism also reveals stylistic differences. Traditional journalism is characterised by a direct and objective presentation that prioritises clarity and immediacy over depth, facilitating rapid consumption of news. Investigative journalism, on the other hand, follows a complex methodological framework that involves hypothesis formulation, testing and reliance on multiple sources, ultimately producing precise and comprehensive results. This approach grants investigative journalism a profound analytical dimension, as journalists seek to present an integrated disclosure of obscured or ambiguous information. The distinction between the two fields also extends to their impact on the public. Traditional journalism aims to inform the public immediately by presenting events as they occur, without delving into their deeper implications, making it a fast and accessible mode of information. Investigative journalism seeks to exert a deeper influence by providing insights into underlying issues, stimulating public debate, encouraging critical thinking, and promoting reform and social change, thereby acting as a driving force for transparency and accountability.

Table 1: Differences Between Investigative and Traditional Journalism

2. The Intersections of Scientific Approaches with Investigative Journalism

Investigative Journalism and the Use of the Scientific Method

The term “method” is derived from the French word *méthode*, which in turn originates from a Greek root meaning “path” or “approach” leading toward a specific purpose. This concept did not acquire its widely recognised epistemological meaning, as a set of rules governing access to scientific truth, until the early European Renaissance, when logicians devoted particular attention to the concept of method as a component of logical reasoning. This intellectual interest gradually evolved, until the term came to denote its contemporary meaning, namely a structured way of uncovering truth through a set of rules that regulate cognitive processes and direct them toward specific results. (13) The scientific method is defined as the art of organising ideas in a coherent and logical manner, either for the purpose of discovering new knowledge or for demonstrating established facts to others. (14) Research steps are carefully coordinated, and research tools are clearly defined to ensure the production of valid and reliable knowledge. Within the field of investigative journalism, the scientific method represents a systematic and continuous path aimed at approaching and uncovering the truth. It connects journalistic investigative mechanisms with rational principles derived from scientific methodologies. Investigative reporting seeks to track, verify and validate information, and subsequently present it to the public with a high degree of objectivity and credibility, a practice commonly referred to within journalistic circles as “transferring facts” to the public. Nevertheless, there is no single unified methodological framework

capable of addressing all investigative phenomena. Investigative approaches vary according to the diversity of issues, the nature of the facts involved, and the methods by which information is concealed or distorted. This diversity necessitates the use of multiple tools and methodologies drawn from different scientific approaches. In their book, *The Elements of Journalism: What Newspeople Should Know and the Public Should Expect*, Bill Kovach and Tom Rosenstiel emphasise that investigative journalism requires methodological flexibility, enabling journalists to employ appropriate scientific tools in accordance with the nature of the facts and the objectives of disclosure. (15) Among the most prominent scientific approaches that investigative journalists draw upon is the descriptive approach, which relies on comprehensive and accurate collection and description of data and information. (16) This approach is particularly useful when monitoring actual conditions on the ground or when analysing statistics and numerical data to construct an overall picture of an issue. The historical approach is employed when investigating issues with extended temporal dimensions or when examining social phenomena rooted in past events, such as conflicts or wars. (17) This approach involves reviewing archival records and historical documents and comparing them with contemporary testimonies, thereby facilitating an understanding of the contexts and trajectories that have shaped present realities. The inferential approach emerges when journalists begin with general hypotheses regarding the existence of corruption or violations and subsequently search for concrete evidence to substantiate these assumptions. Conversely, the inductive approach is particularly suited to investigations based on fragmented or scattered data, where journalists assemble disparate elements to derive broader conclusions or hypotheses. The analytical approach is also employed in cases that require the decomposition of complex phenomena into constituent elements and the examination of their interactions, whether through quantitative data analysis or the study of institutional structures and relational networks. This approach may require advanced data analysis techniques to reveal underlying patterns and future implications. (18) Despite the strong connection between investigative journalism and the scientific method, fundamental differences remain between the work of investigative journalists and academic researchers. (19) Journalistic practice often necessitates flexibility and confidentiality in dealing with sources to ensure their protection. Journalists are also required to condense content to fit media formats and time constraints. Moreover, investigative reporting relies more heavily on direct fieldwork and interaction with actors, whereas scientific research demands a higher degree of procedural rigour and comprehensive documentation, enabling replication or verification by other researchers. The multiplicity of methodologies responds to the need for investigative journalism to address issues that vary in context, involved actors, available data and the nature of concealed information. Political investigations often benefit from combining historical and analytical approaches to trace origins and monitor transformations. Social investigations typically rely on interviews and field observation within an inductive framework. Economic and financial investigations require complex analytical models that integrate quantitative and qualitative methods. The integration of multiple approaches enhances the credibility of findings and provides a comprehensive understanding of the subject, as each methodology compensates for potential limitations inherent in others. Ultimately, the objective of investigative journalism, like that of scientific research, remains the attainment of the highest possible level of accuracy and objectivity in revealing facts, despite differences in procedures, presentation formats and target audiences. Accordingly, methodological plurality in investigative journalism is a practical necessity driven by the diversity of issues addressed. When investigative journalists pose their central question, namely, how to reach the truth in a given case, they encounter a range of methodological options from which

they must select those most appropriate to their subject, data and available resources. Their ultimate aim is twofold: to achieve the highest degree of objectivity, and to serve public interest by uncovering facts that might otherwise remain obscured without investigative effort. The Methodology of Investigative Journalism The methodological process of investigative journalism consists of a series of sequential stages that enable journalists to access accurate and reliable facts related to the issues under investigation. The following represents the most important stages of this process.

First: Identifying the problem or issue The investigative process begins with the identification of the subject matter, which must be of significant public interest. The problem should be clearly and precisely formulated in a single sentence that includes the perpetrator or responsible party, the victim or affected party, and the scope or magnitude of the problem. This step is comparable to problem identification in scientific research, which is defined as “a subject surrounded by ambiguity or a phenomenon in need of interpretation”. (20) It may also be understood as a question requiring explanation, the clarification of its dimensions, and the identification of its variables. The importance of problem identification lies in its role as the primary and specific driver of all subsequent investigative stages. (21) The accuracy of its formulation directly influences the direction of the investigation and determines its scope. Identifying and defining the dimensions of a problem is often more challenging than proposing solutions, as this step precisely maps the investigative trajectory and establishes the boundaries of inquiry.

Second: Determining the hypothesis Following the accurate formulation of the problem, the investigator proceeds to articulate the issue through a set of questions and hypotheses that are measurable and subject to scrutiny. These hypotheses guide the information-gathering process and assist in characterising the phenomenon or event under investigation. In investigative journalism, this stage is referred to as “hypothesis formulation”. In scientific research, a hypothesis is defined as an interpretation of a presumed relationship between two or more variables, typically expressed in testable and verifiable terms, (22) or formulated as conditional statements of a deductive or speculative nature. In journalistic practice, however, a hypothesis is viewed as a proposed explanation of a problematic issue that requires investigation, research and documentation. (23) Article 19 defines a hypothesis as a proposed explanation of a phenomenon or a logical proposition linking multiple phenomena, enabling investigative journalists to construct hypotheses that regulate the course of investigation and determine its directions in accordance with a structured scientific methodology. Based on these definitions, the hypothesis in investigative journalism can be understood as a narrative that requires systematic testing. (24) It includes a clear definition of the problem, identification of potential responsible parties, underlying causes and anticipated consequences. Hypothesis formulation extends beyond establishing relationships between variables to constructing an integrated narrative framework that organises the elements of the investigative story. It functions as a guiding focus for the research process and represents a “systematic assumption” that directs the journalist toward specific angles of inquiry, enhances the testing of potential causal links, and ultimately leads to evidence-based conclusions that present the reader with a comprehensive understanding of the issue.

Table 2: Models for the Formulation of Hypotheses in Investigative Journalism

Third: Determining the hypothesis provisions and formulating questions Once the hypothesis has been formulated, the next stage involves breaking it down into specific components and developing a detailed set of questions to guide the investigation. This process aims to analyse the hypothesis by identifying its key elements, enabling the journalist to determine relevant actors, causes and effects, as well as to explore contextual factors surrounding each component, thereby facilitating accurate and reliable answers. Formulating detailed questions at the outset of an investigation is a critical methodological tool for ensuring

systematic access to truth. It contributes to organising ideas, selecting appropriate sources, and identifying suitable research instruments. Moreover, dismantling the hypothesis into precise components and investigative questions enhances the effectiveness of investigative procedures, as it increases the likelihood of uncovering intersecting relationships among the various factors influencing the case. This approach ultimately supports the development of well-founded conclusions, strengthens investigative quality, and enhances credibility and impact.

Table 3: Model of Hypothesis and Investigative Questions

Fourth: Identifying sources and collecting information

After the hypothesis has been formulated, its components defined, and detailed questions established, the next stage involves identifying the sources that will be used to collect the information necessary for the investigation. This stage is central to investigative methodology, as it ensures access to accurate, diverse and verifiable data that enables journalists to construct a comprehensive understanding of the issue under study. Source identification involves selecting both primary and secondary sources. Primary sources include eyewitness testimonies, direct interviews, field observations, official documents and data obtained from public or private institutions. Secondary sources consist of previous studies, published reports, academic research and relevant media materials. The careful selection of sources contributes to achieving balance and comprehensiveness in the investigation and facilitates verification through comparison and cross-referencing. The use of multiple research tools, such as interviews, document analysis and direct observation, enables the journalist to approach the issue from different perspectives and enhances the reliability of findings. During this stage, it is essential to distinguish between data and information. Data are defined as raw, unprocessed facts that are often fragmented and presented without interpretation or bias. (25) In their initial form, data consist of numbers, symbols or isolated observations that lack inherent meaning (26). Their value emerges only after they are processed and organised. Information, by contrast, refers to data that has been processed, structured and contextualised. (27) Information appears in the form of coherent statements, reports or visual representations, such as charts and tables, and can be directly used in analysis and decision-making. Information provides interpretive value and deeper understanding, enabling the identification of patterns and the formulation of conclusions.

Fifth: Proof of the hypothesis

Substantiating the investigative hypothesis requires the application of multiple verification mechanisms that enhance the credibility and accuracy of findings. These mechanisms include cross-checking testimonies from primary sources, particularly eyewitnesses, whose accounts are used to confirm factual details. The journalist's direct engagement with the field also contributes to contextual understanding by allowing firsthand observation of events or conditions under investigation. Additional verification tools include the use of specialised techniques, such as covert observation of when information is otherwise inaccessible, as well as reliance on studies, reports and statistical data that provide a scientific foundation for the investigation. Surveys and questionnaires may be employed to capture public perceptions or attitudes related to the issue, (28) while expert opinions support analysis by offering specialised insight into technical or institutional dimensions of the subject. In certain cases, secret audio or video recordings may be used to ensure the accuracy of information obtained from private sources, subject to ethical and legal constraints. The method of reconstruction is also employed to objectively reassemble events, enabling clarification of complex sequences and validation of the hypothesis. Together, these mechanisms strengthen the evidentiary basis of investigative reporting and support the production of reliable and well-substantiated conclusions.

Sixth: Editing the investigative story

Editing represents the final stage of investigative work and involves constructing an integrated narrative that combines factual

rigour with coherent storytelling. This stage seeks to achieve two complementary objectives: the transmission of knowledge and the effective presentation of information. Characters constitute a central component of the investigative story and include both principal and secondary figures whose actions drive the narrative. These characters must be presented with clear social and psychological dimensions to facilitate reader engagement and comprehension of motivations and consequences. Context is another essential element in shaping the investigative narrative. It situates events within their temporal and spatial frameworks and explains the circumstances surrounding them, thereby enabling the reader to understand the relationships between actors and developments.

Contextualisation enhances credibility by clarifying the factors that generate conflict and by grounding the narrative in objective conditions. Conflict represents the core of the investigative story, as it generates tension and movement through interactions among individuals, institutions or interests. Conflict may manifest externally, through confrontation between actors, or internally, through moral or psychological struggles. The gradual development of conflict through escalating challenges contributes to narrative coherence, sustains reader attention and reinforces the analytical depth of the investigation. The conclusion constitutes the resolution of the investigative narrative. It presents the outcomes of the investigation, addresses the questions raised throughout the story, clarifies the consequences for the actors involved, and outlines potential future implications. A well-constructed conclusion provides narrative closure while reinforcing the dual purpose of investigative journalism, namely the delivery of verified knowledge and the articulation of broader societal implications.

3. Methodological Challenges in Investigative Journalism Investigative journalism remains a specialised journalistic practice grounded in rigorous documentation and in-depth research, requiring strict adherence to scientific and professional methodologies. While journalistic work in general is susceptible to error, mistakes in investigative journalism can have particularly serious consequences. Investigative journalists are therefore required to apply research methodologies with precision and consistency, regardless of the difficulties encountered during the investigative process. This reality necessitates the continuous development of journalists' capacity to analyse the challenges they face, devise effective strategies to address them, and adapt flexibly to changing conditions. Strengthening these capacities contributes to improving the efficiency and accuracy of investigative work and ensures the achievement of its intended objectives. Four primary challenges commonly confront investigative journalists in practice: time constraints that limit research depth, ethical constraints that demand strict professional compliance, obstacles related to access to information, and the need for caution when dealing with confidential sources.

First: Time limitations Time constraints constitute one of the most significant challenges in investigative journalism. The nature of investigative work requires extended periods for comprehensive data collection and analysis. However, media environments often impose strict deadlines driven by accelerated publishing cycles and audience demand for immediate information. This challenge requires journalists to balance the pursuit of quality with the pressure for speed. In some cases, journalists may be compelled to shorten investigative stages or make rapid analytical decisions, potentially affecting accuracy. Consequently, effective time management and prioritisation become essential, with emphasis placed on the most critical investigative components in order to deliver accurate and reliable information without compromising professional standards or content quality.

Second: Ethical constraints Ethical considerations represent a fundamental challenge in investigative journalism. Journalists must make sensitive decisions related to privacy, integrity and individual rights. These decisions include protecting confidential sources, avoiding bias and refraining from deceptive information-gathering practices, all of which are essential for maintaining

investigative credibility and adherence to professional ethics. Despite pressures arising from sensitive topics or institutional demands, investigative journalists are required to balance access to information with unwavering commitment to ethical standards. Such commitment safeguards individual rights and affirms the legitimacy of investigative journalism as a responsible practice dedicated to transparency and accountability. Ethical responsibility supersedes institutional obligations and requires adherence to professional codes that define journalistic conduct. In the Moroccan context, these principles are enshrined in the Charter of Ethics for the Profession of Journalism, (29) which establishes binding standards of professional conduct. In accordance with these standards, investigative journalism does not rely on impersonation or hidden cameras as foundational practices, contrary to some misconceptions. Instead, professional values emphasise credibility, transparency and the use of lawful and ethical methods of information collection, with due respect for rights and privacy. Adherence to these principles enhances both the credibility of investigative outcomes and the role of the press as a responsible oversight institution operating within a clear legal and ethical framework.

Third: Obstacles to accessing information Access to information constitutes one of the most persistent challenges facing investigative journalists. Legal, administrative or institutional barriers may restrict access to documents or data, sometimes through deliberate obstruction or information blackout. In such cases, journalists may be compelled to rely on alternative sources, including public records, prior studies or informal sources, requiring adaptability and innovative strategies to obtain necessary information. In principle, the right to access information is a key indicator of human rights conditions within a state, as it is based on the premise that information should be available without justification. Information is defined as data expressed in numerical, textual, visual or audiovisual forms contained in documents, reports, studies, decisions, databases and other records produced or held by public institutions within the scope of their functions. (30) In Morocco, Article 27 of the Constitution guarantees citizens' right to access information held by public administrations, elected bodies and institutions performing public service functions, subject only to legal limitations. Article VI of the Press and Publication Law further affirms journalists' right to access information from various sources, except in cases involving confidentiality, such as national security, internal or external state security, personal privacy, or the protection of fundamental rights and freedoms. This article also obliges public authorities to provide journalists with information within legally specified timeframes, with penalties imposed on entities that refuse compliance. A major challenge lies in the effective implementation of Law No. 31.13 on the right of access to information. Although it was adopted after an eight-year ratification process and entered into force on 12 March 2020, practical shortcomings have emerged, prompting calls for amendments aimed at strengthening its effectiveness and enhancing transparency for journalists and citizens alike.

Fourth: Dealing with confidential sources Engaging with confidential sources is one of the most sensitive challenges in investigative journalism. It requires balancing the obligation to protect the source's anonymity with the need to ensure the accuracy and reliability of information. This challenge is particularly acute in investigations involving sensitive issues, where disclosure of a source's identity may pose serious personal or professional risks. Investigative journalists bear both moral and legal responsibility to protect confidential sources. This obligation necessitates the adoption of strict security measures, such as encryption tools and careful handling of information that could reveal a source's identity. At the same time, journalists must independently verify information obtained from confidential sources to prevent misinformation or manipulation. Protecting confidential sources is a cornerstone of investigative ethics, as it fosters trust between journalists and informants and reinforces the credibility of the press as an institution committed to public

interest and professional integrity. To manage confidential sources effectively, investigative journalists should adhere to four guiding principles: attributing information transparently to its source when possible, recognising that accounts may differ even among closely involved sources, avoiding reliance on minors as sources, particularly in criminal cases, and prioritising sources with direct relevance to the issue to ensure accuracy and comprehensiveness.

Conclusion This study has provided an in-depth analysis of the intersections between scientific methodologies and investigative journalism, highlighting the methodological steps required to conduct rigorous investigative reporting. The findings demonstrate a strong convergence between scientific research methods and investigative journalism practices, as both rely on problem identification, hypothesis formulation, and strict commitment to accuracy and objectivity. Despite these similarities, investigative journalism retains a degree of methodological flexibility that distinguishes it from academic research, without undermining shared foundations aimed at producing reliable results. The study emphasises that effective investigative journalism depends on adherence to ethical standards that ensure credibility and protect both sources and subjects, particularly in sensitive investigations. Protecting sources, avoiding manipulation and maintaining objectivity constitute essential pillars for strengthening public trust and reinforcing the role of the press as a responsible oversight institution. Finally, the study identifies four major challenges confronting investigative journalists, namely time constraints, ethical obligations, barriers to accessing information, and the complexities of managing confidential sources. Addressing these challenges requires adaptability, continuous skill development, and unwavering commitment to professional standards. By overcoming these obstacles, investigative journalism can serve the public interest more effectively, enhance societal awareness, and contribute meaningfully to transparency and accountability.

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17. Why Trump Hesitates to Go to War with Iran

URL: <http://studies.aljazeera.net/en/analyses/why-trump-hesitates-go-war-iran>

After the brazen violation of international law represented by the abduction of Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro, tensions in the Middle East have escalated dramatically in recent weeks, prompting growing speculation about a direct clash between the United States and Iran. It is crucial to understand why the United States has not yet engaged in military action against Iran. Washington is not hesitant because it lacks overwhelming military capability—far from it. It has hesitated because, in the case of Iran, power does not translate into speed, and speed is the currency Donald Trump values most. The common belief in the West is that Iran is weak, overextended and just putting on a brave face. However, this belief is based on a mistaken idea: that a war with Iran would be quick, controllable, and ultimately end in a way that benefits the United States. This view is dangerously naive. Iran has spent decades preparing not to win quickly, but ensuring that any conflict with its adversaries becomes drawn out and costly. Its strategy is not centred on territorial conquest or flashy tactical successes. Instead, it is built on endurance and the imposition of costs. Iran does not aim for a knockout blow; it seeks to draw its enemies into prolonged conflicts that drain their resources, erode political capital, and consume time—ultimately exhausting even the most powerful militaries. This is precisely why the United States remains hesitant—and why Donald Trump, in

particular, treads carefully. Trump is a gambler, but he is not suicidal. He is willing to roll the dice when he believes the odds are stacked in his favour, and the payout is immediate. Iran, however, represents a different reality: a conflict with enormous downside, limited upside, almost no plausible path to a decisive resolution, and no assurance of a clean victory. The Simple Math of Missile Defence Modern war between sophisticated actors is no longer primarily about weapon platforms, tactics or doctrine. It is about arithmetic. More specifically, it boils down to the exchange rate between offensive munitions and defensive interceptors—and the depth of the arsenals behind them. Analysts obsess over interception rates: how many Iranian missiles were shot down, or how effectively Israeli or American missile defence systems performed. But what matters is not how well defences perform on day one, but how long they can be sustained. Ballistic missile defence (BMD) interceptors are not only expensive but also slow to produce. Offensive missiles, especially those made in Iran, are comparatively cheap and easier to produce at scale. In practical terms, a single interceptor does not guarantee the defeat of a single missile. In reality, defenders frequently fire two interceptors per inbound threat to hedge against failure. Clearly, this is problematic for the defender. Iran understands this dynamic. Its strategy is built around exhausting missile defence systems rather than defeating them quickly. It is irrelevant whether 80 per cent or even 90 per cent of missiles are intercepted if the small percentage that gets through can inflict economic damage, close airspace or lower morale, thereby creating political pressure. Over time, the penetration rate increases because defensive resources become depleted. The June 2025 Iran-Israel War was an example of this reality at play. Israel's Arrow-2 and Arrow-3 interceptors were heavily expended. The United States had to step in with a backstop, deploying THAAD batteries and expending large numbers of MIM-401 Talon interceptors, alongside ship-launched SM-3 interceptors from U.S. Navy destroyers. Tactically, the defence worked. Strategically, it imposed a cost that the United States cannot afford to repeat. The depth of an arsenal is the most critical factor in any conflict. Replenishing high-end BMD interceptors takes years. Even with the most optimistic projections, restoring U.S. THAAD interceptor stocks to pre-June 2025 levels will not occur until around 2027. This is unfolding as China continues its military buildup, where these same interceptors are vital for deterrence in the Western Pacific. Every interceptor used in Israel is not available for other purposes. Each time missile defence assets are deployed to the Middle East, there is an opportunity cost. The United States is no longer operating in isolation; it is balancing a multi-theatre competition with limited resources. Iran, by contrast, needs only to ensure that its offensive arsenal remains larger than the defensive inventory arrayed against it. In this respect, Iran holds a decisive advantage. Iran's Indigenous Ecosystem Iran's capabilities are frequently misunderstood because they are evaluated piecemeal. Iranian systems are designed to operate as a coordinated ecosystem—a system of systems—each component optimised for specific roles within Iran's unique military-geographical context. Iranian ballistic missiles, cruise missiles and strike drones are tailored to operate within Iran's specific environment, meeting its strategic needs. These systems are not designed to work alone; they are intended to overwhelm and exhaust the enemy's defences through constant, unrelenting pressure. This allows for a gradual increase in pressure as a higher percentage of munitions successfully penetrate enemy defences, ultimately paving the way for a resolution to the conflict. The ecosystem includes ballistic missiles across multiple range classes, cruise missiles such as the Paveh family, propeller-driven strike drones like the Shahed-136, and others. This is why dismissing Iranian drones as "ineffective" misses the point. Drones shot down still impose a cost. They tie up combat air patrols and force the expenditure of air-defence munitions. This is a form of attrition. Ansar Allah Yemen occupies a peculiar position in Iran's

regional strategy. From a purely military standpoint, it is too far from Israel to be an optimal platform for decisive strikes. This has led some observers to dismiss Ansar Allah's role as marginal or symbolic. This is a mistake. Ansar Allah's primary role is not to launch direct, decisive attacks against Israel. Instead, the focus is on maritime coercion, economic disruption and strategic harassment. The Bab al-Mandeb Strait is a narrow chokepoint through which a vast volume of global commerce flows. Most Iranian-supplied anti-ship munitions in Ansar Allah's arsenal are optimised for range rather than payload. Their warheads are relatively small, and they are often launched in modest numbers. The objective is not to destroy warships outright, but to tie down naval assets that could be tasked elsewhere. In effect, Yemen functions as a force in being. The mere existence of credible anti-ship capabilities compels various navies to conduct escort missions for merchant traffic. Warships are a limited resource; each destroyer sent to the Red Sea is one less available for areas like the Gulf or the Pacific. Additionally, these threats drive up insurance premiums, increasing the cost of transiting the Red Sea. As a result, some shipping companies opt to avoid the region altogether, considering the risk too high, even with escort protection for their vessels.

Endurance by Design A common analytical mistake is to assume that escalation is binary: either Iran launches a massive, decisive strike or it does nothing. In reality, Iran's preferred strike pattern in a prolonged conflict would likely consist of small daily launches—ballistic missiles, cruise missiles and strike drones—interspersed with periodic larger salvos. Ballistic missile defence systems are optimised for short, intense engagements. They are not optimised for weeks of constant readiness and the resulting crew fatigue. Maintenance backlogs accumulate. Even if interception rates remain high, readiness erodes. This logic applies equally to the Israeli and American air forces. Continuous air defence operations require combat air patrols that could otherwise be used for strike missions. Every aircraft tied down defending airspace is one less attacking Iran. Iran counts this as success. Crucially, Iran's arsenal is diversified precisely to sustain this tempo: ballistic missiles, cruise missiles and strike drones. Each system compensates for the others' weaknesses. None is decisive alone; together, they create an environment in which defenders are never allowed to rest. The underappreciated fact is that wars are often decided by which side can outlast the other.

Cruise Missiles During the June 2025 Iran-Israel War, Iranian cruise missiles did not play a significant role. However, this does not imply that they would not be influential in any future conflict involving the United States. Cruise missiles matter because they solve problems that ballistic missiles cannot. They are cheaper substitutes for manned aircraft. They are more accurate than most ballistic missiles. They fly at low altitude, reducing detection time and defensive reaction windows. They are also well-suited for attacking infrastructure. Iran's cruise missile programme is the result of frustration with ballistic missile accuracy and airpower limitations. For some target types, such as oil facilities, ports and hardened aircraft shelters, accuracy matters more than destructive force. Recent design changes suggest a maturation of guidance and launcher concepts. Cruise missiles also complicate civilian–military deconfliction. Their use almost guarantees airspace closures, imposing immediate economic costs even when interceptions are successful.

The Maritime Aspect The Gulf, the Strait of Hormuz and the Bab al-Mandeb Strait are confined environments in which surface ships are inherently disadvantaged relative to land-based strike systems. Iran's maritime strike capabilities are often compared unfavourably to China's. This comparison misses the point. Iran does not need DF-21D-type systems to create a severe risk in the Gulf. It operates in much narrower waters, against slower, less manoeuvrable targets, and at ranges where intelligence, surveillance and reconnaissance (ISR) constraints are far more manageable. Within this envelope, even “cruder” anti-ship ballistic missiles and anti-ship cruise missiles can be

strategically meaningful. U.S. carriers now operate hundreds of kilometres from contested coastlines. This reduces risk but also means fewer sorties, longer flight times, greater reliance on tanker support, and a heavier reliance on standoff munitions. No ships need to be sunk for this to matter. The “Use It or Lose It” Problem Israeli assassinations of senior figures—often in their homes, sometimes alongside family members—introduced a new psychological dynamic. Iranian leaders are no longer weighing abstract regime survival alone. They are weighing personal survival. This creates a “use-or-lose” mindset. Restraint becomes less rational once escalation begins. Capabilities previously held in reserve become harder to justify withholding. A testament to this new reality is the unprecedented declaration by Iran’s Supreme National Defence Council that Iran reserves the right to launch pre-emptive strikes based on ‘objective signs of threat’. Major General Abdolrahim Mousavi, Chief of Staff of the Iranian Armed Forces, also remarked that, following the recent 12-day conflict, Iran revised its military doctrine, shifting from a purely defensive posture to an offensive posture and delivering a crushing response to any aggression. The Davidson Window The United States is no longer operating in a world in which it is the only major military player. As stated earlier, every interceptor fired in the Middle East carries an opportunity cost in the Western Pacific. The depletion of THAAD and SM-3 inventories in 2025 will not be remedied until about 2027, overlapping with the so-called Davidson window regarding China and Taiwan. Iran knows this. Israel knows this. Trump knows this. This is why symbolic action is more attractive than all-out war. The Axis of Resistance After 7 October Any serious analysis of Iran’s current posture must begin with an uncomfortable admission: the strategy pursued by Iran and Hezbollah for nearly two decades failed after Hamas’s 7 October 2023 attack on Israel. That strategy—often described as “no war, no peace”—was not foolish. On the contrary, it worked for a long time. It relied on a threat of regional escalation to deter Israel while avoiding the costs of full-scale war. For years, Israel refrained from striking many high-value Hezbollah and Iranian targets not because it lacked intelligence or capability, but because it did not want to risk a war that could devastate its economy and society. Hezbollah’s arsenal functioned as a sword of Damocles, and Iran reinforced that deterrent balance. What broke this equilibrium was not Hezbollah’s actions, but Hamas’s unexpected success on 7 October and the psychological shock that followed. Israel went onto a full war footing in Gaza, absorbing costs that would previously have been politically unacceptable. As the Gaza war dragged on, the marginal cost of expanding the conflict northward steadily declined. Iran and Hezbollah misread this shift. Their response—limited attacks calibrated to signal solidarity without triggering war—was strategically incoherent. They attempted to fine-tune escalation in an environment where Israel was no longer interested in calibration. The “no war, no peace” paradigm became a trap. Israel escalated relentlessly. The bombing of the Iranian consulate compound in Syria in April 2024 should have been a flashing red warning sign. The assassination of Fuad Shukr in Beirut on 30 July 2024, followed by the assassination of Ismail Haniyeh in Tehran the next day, marked an even more dramatic turn of events. By September, the pager and handheld radio attacks against Hezbollah obliterated whatever remained of the old rules. Hezbollah and Iran were paralysed—not because they lacked capability, but because they were trapped between two fears: the fear of all-out war and the fear of appearing impotent. Israel recognised this paralysis and exploited it. Deterrence failed not because Iran’s strategy was absurd, but because it was overtaken by political and psychological shifts triggered by mass violence. This failure matters because it reshaped escalation dynamics across the region. The old equilibrium is gone. Actors are now operating in a far less stable environment, where miscalculation is more likely and restraint is harder to sustain. Forward Deployment in Iraq One of the most underappreciated shifts since early 2024 has been the growing

importance of Jordan in American military planning against Iran. Iran's strike capabilities—imperfect as they are—have succeeded in keeping most Gulf states on the fence. The threat Iran poses to their oil, gas, desalination, aviation and broader economic infrastructure is real enough to shape political behaviour. Jordanian airbases are, for all practical purposes, as distant from Iran as Israeli airbases. Iran's shorter-range strike munitions—those most relevant to coercing Arab states—cannot be used against Jordan. As a result, Jordan has become the one place in the region—aside from Israel itself—where the United States can openly deploy offensive forces with relatively limited Iranian counter-leverage. American aircraft operating from Jordan can strike Iran while benefiting from distance, concentrated defences, and a compact footprint that economises scarce BMD assets. Iran can respond through its Iraqi non-state allies, and it likely would. But that card can only be played so many times. Iraq is not Yemen, and Iranian influence there is constrained by domestic politics and Iraqi sensitivities to becoming a battleground once again. This changing geometry helps explain why Iran has emphasised forward deployment of strike systems to Iraq. Lebanon is too close and too exposed. Yemen is too far for many systems. Iraq, on the other hand, is close enough to Israel to matter and useful for threatening American forces. Why Airpower Alone Cannot Deliver a Decision There remains a persistent belief that American airpower is omnipotent and can resolve the Iran problem through precision strikes: destroy missile sites, cripple production, decapitate leadership, and walk away. This belief ignores reality. Iran's strike systems are dispersed, mobile and increasingly hardened. Ballistic missile launchers are challenging to find and harder to destroy. Cruise missiles and drone launchers are cheap, mobile and easily concealed. Decoys further complicate targeting. Standoff munitions are finite and expensive. Their payloads are often insufficient to destroy hardened underground facilities. Against such targets, the weapon of choice is often a heavy penetrating bomb, which is not a true standoff munition and requires aircraft to operate closer to contested airspace. Airpower can impose costs. It cannot end the war. That is the reality Trump confronts—and seeks to avoid. Economic Warfare Iran's leverage over the Arab states is often underestimated because analysts focus narrowly on oil infrastructure. In reality, Iran does not need to destroy oil fields to cause an economic catastrophe. It can close the airspace. Civil aviation is the lifeblood of Dubai, Doha and Abu Dhabi, which are global hubs. Airspace closures—even temporary—have cascading effects: aircraft diversions, insurance spikes, stranded passengers and reputational damage. Tens of billions of dollars' worth of wide-body aircraft sit exposed in airports at any given time. This vulnerability explains Arab mediation efforts far better than appeals to regional harmony. These states are not neutral out of altruism. They are rational actors seeking to avoid becoming collateral damage in a war they cannot control. The closure of civilian airspace is also one of the clearest early-warning indicators of impending conflict. Unlike ballistic missiles, cruise missiles and strike drones cannot be safely deconflicted from civilian air traffic. Trump Donald Trump is particularly susceptible to the hot-hand fallacy—the belief that a series of successes reflects inherent skill rather than favourable conditions. Hitler was a gambler who mistook early successes for a sign of destiny. The remilitarisation of the Rhineland, the Anschluss, the invasion of Czechoslovakia and the defeat of France all built up the false belief that he was unbeatable. Each gamble succeeded, not because Germany was invincible, but because its opponents hesitated. These successes led to growing overconfidence. In the end, Hitler took a reckless risk by underestimating the industrial power, population strength and endurance of his enemies. His winning streak ended in catastrophic failure. Trump's is different, but the psychological pattern is familiar. He has experienced repeated instances in which aggressive posturing has led to concessions. He believes pressure works because it has before. The danger lies in assuming it will

always work. Iran is not like Venezuela, Libya or Iraq in 2003. It is a large, resilient country with significant military capabilities, including the largest ballistic missile arsenals in the Middle East, and institutions built to endure hardship and external pressure. Its regional reach, a culture centred on resistance and survival, means it does not have to win fast; it only needs to make sure its opponents don't. Trump knows how a failed military gamble can destroy a presidency. He also understands that a prolonged Middle Eastern war would shatter his narrative. This is why symbolic strikes—demonstrations of resolve without open-ended escalation—are far more attractive than full-scale war. Conclusion If the illusion of a swift victory is removed, what is left is a drawn-out war of attrition with no true winners. From this viewpoint, diplomacy becomes the only realistic option. The Middle East is already facing a host of issues, and any escalation into war would be disastrous for everyone involved. Chinese military general and strategist Sun Tzu famously wrote, "When you surround an army, leave an outlet free." This does not mean allowing the enemy to escape. Rather, as Chinese politician and poet Du Mu explains in his commentary on *The Art of War*, the purpose is to "make him believe that there is a road to safety, and thus prevent his fighting with the courage of despair." That logic applies here. Iran and the wider "Axis of Resistance" possess the means to set the region on fire, and if they believe they have nothing left to lose, there is little reason to think they would refrain from doing so. Iranian officials have hinted as much. More importantly, 2026 is a critical year for the Trump presidency. It is difficult to imagine him risking his presidency on a prolonged war in the Middle East, with its inevitable economic fallout – something that was, and likely still is, Anathema to his platform. Trump is motivated by the desire to win and to win fast. While victory might be possible, it would come at an enormous cost, and expecting a quick, decisive outcome is unrealistic. That's why I believe a symbolic strike—one that shows strength without causing uncontrollable escalation—is much more likely. This could be paired with increased economic and political pressure aimed at gradually destabilising Iran, much like boiling a frog. (1) Ali Harb, "Trump's abduction of Maduro escalates concerns over potential war with Iran", Al Jazeera, 5 January 2026, <https://tinyurl.com/2wswxan5> (accessed 24 January 2026). (2) Kayla Epstein, "Trump's seizure of Maduro raises thorny legal questions", BBC, 5 January 2026, <https://tinyurl.com/376nctnw> (accessed 29 January 2026). (3) Wes Rumbaugh, "The Depleting Missile Defence Interceptor Inventory", Center for Strategic & International Studies, 5 December 2025, <https://tinyurl.com/mtsmmmfn> (accessed 30 January 2026). (4) Thibault Denamiel, et al., "The Global Economic Consequences of the Attacks on Red Sea Shipping Lanes", Center for Strategic & International Studies, 22 January 2024, <https://tinyurl.com/4dx68nya> (accessed 1 February 2026). (5) Agnes Chang, Pablo Robles and Keith Bradsher, "How Houthi Attacks in the Red Sea Upended Global Shipping", The New York Times, 21 January 2024, <https://tinyurl.com/yex9tf2s> (accessed 1 February 2026). (6) Shahryar Pasandideh, "Many appear to be making the mistake of...", X, <https://tinyurl.com/cthzmtkb> (accessed 2 February 2026). (7) Shahryar Pasandideh, "Hizballah and Iran's strategy appear to be in tatters following...", X, <https://tinyurl.com/3y wzpp78> (accessed 2 February 2026). (8) Shahryar Pasandideh, "Whether or not the relevant Iranian decision-makers view...", X, <https://tinyurl.com/mr2w2fnf> (accessed 3 February 2026). (9) Sun Tzu, *The Art of War*, chapter 7, passage 36, translated on SunTzuSaid.com, <https://tinyurl.com/29fwykm8> (accessed 4 February 2026). (10) Roohola Ramezani, "Iran is rewriting its rules of war—and raising the stakes for everyone", Australian Strategic Policy Institute, 9 January 2026, <https://tinyurl.com/3vcm6zvz> (accessed 7 February 2026). (11) "Iran Shifts to Offensive Military Doctrine: Top General", Tasnim News Agency, 2 February 2026, <https://tinyurl.com/5ccfy32e> (accessed 7 February 2026).

18. Proceedings of the 17th Al Jazeera Forum: The Palestinian Cause and the Regional Balance of Power in the Context of an Emerging Multipolar World

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The 17th Al Jazeera Forum was held in Doha from 7 to 9 February 2026, with participation from a diverse group of policymakers, researchers, experts and media professionals. The forum focused on the Palestinian cause within the context of rapid regional and international transformations. Its sessions took place amid complex political and security developments that have reshaped regional priorities and sparked extensive discussions on the future of regional balances and the Middle East's place in an evolving international system. In his opening remarks, Sheikh Hamad bin Thamer Al Thani, Chairman of the Board of Al Jazeera Media Network, emphasised that the forum convened at a highly sensitive moment of accelerating regional and international changes. He noted that the forum's theme reflects a new reality in which power intersects with law along shifting international trajectories. He highlighted that the forum's value lies in its discussions of major issues with balanced perspectives, intellectual courage and integrity. He touched on the transformations experienced by the Palestinian cause during the war on Gaza, describing it as a turning point amid attempts to reoccupy the Gaza Strip, displace its population, and annex what remains of the West Bank. He noted that the war brought the cause back to the forefront of global attention and sparked widespread solidarity, making recognition of the Palestinian state an increasingly prominent demand. He also affirmed that hosting the forum continues Al Jazeera's mission to ensure access to knowledge and responsible debate, honouring the sacrifices of its correspondents who lost their lives while reporting the truth, and reaffirming the network's commitment to its professional mission despite challenges. Sheikh Nasser bin Faisal Al Thani, Director General of Al Jazeera Network, speaking through Mohammed Mukhtar Al Khalil, Director of Al Jazeera Centre for Studies, stated that the forum extends a path established by the network over more than three decades, positioning it as a platform for dialogue and a meeting point for policymakers and media figures. He emphasised that Al Jazeera was built on the principle of "opinion and counter-opinion", valuing plurality and celebrating human cultures, while shaping editorial policies that uphold human dignity and recognise diverse perspectives. The 17th edition of the forum continues a tradition spanning more than two decades, bringing together researchers and decision-makers in a communicative space extending from television screens to digital platforms under the network's unifying slogan. He described the current international moment as a phase dominated by global instability, the dominance of power, and the weakening of rules governing international relations. He called for prioritising truth and reinforcing human values to prevent further wars and crises, stressing that humanity has historically overcome hardships by adhering to justice and rejecting the law of might. He concluded by affirming that Al Jazeera will continue its mission with professional rigour and thoughtful awareness, remaining a unifying platform for dialogue and diverse perspectives in a world undergoing profound change. Somali President Hassan Sheikh Mohamud warned that the world faces a crossroads threatening the rules-based international order, with the resurgence of power politics and declining respect for international law. He linked developments in Gaza to the risks of

global fragmentation, stressing that the absence of a just solution to the Palestinian question undermines international peace and security. He also highlighted the implications of regional moves in the Horn of Africa and the Red Sea, emphasising the need to protect state sovereignty and secure vital passages. Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi asserted that Palestine has become an ethical benchmark for the international system amid the erosion of international law and the rise of power politics. He argued that impunity and the normalisation of violence threaten the foundations of global justice and called for a coordinated strategy based on activating international legal mechanisms, imposing restrictions on military cooperation, and creating a political pathway to end the occupation. Similarly, Burhanettin Duran, Head of the Directorate of Communications of the Republic of Türkiye, emphasised that the ongoing transformation goes beyond traditional power balances, targeting the very nature of conflict, as information warfare has become integral to confrontation. He noted that the post-war phase is as strategic as the war itself, and that Gaza and Syria illustrate conflicts that do not end with ceasefires but through the reconstruction of governance systems, infrastructure and political pathways. Yemeni Deputy Foreign Minister Mustapha Ahmed Noman stressed that the region faces complex challenges requiring the restoration of state authority and institutions, warning of the risks posed by armed groups operating outside state control. He linked Yemen's stability to restoring security, unifying military formations under a disciplined national doctrine, and ensuring the continuity of services and salaries, arguing that disarmament and adherence to the political process are prerequisites for any sustainable settlement. Khaled Meshaal, Head of Hamas abroad, described the Palestinian people as facing a complex historical moment, noting that ending the war does not equate to ending the conflict. He affirmed that resistance is linked to the existence of occupation and declared the movement open to approaches based on political and security guarantees. He viewed thwarting displacement projects as a central achievement at this stage and called for leveraging international transformations to reaffirm the essence of the Palestinian cause as one of occupation and the right to self-determination. Victor Gao, Vice President of the Center for China and Globalization, argued that the international system is at a historic turning point and that 2026 may mark the beginning of the end of unipolar dominance. He highlighted the limited prospects for economic decoupling from China given its industrial and economic weight and reaffirmed his country's commitment to UN principles and international law, in contrast to the increasing use of unilateral sanctions outside legal frameworks. Following these speeches, the forum moved into dedicated sessions addressing interconnected themes related to the Palestinian issue, regional transformations and the reshaping of the international system. A key focus of the discussions was the political and legal trajectories of the Palestinian cause post-war. Gaza was examined as a focal point where the resistance project intersects with occupation plans and internationalisation proposals, with attention to ongoing challenges of displacement and geopolitical restructuring. Political initiatives, including the Trump peace plan, were analysed in terms of consistency with international law and the right to self-determination, amid continued occupation, settlement expansion and Palestinian division. Discussions also addressed accountability and the rule of law, highlighting the gap between clear facts and implementation, and stressing the need for legal tools to be accompanied by political will to consolidate the principle of accountability. The sessions also explored regional transformations and shifts in regional power balances following the Gaza war, noting that declining Arab influence is linked to ongoing internal crises and economic and security fragility, underscoring the need to rebuild national institutions and develop more effective coordination mechanisms. The discussions concluded that the region is undergoing strategic repositioning, where security calculations intersect with broader international

shifts. On a broader scale, the sessions examined changes in the international system amid rising multipolarity and evolving competition patterns, emphasising the Middle East's growing role in shaping global balances. The impact of the digital revolution on power redistribution was also explored, discussing how modern technologies reshape deterrence and dominance, with cyberspace emerging as a central arena in contemporary conflicts. The forum also gave attention to the battle of narratives and influence in the digital environment, discussing the emergence of influencers and content creators as key actors in shaping public opinion, along with the associated professional and ethical challenges related to verification and trust-building. The effect of digital platforms and their algorithms on the public sphere was analysed, highlighting the importance of translating "digital sympathy" into tangible political and humanitarian impact. Cultural and human rights dimensions were also highlighted. The film *Madleen* was screened, illustrating the use of AI techniques to reconstruct scenes lacking field coverage, prompting discussion on the limits of this type of documentation. The film *The Last Doctor Standing* was also shown, serving as a human testimony to the realities faced by medical teams amid the collapse of the healthcare system, examining the targeting of the health sector and the role of cinematic documentation in preserving memory and reinforcing accountability. In his closing remarks, Dr. Al Khalil affirmed that the forum continues its long-standing tradition of providing a platform for dialogue that brings together researchers and policymakers, recognising diverse perspectives and celebrating differences. He described the current international moment as characterised by the dominance of power and weakening of the rules governing international relations, urging the use of thought and dialogue to prevent further wars and crises. He expressed confidence in humanity's ability to overcome its challenges if truth, justice and human values are upheld, reaffirming the network's ongoing professional mission and its commitment to remaining a unifying platform for dialogue and pluralism.

19. Iran's Internal Challenges and Confrontations Abroad

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Introduction The developments began in Tehran's bazaar, where traders protested fluctuations in the national currency. These protests quickly spread to other cities in response to inflation, declining purchasing power, and deteriorating economic conditions. After ten days of peaceful demonstrations and slogans focused on improving living standards, Iran entered a phase of violence that was rare in the country. Protest slogans moved beyond economic grievances to directly target the regime and the country's security and stability. Developments did not stop at Iran's borders. Israeli politicians encouraged Iranians to persist until the overthrow of the regime. The US president reinforced this position by explicitly threatening to come to the "aid" of demonstrators if the authorities began killing them. (1) This paper aims to clarify the circumstances of the protests, their trajectory, and the violence that accompanied their conclusion, before examining their domestic impact and outcomes, as well as Iran's interactions with external actors, particularly the United States. New Policy and Protest

Protests have been a recurring feature in contemporary Iran, and periods of escalation or decline do not necessarily mean that the country is experiencing an exceptional moment. What distinguishes the recent wave, however, is what accompanied the protests: first, the declared and explicit support for the protests and the accompanying acts of violence by Israel and the United States; and second, the level of violence itself, which the Iranian government has described as

“armed terrorism”. Iran is currently experiencing one of its most sustained periods of protests in recent years. Each wave of protest has a primary driving force. For example, two years ago, the protests were driven by the issue of the veil. This does not mean that other motives were absent. The recent wave of protests was driven by the deterioration of economic conditions and the growing popular discontent over the decline in the value of the Iranian currency, the rial, against the dollar, as well as the steady erosion of citizens’ purchasing power. Currency depreciation played a key role in the initial wave of bazaar protests in Tehran. Many traders and merchants in Iran’s largest bazaar closed their shops and organised demonstrations, arguing that instability in the dollar exchange rate prevented them from conducting business. Importers, for example, purchase goods at one exchange rate, and after selling them, are forced to import again at higher prices that exceed the value of their sales. Iranian authorities, including the Supreme Leader and the President, expressed understanding of these demands and acknowledged the protesters’ rights, which helped prevent clashes. (2) This situation persisted for approximately ten days. President Masoud Pezeshkian’s government announced sweeping economic reforms, focusing on changing the policy of subsidising imports in order to decouple prices from the dollar exchange rate and thus control the rising cost of living. These policies are complex, but their main pillars are outlined here to clarify the broader picture. It had become customary practice for a group of companies and institutions to obtain dollars from the Central Bank at subsidised rates in order to import essential goods and medicine and sell them to citizens at prices below market rates. In theory, importers were required to sell goods at subsidised prices and return the equivalent amount of dollars to the Central Bank after completing the process. In practice, however, this system failed to achieve its intended goals, and the entire process became rife with financial and economic corruption. The Minister of Economy recently announced that many importing entities failed to return the dollars they had received to the Central Bank, while others sold imported goods at market prices rather than subsidised ones. Over decades, this system evolved into a mechanism of corruption, with importers treating subsidised dollars as “rents” for personal gain rather than for the benefit of citizens. Oversight efforts ultimately failed to curb this corruption. As a result, the government announced the suspension of subsidised dollar allocations to importers. (3) Because commodity prices would now reflect market exchange rates, the government announced that it would distribute the difference between the subsidised rate and the market rate to citizens in the form of grants. In Pezeshkian’s words, the government decided to provide direct support to the final link in the supply chain, the citizen, instead of indirectly subsidising the first link, the importer. This policy aims to eliminate one of the country’s most significant sources of financial corruption and retain hard currency reserves in government hands, enabling better control of the exchange rate and slowing the depreciation of the national currency. Those who benefited from the previous system therefore opposed the policy and sought to mobilise the bazaar against the government’s measures. But managing these pressures and allowing society to adapt to the new reality requires time. The announcement of this major policy shift did not immediately calm the market or reassure citizens. Nevertheless, the government began implementing the policy during the protests in hopes of slowing their momentum. Bazaar protests continued for nearly ten days, during which demonstrations spread to several smaller and border cities, particularly in western Iran. Authorities sought to avoid confrontation with protesters, although some incidents of violence were reported. However, after one of the most prominent opposition figures abroad—the son of the Shah overthrown in the 1979 revolution—called on Iranians to rise up against the regime and take to the streets on Thursday and Friday, 8 and 9 January 2026, the country experienced a level of violence rarely witnessed in previous protests. Violence Comes to the

Protest Thursday initially resembled the preceding ten days of bazaar protests and demonstrations in other cities, which focused on economic slogans and livelihood issues. However, by Thursday evening, widespread violence erupted alongside the protests, targeting sovereign institutions across various cities and provinces. This violence included attacks on security forces, the Basij, and military and security headquarters, despite the continued official policy of avoiding direct confrontation with protesters. Gunfire was reported at several mosques and banks, and numerous public and private facilities were damaged. In the northern city of Rasht alone, the burning of a single private store led to a fire that destroyed an entire market containing dozens of shops. The shootings – some of which were captured on video, showing individuals firing indiscriminately at security forces and civilians – had a profound impact on the Iranian public. Attacks on security forces and popular mobilisation units resulted in alarming numbers of casualties, alongside numerous civilian deaths and injuries. At a single funeral ceremony held in Tehran following the violence, more than one hundred members of the security forces and civilians were commemorated. (4) As violence escalated and slogans shifted from economic demands to direct opposition to the regime, protest momentum declined sharply on the evening of Thursday, 8 January 2026. On Friday, 9 January, many protesters stayed home, and by Saturday calm had returned more quickly than many observers had anticipated. Authorities called on citizens to demonstrate against “armed terrorism” on 12 January 2026. Large crowds responded in Tehran and other cities, with officials claiming participation exceeded three million in the capital alone. No protest rallies or violence occurred. The reasons for this can be summarised as follows: - Escalating violence: By Thursday night, protests were effectively extinguished. Most protesters withdrew after scenes of violence emerged. Citizens seeking economic improvement did not wish to be drawn into acts of violence that neither advanced their demands nor improved their conditions, but instead generated insecurity, injuries and deaths. - Israeli-American support: Political figures in Israel and the United States openly called on Iranians to overthrow the regime. While protesters initially ignored these statements, many later feared that the violence was linked to these calls and began questioning whether they were being drawn into externally driven confrontations. Iranian authorities emphasised this linkage in their discourse, which resonated with citizens who had recently witnessed foreign attacks on their country and the ongoing devastation in Gaza. - Security at stake: Protesters initially mobilised to pressure the government over economic and living conditions, but chaos and insecurity quickly became a greater concern. As soon as disorder appeared, many citizens withdrew from the streets out of desire to avoid security collapse. This withdrawal does not signify acceptance of economic hardship, but rather a clear rejection of violence and armed action. - Return to the economy: Protesters’ initial focus was economic reform. Their retreat from the streets can be interpreted as an effort to reassert this priority and reject slogans and actions that shifted the protests from economic demands toward political and security confrontation. The Clash of Narratives Competing claims over the meaning of the protests and the accompanying violence became another arena of conflict in media and political discourse. Two primary narratives emerged. The opposition narrative rests on a complete rejection of the regime, portraying both protests and violence as expressions of widespread popular opposition. This narrative emphasises three dimensions: the erosion or collapse of regime legitimacy; the portrayal of entire population as unified against the ruling system; and the promotion of alternatives under the banners of “democracy” and “constitutionalism”. This narrative offers an oversimplified reading of reality. The opposition remains fragmented and has never agreed on unified leadership. Abroad, it is divided abroad between royalists, the People’s Mojahedin Organisation, and various nationalist or separatist movements. For the first time, these factions

appeared to mobilise simultaneously against the regime, a development that some observers in Iran attribute to the involvement of Israeli or American intelligence. (5) All of these groups view violence and armed confrontation as legitimate means for overthrowing the regime and have employed them in the past. Reading every protest as an attempt to overthrow the regime is overly simplistic. Many Iranians critical of economic governance do not support regime change. Even supporters of the system criticise government performance without seeking its collapse. Less than two years ago, more than half of Iranians participated in presidential elections, signalling engagement with reform through existing institutions. Moreover, leaders across Iran's political spectrum called for unity in the face of violence and foreign-backed opposition. The revival of pre-revolutionary alternatives, supported by states that attacked Iran only months earlier, has limited appeal among the population. Nevertheless, the opposition has advanced its confrontation with the regime further than in previous episodes. In contrast, the government narrative distinguishes between legitimate economic protesters and violent groups described as "armed terrorists" linked to foreign agendas. Officials recognise citizens' right to protest economic conditions while accusing violent groups of receiving foreign funding, training and weapons. This narrative asserts that economic protest does not equate to regime opposition, that the people stand with the state against foreign-backed adversaries, and that Iranians remain committed to their legal system rather than externally imposed alternatives. (6) While this narrative separates protest from violence, the reality is more complex. Those who carried out violent acts and chanted anti-regime slogans are Iranian citizens, even if they received external support. Some opposition factions openly view Israel and the United States as allies, echoing Shah-era alliances with Washington and Tel Aviv. Economic protest does not automatically translate into regime confrontation, but accumulated pressures can blur this distinction during crises. This ambiguity has been exploited by opposition forces, though with limited success. The Role of the Outside External involvement in Iran's protests took two forms: direct support for violent groups and indirect political pressure. Israeli political figures and institutions openly voiced support for the protesters, while reports also suggested involvement by Mossad. (8) Iranian authorities allege that Israeli agents smuggled weapons and sought to exploit protests. US rhetoric emphasised alleged repression and threatened intervention if protesters were killed. Authorities framed the violence as a second phase of the twelve-day war of June 2025, aimed at achieving through internal conflict what military confrontation failed to accomplish. That war ended due to Iran's missile deterrence, limited US escalation and strong domestic unity. The strategy of provoking internal chaos ultimately failed. Violence subsided rapidly, limiting international pressure and prompting a rhetorical shift from Washington. (10) Iran's Defence Council declared threats to national unity a red line, signalling a shift toward a more initiative-driven defence doctrine. (11) Iran's deterrence capabilities, readiness and rapid restoration of internal calm reduced the likelihood of renewed military confrontation. While future conflict remains possible, reliance on internal fragmentation as a strategy has significantly declined. Diplomatic prospects remain bleak. Talks between Iran and the United States have been suspended since the June war, with both sides operating under fundamentally different negotiating frameworks. The protests and associated violence have not altered Iran's position. Conclusion Protests in Iran began with economic grievances and objections to government mismanagement and lasted for ten days before opposition groups escalated violence on Thursday, 29 December 2025. As violence spread, protest momentum declined, and citizens did not return to the streets. Meanwhile, the new economic policies of Pezeshkian's government came into effect, aiming to improve living conditions and curb inflation by stabilising the dollar exchange rate and slowing the depreciation of the rial. Narratives diverged sharply: the opposition framed events as a rejection of

the entire regime, while the government distinguished economic protest from violent destabilisation. Authorities accused Israel and the United States of exploiting unrest to undermine national unity. The rapid decline in violence thwarted these efforts and reduced the risk of external targeting. With calm restored, speculation is once again focused on the possibility of future conflict or renewed negotiations between Iran and the United States. Whatever the outcome, reliance on internal division as a strategy to weaken Iran has, for now, largely failed. - Donald J. Trump, "If Iran shoots and violently kills peaceful protesters, which is their custom, the United States...", Truth Social, 2 January 2026, <https://tinyurl.com/2fm693yk> (accessed 5 February 2025). - "«[Remarks Delivered to the People of Qom]», The Supreme Leader's Official Website, 9 January 2026, <https://tinyurl.com/mryvs5fm> (accessed 14 January 2026). - "«[Several Conditions for Ending the Preferential Exchange Rate]», ISNA, 5 January 2026, <https://2u.pw/0eQxE> (accessed 16 January 2026). - "«[Funeral Procession for Over 100 Civilian and Security Martyrs Begins in Tehran]», Sputnik Iran, 14 January 2026, <https://tinyurl.com/y5kkh7py> (accessed 5 February 2026). - Abdollah Ganji, "«[The Mystery of 8 p.m.]», Fars News Agency, 12 January 2026, <https://tinyurl.com/5h4d8dd7> (accessed 14 January 2026). - "«[Remarks Delivered to the People of Qom]», The Supreme Leader's Official Website, 9 January 2026, <https://tinyurl.com/mryvs5fm> (accessed 14 January 2026). - Opposition media claim that 12,000 protesters were killed, while Israeli sources place the number at 5,000. The sources of these figures, announced immediately after the end of the events, are unknown. Meanwhile, the authorities have not yet released any statistics, stating that they will rely on forensic medicine reports to do so. The number of security personnel killed, as reflected in the funeral processions for the "martyrs of security", indicates that a substantial portion of the dead and wounded were from the ranks of security forces and the popular mobilisation. - The Persian-language Mossad page published a tweet addressing Iranians, stating that it was "with them on the ground". See "«[Mossad to Iranian Protesters: 'Take to the Streets; We Are with You on the Ground]», Euronews, 31 December 2025, <https://tinyurl.com/bde5tcty> (accessed 16 January 2026). - "«[Houshang: Recent Unrest Is a Continuation of the 12-Day War]», Tasnim News, 11 January 2026, <https://2u.pw/DJ3Qw> (accessed 16 January 2026). - Patrick Wintour and Lorenzo Tondo, "Trump says Iran has told him 'killing has stopped' as he pulls back from strike threats", The Guardian, 15 January 2026, <https://2u.pw/3lACO> (accessed 16 January 2026). - "«[Defence Council Issues Stern Warning: Iran's Security and Territorial Integrity Are an Uncrossable Red Line]», Pooya Press, 6 January 2026, <https://2u.pw/hzlyh> (accessed 16 January 2026).

20. Damascus's Approach to The SDF Question: A Shift in the Path Toward Unifying Syrian Territory

URL: <http://studies.aljazeera.net/en/analyses/damascus%E2%80%99s-approach-sdf-question-shift-path-toward-unifying-syrian-territory>

Introduction The issue of Syrian territorial unity is one of the most important priorities of the Syrian state, which inherited a fragmented geography following years of civil war. The Syrian Democratic Forces (SDF) have posed the most significant challenge to reunification efforts, maintaining separate administrative, military, and security structures from the Syrian state since 2015. Furthermore, the SDF has controlled some of Syria's most strategically important regions in the north and east, which hold key resources such as oil, gas, and wheat, granting it a considerable degree of economic autonomy. In the first year following the leadership change, the SDF approached Damascus as a counterpart—or even as an alternative—to the Syrian government. It emphasized its military's inclusion of diverse Syrian factions and advanced its own constitutional vision, claiming to represent the demands of “Syrian minorities.” In this context, the SDF held a conference in Hasakah in August 2025 titled “Unifying the Position of the Components of Northern and Eastern Syria”. It also opened its ranks to former regime officers and wanted individuals who had fled from the coastal region. Throughout negotiations with Damascus, the SDF insisted that government forces remain out of areas under its control. (1) Following the clashes between tribal and Druze factions in the Suwayda Governorate in July 2025, and the subsequent intervention of government forces, the SDF adopted an escalatory rhetoric against the Syrian government. Media and political figures close to the SDF emphasised the difficulty of dismantling of SDF forces and asserted that its weapons would remain to “defend” the Kurds. The SDF adopted a hardline stance toward the Syrian government, particularly during the nearly ten-month negotiations on the implementation of the 10 March 2025, agreement, which stipulated its integration into the Syrian state. This approach ultimately led to military confrontation, beginning with attacks carried out by SDF-affiliated elements on government forces in Aleppo in early January 2026, later spreading to the Jazira region, the SDF's main stronghold. As a result, relations between the two parties entered a new phase combining military pressure with negotiation. This paper aims to analyse Damascus's approach to the SDF as an entity demanding autonomy and refusing national reunification in accordance with the central government's vision. It also seeks to assess the outcomes of nearly three weeks of military confrontations, their economic, political and security implications, their potential repercussions at the local, regional and international levels, and their expected effects on the process of state reconstruction.

First: The Outcome of Three Weeks of Military Confrontation

The recent confrontations between the Syrian government and the SDF, which lasted from 7 to 21 January 2026, unfolded in three phases. In the first phase, government forces succeeded in taking control of three neighbourhoods in Aleppo where the SDF had been deployed: Ashrafiyeh, Sheikh Maqsoud and Bani Zeid. Subsequently, government forces extended operations to Deir Hafer and the Tishreen Dam near Manbij, to eliminate SDF forces from Aleppo entirely, except for the area of Ayn al-Arab (Kobane), which remains under SDF control. The second phase took the form of a tribal uprising in Raqqah and Deir Az Zor against SDF control. During the initial days of this uprising, government forces avoided direct intervention, particularly in areas east of the Euphrates River, which for years had served as a dividing line between areas of US influence and the rest of Syrian territory. (2) The third phase began after tribal forces gained control over the entirety of the Raqqah and Deir Az Zor Governorates. Government forces moved east of the Euphrates and began to take over areas vacated by the SDF and entered the Al-Yaarubiyah crossing on the Iraqi border. At the same time, the government tightened the siege around the remaining SDF-controlled areas inhabited by hundreds of thousands of Kurds, including Qamishli, Darbasiyah, al-Malikiyah and certain neighbourhoods in the city of Hasakah, as well as Ayn al-Arab (Kobane) in the Aleppo countryside. However, these areas were not stormed, apparently in order to avoid providing the

SDF with an opportunity to incite clashes under the pretext of defending Kurdish areas. The two sides then shifted to a phase of de-escalation without the declaration of a comprehensive ceasefire. The Syrian government was able to fully secure the city of Aleppo by removing SDF elements from elevated neighbourhoods overlooking the rest of the city, such as Ashrafiyah. This security operation was completed after government forces took control of Deir Hafer and Maskana, from which SDF drones had been launched to strike targets in Aleppo. The government's control over Raqqah and Deir Az Zor unified decision-making related to security under a single authority, thereby closing potential security gaps that could arise from poor coordination among multiple security actors. Furthermore, securing the Syrian-Iraqi border significantly reduced smuggling operations, including, at times, the trafficking of weapons. At the political level, recent military operations eroded the legitimacy of the SDF. On the one hand, the Arab component withdrew and aligned itself with the government, as demonstrated by the clear rejection of SDF rule among local communities, particularly in Arab-majority areas. On the other hand, the SDF demonstrated its willingness to abandon one of its principal tasks under the international coalition, namely the protection of prisons holding former members or suspected affiliates of the Islamic States (IS). For instance, the SDF withdrew from Shaddadi prison in the countryside of Hasakah without coordination with coalition forces, leading to the escape of dozens of detainees, only some of whom were later recaptured by government forces. On 20 January 2026, US envoy Thomas Barrack announced the end of the SDF's primary mission to combat ISIS. This development represents a form of political delegitimisation and signals a shift in the international coalition's support away from the SDF toward the Syrian government, which is bolstering its international legitimacy through counterterrorism efforts. (3) Economically, the Syrian government has achieved substantial gains through territorial expansion and restored control. These gains include the recovery of areas containing most of Syria's oil and gas reserves, as well as major fields such as al-Hol, al-Omar, Conoco and al-Tanak. Conversely, the SDF has lost critical economic resources that, over nearly eleven years, had enabled it to consolidate its self-administration across an area estimated at roughly one quarter of Syrian territory and to finance volunteer expenditures within its ranks. Second: Possible Implications of Developments between Damascus and the SDF Recent developments between Damascus and the SDF are expected, in the short and medium terms, to produce a number of implications that can be categorised into three main levels. On the domestic level, the military achievements of the Syrian government at the expense of the SDF have generated renewed popular momentum, similar to that experienced when the government led military operations to overthrow the Assad regime. These achievements followed a period of increasing criticism of the government, particularly from Arab tribal communities, which accused it of excessive leniency in negotiations with the SDF at the expense of Arab populations living under SDF control. However, following the government's takeover of Raqqah and Deir Az Zor, security and military recruitment centres recorded a significant increase in enlistment from local populations, reflecting growing public confidence in state institutions. After demonstrating its ability to break the SDF's intransigence and significantly undermine the project of "independent self-administration" through a combined political and military approach, expectations regarding the establishment of autonomous regions, previously advocated by Alawite and Druze actors linked to religious authorities such as Ghazal Ghazal and Hikmat al-Hijri, who participated in the SDF-sponsored Components Conference in August 2025, have likely diminished. Military operations against the SDF generated heightened tensions within certain Syrian Kurdish circles, particularly due to SDF propaganda portraying the operations as collective attacks on Kurds. In response, the Syrian government sought to de-escalate tensions and limit the SDF's

ability to exploit them by issuing Decree No. 13 of 2026, which recognised the cultural and civil rights of the Kurdish component in Syria. This decree contributed to a more positive atmosphere among segments of Kurdish political forces and civil society, which interpreted it, along with government measures facilitating the return of displaced Kurds to areas they had left nearly eight years earlier, such as Afrin, as evidence of the government's seriousness in rebuilding the Syrian state on inclusive foundations. (4) In parallel, the government worked to enhance public reassurance by demonstrating concern for humanitarian consequences during its military operations. It opened safe corridors for civilians to evacuate conflict zones and provided shelter for displaced populations, as seen in the accommodation of residents from Ashrafieh and Sheikh Maqsoud in shelters in the Afrin area, followed by their facilitated return after the conclusion of operations. This approach conveyed an image of ongoing institutional development within the military and security apparatuses, marked by stronger central control and a reduction in violations during operations. This stands in contrast to the situation in Suwayda Governorate in mid-2025, where violations occurred following the entry of newly integrated factions and irregular tribal forces. (5) On the regional level, the SDF possesses regional extensions, given that the People's Protection Units (YPG), the dominant Kurdish component within the SDF, maintains ideological and political ties with Kurdish parties in neighbouring countries, particularly Iraq and Turkey. This regional dimension is further reinforced by the fact that many of the unit's leaders are originally affiliated with the Kurdistan Workers' Party (PKK). These links became evident following the outbreak of confrontations with the Syrian government, as the Kurdistan Democratic Party (KDP), which governs the Kurdistan Region of Iraq, intervened to sponsor mediation efforts. In parallel, both the PKK and the Patriotic Union of Kurdistan (PUK) encouraged their affiliates to fight alongside the YPG, while a delegation from Turkey's Peoples' Equality and Democracy Party (DEM Party) visited Syria. (6) The YPG's loss of oil and gas revenues, previously generated from sales either to Syria or to entities within the Kurdistan Region of Iraq, has reduced its capacity to finance the PKK, which had benefited from a portion of these funds. Moreover, the Syrian government's control over much of the Iraqi border has disrupted communication between the YPG and PKK strongholds in the Sinjar region, weakening the party's position and limiting the room for manoeuvre of leaders opposed to a political settlement led by the imprisoned PKK leader Abdullah Öcalan. These developments have expanded regional involvement, particularly Turkey's, due to concerns over border security. This coincides with repeated attempts by PKK-linked actors to link the fate of Turkey's domestic peace process, initiated in early 2025, to developments in northern and eastern Syria, using the SDF issue as leverage against Ankara. Additionally, the Kurdistan Regional Government (KRG) became involved in the Syrian issue by leveraging its relations with the United States and the Syrian government's openness to mediation by a Kurdish party not affiliated with the PKK's hardline movement. This enabled Erbil to sponsor mediation between Damascus and the SDF and to host talks involving Barrack and SDF commander Mazloum Abdi, culminating in an 18 January 2026 agreement that included a ceasefire and provisions outlining mechanisms for SDF integration into the Syrian state. Moreover, the deployment of Syrian government forces to the Iraqi border appears to have influenced, to some extent, the Iran-backed Iraqi Coordination Framework's decision to nominate Nouri al-Maliki for premiership as a "hawkish" option. This reflects concerns among Iranian and Iraqi Shiite actors over the shifting balance of influence amid accelerating regional changes, including the consolidation of Syrian government control under an Islamist-oriented leadership aligned with a Turkish-Arab axis and the strengthening of ties with the Trump administration. These concerns are further heightened by the potential impact of such

changes on Iraq's internal dynamics, particularly among Sunni political and tribal forces recently organised within the National Political Council. It is also likely that the erosion of the SDF and its loss of US political cover will diminish Israel's interest in investing in the group, especially following months of indirect signalling and the SDF's overt appeals for Israeli support. On the international level, international repercussions quickly followed developments in northeastern Syria, most notably a significant decline in US support for the SDF alongside clear indications of growing confidence in the Syrian government. This shift is attributable to the SDF's conduct during negotiations, its failure to implement US-brokered integration agreements, and its reduced commitment to securing detention facilities holding IS fighters. US forces have already begun transferring IS detainees to Iraq, amid reports that Washington is considering a full military withdrawal from Syria. Consequently, the United States may limit its role to security coordination with the Syrian government through advisers, rather than maintaining a direct military presence. (7) The Syrian government's control over most of the country, except for a small enclave in the Aleppo countryside and a narrow strip in Hasakah, has also prompted Russia to reassess the viability of maintaining its base in Qamishli under SDF control. The transfer of personnel from that base to Khmeimim Air Base, under government control, has reportedly begun. Third: The Future of the SDF Issue and Its Impact on State Reconstruction Based on current internal and external indicators, it is no longer feasible for the SDF to continue operating under its previous exceptional status within the Syrian state. The group has lost extensive territory and international legitimacy as a counterterrorism actor, and cannot indefinitely rely on cross-border Kurdish support, as such ties also invite increased political, security and military backing for the Syrian government from regional and international actors concerned about the activities of these parties. The international community broadly supports the integration of the SDF into the Syrian state, including countries that maintain relatively positive relations with the group, such as France, which has recently emphasised the necessity of Kurdish integration within Syria. Accordingly, the SDF appears to face a decisive juncture: integration into the Syrian state under an acceptable formula for all parties, whether through negotiation or following further military pressure that would compel concessions and the abandonment of demands for an ethnically based self-administration or decentralisation. The government is likely to continue pursuing an inclusive approach that recognises the particularities of Syria's components, as demonstrated by Decree No. 13. This may include allowing Kurdish participation in local governance in areas where they constitute a demographic majority and entrusting security responsibilities to Kurdish personnel, provided this occurs under the authority of the central state and does not result in independent administrative or security structures. The mechanism employed by the government in addressing the issue of the SDF, i.e. allowing local participation while maintaining central authority, is likely to be replicated as a model for resolving other outstanding issues, such as the situation in the Suwayda governorate. In this sense, the SDF case may establish a framework for decentralised administrative governance that accommodates local participation without undermining state unity, thereby enhancing domestic and international confidence in the government's capacity to manage the country. This approach is reinforced by the government's demonstrated reluctance to engage in direct confrontation with Kurdish communities, its emphasis on civilian protection, and its efforts to evacuate populations and open humanitarian corridors prior to military operations. Conclusion Throughout months of negotiations, the Syrian government demonstrated a degree of flexibility aligned with internationally mediated political solutions, subsequently reinforcing this approach through disciplined conduct during military operations in Aleppo and humanitarian assistance to displaced Kurds from Ashrafieh and Sheikh

Maqsoud. This contributed to projecting an image of a government capable of managing a diverse society. Conversely, the broad participation of Arab tribes in the uprising against the SDF in Raqqqa and Deir az Zor highlighted widespread dissatisfaction with the group's governance of multi-ethnic areas. The confrontations also exposed SDF involvement in abuses against Arab populations, extrajudicial killings of former detainees, and the detention of minors with no links to IS. These factors influenced the US position and undermined confidence in the viability of continued support for the SDF outside the framework of the Syrian state. Although the YPG retains limited territorial control, it has effectively lost the broader SDF umbrella through which it portrayed itself as a multi-component force. This has reinforced the ethnic dimension of the YPG's approach, particularly as the SDF has increasingly relied on PKK support, including the deployment of fighters from Iraq. As a result, the YPG has effectively confirmed its association with an organisation listed internationally as "terrorist" after years of denial. Finally, recent developments underscore the consensus among influential international actors on preserving Syrian territorial integrity, regardless of the administrative mechanisms ultimately adopted. The successful integration of the Kurdish component into the Syrian state could pave the way for addressing remaining unresolved issues, including that of the Suwayda Governorate. - Mounir Rabie, "العمليات العسكرية في رقة ودرع الزور: ما وراء المشهد قبل وبعد اتفاق الشراة-عبدي" [Behind the scenes before and after the al-Sharaa–Abdi agreement and its collapse]", Al Modon, 20 January 2026, <https://h7.cl/1iwPG> (accessed 25 January 2026). - "العمليات العسكرية في رقة ودرع الزور: ما وراء المشهد قبل وبعد اتفاق الشراة-عبدي" [Syrian Interior Ministry spokesperson: The tribal uprising accelerated the liberation process in Raqqqa and Deir Az Zor]", Al Ikhbariah, 20 January 2026, <https://h7.cl/1iwY9> (accessed 25 January 2026). - Laith Al-Jnaidi, "العمليات العسكرية في رقة ودرع الزور: ما وراء المشهد قبل وبعد اتفاق الشراة-عبدي" [Washington: The SDF's mission is over and the Syrian government is ready to take on security]", Anadolu Agency, 20 January 2026, <https://h7.cl/1nx44> (accessed 25 January 2026). - "العمليات العسكرية في رقة ودرع الزور: ما وراء المشهد قبل وبعد اتفاق الشراة-عبدي" [Kurdish National Council: The al-Shara Decree is a cornerstone for building a democratic, decentralised Syria and ending decades of injustices]", Kurdistan 24, 18 January 2026, <https://h7.cl/1ix4C> (accessed 26 January 2026). - "العمليات العسكرية في رقة ودرع الزور: ما وراء المشهد قبل وبعد اتفاق الشراة-عبدي" [Last families return to Ashrafieh and Sheikh Maqsoud following the closure of the final shelter in Aleppo]", Syrian Arab News Agency (SANA), 14 January 2026, <https://h7.cl/1nx6O> (accessed 26 January 2026). - "العمليات العسكرية في رقة ودرع الزور: ما وراء المشهد قبل وبعد اتفاق الشراة-عبدي" [Arrival of PKK members in Hasakah to support the SDF]", Al Khabour, 25 January 2026, <https://h7.cl/1nx7S> (accessed 26 January 2026). - "العمليات العسكرية في رقة ودرع الزور: ما وراء المشهد قبل وبعد اتفاق الشراة-عبدي" [Washington considers full military withdrawal from Syria following the collapse of the SDF], Al Jazeera, 23 January 2026, <https://h7.cl/1nx9Q> (accessed 26 January 2026).